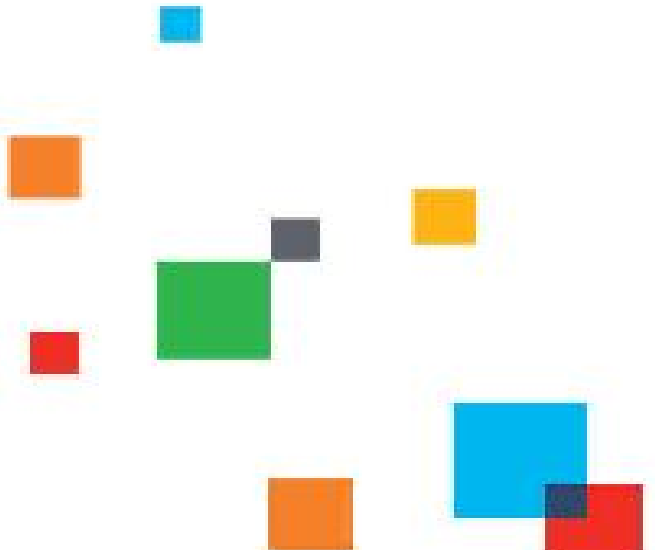


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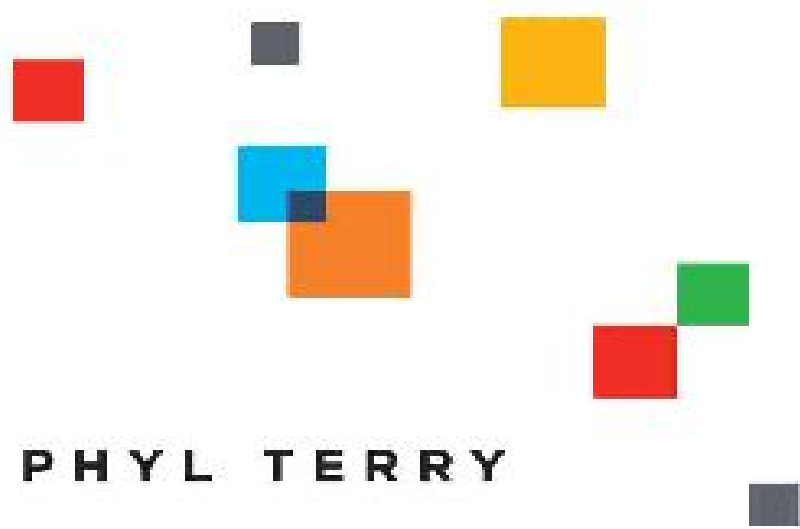
*"If you're even thinking about
a job search, start here."*

—Marty Cagan, Silicon Valley Product Group

NEVER SEARCH ALONE

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THE JOB SEEKER'S PLAYBOOK

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PHYL TERRY

Praise for

NEVER
SEARCH
ALONE

“Finally, Phyl has taken all the advice that has helped me and so many others over the years and put it in writing. His book is as creative, insightful, and thoughtful as his professional advice. I recommend, without reservation, that this be your first step in your next job search!”

— **Charlie Herrin**, President, Technology, Product and Experience, Comcast

“*Never Search Alone* was an incredibly timely and invaluable read for me at a critical point in my career. This book is a fascinating departure from job search resources that center “the job” as the ultimate gain from the search process. In providing highly actionable tactics for taking control of your career, Phyl transformed my perspective on the process of landing a new role from something stress-filled and tedious, to a career-affirming journey of in-depth self-discovery. While jobs may come and go, Phyl effectively teaches the reader how to cultivate and nurture something of infinite value — a community of supporters who will advocate and advise you throughout the duration of your working life. I strongly believe this unique approach will lead job seekers not only to the role of a lifetime, but toward a career legacy marked by deep impact, rich relationships, and meaningful interpersonal connections.”

— **Yetunde O. Duro-Emanuel**, Venture Partner at Republic, Product Manager at Everly Health

“Phyl’s book was so relevant for me, it felt like I was reading a thriller — I couldn’t put it down. Every chapter has nuggets of wisdom and gave me a playbook that supported me through my job search. I’ve recommended this book to countless friends and former colleagues, and it’s my first gift to anyone

who has been laid off. Don't search alone — use Phyl's book! You will get an amazing toolkit to find the right job for you now and set yourself up well for the future."

— **Priya Mathew Badger**, Principal Product Manager, GoPuff

"*Never Search Alone* completely revolutionized my preconceived notions of the job-search process. The lessons of patience and self-advocacy helped me land my first full-time role out of undergrad — my dream job — and I have no doubt I'll revisit this book again and again throughout my career."

— **Maslyn P.**, University of Virginia Class of 2022

"This groundbreaking book is required reading for every job seeker. Surprising, practical, and full of examples informed by Phyl's career working with thousands of executives, this book shows readers how to build a team to land a great job."

— **Amy Edmondson**, Novartis Professor of Leadership and Management,
Harvard Business School

"If you are like me, then you'll be sorry you didn't read this book during your last job search. Make sure you read it for your *next* one."

— **Craig Hopkins**, CIO, City of San Antonio

"The job search can be really lonely, but Phyl teaches us how to build a village of support as a way to find roles we really love."

— **Linda Jiang**, Designer, Creatable World (first gender-inclusive doll), Mattel

"Phyl offers an actionable 'how-to' playbook for not just landing a job (or promotion), but making the right move and getting the resources you need to succeed. You'll never think about promotions or job searching the same!"

— **Jason Jedlinski**, SVP Product Management, *Wall Street Journal*

"*Never Search Alone* provides a simple yet powerful approach for anyone working through a career change or their next role. It certainly inspired and guided me."

— **Karen Brewer**, Chief Marketing Officer & EVP, fabric

“*Never Search Alone* is a practical, thoughtful guide to finding your dream job.”

— **Kerry Cooper**, Board of Directors PG&E, UpStart

“Whether you want a bigger job, more money, more time with family, or a career switch, read this book. Execute the advice. You will be *far* better off for it.”

— **Michael Newton**, VP of Product, Nike

“*Never Search Alone* is an invaluable resource — Phyl channels experience helping thousands of job seekers into one of the most useful guides I’ve seen on the subject. I benefited from this book, and I know you will too.”

— **David Rabkin**, EVP, Head of Small Business Card, Capital One

“*Never Search Alone* was instrumental in helping me find the right job for moving my career forward. Phyl Terry’s instructions on effective negotiation (beyond just salary), evaluating cultural fit, and several other tips were inspiring. But the real game-changer for me came from his exploration of how and why to establish a strong community of fellow job-seekers. For anyone looking for a new job (or promotion), this book is the right place to start.”

— **Corleen Heidgerken**, Director of Product, Glassdoor

“*Never Search Alone* helped me get an internal promotion by supporting me through my hesitations, guiding and facilitating alignment conversations, and improving my confidence and preparation throughout the process — from outlining my job mission, to negotiating salary and resources. I will return to this book again and again *throughout* my career.”

— **Shaelyn Clements**, VP of Customer Experience, Arc XP, *Washington Post*

“Surprisingly, 99% of people (including me) get job searching wrong. This incredibly insightful book will open your eyes to the simple, powerful, game-changing *right* way to not just finding a job but to managing your whole career.”

— **Victor Cho**, CEO, Evite

“This is such an important book for this ‘Great Resignation’ moment when people are seeking more purposeful lives. Phyl’s *Never Search Alone* gives job seekers the courage, hope, and practical advice to find better roles with more pay and with a little more joy and meaning.”

— **Chip Conley**, *New York Times* Bestselling Author; Founder, Modern Elder Academy

“While I have worked in the talent and people space for my entire career, I had never thought to ask for help during my own career searches. Phyl’s book, *Never Search Alone*, changed my approach and helped me land some great jobs. I recommend this book to *every* job seeker out there.”

— **KC Jorgensen**, Chief People Officer, StyleSeat

“*Never Search Alone* is like the best friend who will tell you the hard truth when you need to hear it. It helped me realize that I had not been thoughtful about my career choices in the past, and it empowered me to be choosy and thoughtful about my next move. Armed with the tools from Phyl’s book and a Job Search Council to support me along the way, I ended up finding a job that fits my strengths, challenges me in the right ways, and removes the things I had hated most about previous jobs. Oh yeah — and it pays much better!”

— **Lily Inman Wilson**, Director of Strategic Initiatives, Angi

“Everyone asks me why I rave about this book. I tell them it’s like AA for product leaders. It helps you do the impossible: find your dream job (or promotion).”

— **Seth Roe**, SVP, Product, MyFitnessPal

“*Never Search Alone* has helped me with every phase of the job searching process from the job profile exercise and homing in on what I was looking for to practical advice on interviewing and salary negotiations. But most importantly, joining a Job Search Council, as is recommended in the book, has

connected me with some amazing women in my profession, and we continue to support and learn from each other in our new jobs.”

— **Deena Minwalla**, Director of Product, KQED

“This book is rooted in real practical lessons Phyl has been teaching for years. More importantly, the advice herein has doubled salaries, taken people out of the misery of dead-end jobs, and given people hope about finding a better career. Don’t go into any job search alone. Buy this book and advance your career.”

— **Troy Anderson**, Chief Product and Technology Officer, Schlesinger Group

“*Never Search Alone* is an insightful, easy to follow, must-read guide for anyone searching for their next *and* best job.”

— **Michael Blank**, SVP Player Network, Electronic Arts

“Looking for a promotion or new job *inside* your current company? Then read this book. *Never Search Alone* helped me identify what is important in my current career and uncover opportunities I didn’t even know were possible. Amazing.”

— **Josh Wiley**, Director, Wine & Spirits Sales, Constellation Brands

“Upon reading this book, you’ll shake your head at what you were doing — romanticizing job postings and glossing up resumes for robots, instead of purposefully executing on a real career strategy of happiness and reward. Phyl has his finger on the pulse of what it takes to have a you-to-opportunity fit in a more connected world.”

— **Bill Holman**, Director of Customer Experience, University of Phoenix

“*Never Search Alone* is a modern, pragmatic, relatable, and actionable guide to taking your career to the next level. It goes beyond explaining how to get hired; it also teaches you to identify the role — and the employer — that’s right for your own unique situation. Following Phyl’s advice will accelerate your career, no matter what stage you’re at today.”

— **Agata Celmerowski**, Founder, Velocity by Design

“*Never Search Alone* is incredible. It really spoke to me and addressed the hesitation I’ve had searching alone. Phyl has woven his trademark kindness, empathy, and intuitiveness into a clear, practical blueprint that leverages the magical ingredient of community support at its core. Frankly, the message is much bigger than the book.”

— **Abigail Muraskin**, Job Seeker and former Head of Strategy and Digital Business Development at Associated Press

“As relevant to me as for the people I mentor and manage, *Never Search Alone* provides practical step-by-step career advice. Highly recommended for anyone, especially those not *yet* searching.”

— **Jeff Kupietzky**, CEO, Jeeng

“Phyl’s motto ‘never search alone’ is a gift to all. The members of my Job Search Council (one of Phyl’s key recommendations) were a godsend in helping me go through the ups and downs of the job search. We were one another’s support whether we needed quick feedback, to practice a presentation, prepare for an interview, or negotiate an offer. We held ourselves accountable and helped one another get unstuck, even giving me confidence to say no to opportunities that weren’t the right fit. All this goodness is embodied in Phyl’s book. Gift someone the gold: ensure no one searches alone.

— **Paige Nesis**, Chief of Staff to the President, Moody’s Investors Service

“Following the steps in *Never Search Alone* led to a better outcome in my job search as well as more confidence and less anxiety as I went through it. The time I spent up front to hone my story, get feedback from prior managers and from my Job Search Council, made me more able to articulate my unique value and the kind of role I was looking for. As a result, the hardest part ended up deciding between two interesting job offers. I ended up taking the somewhat riskier job offer because it felt more aligned to my career goals and desire for adventure. I am now six months into that job, and am loving it. I will buy this book for anyone I know going through a job search. It is a must-read.”

— **Kimarie Matthews**, EVP Customer Engagement, Bank of Hawaii

“Phyl has taught me the incredible power of asking for help and now his book, *Never Search Alone*, provides readers a practical roadmap for charting their future.”

— **Loren Mayor**, COO, World Wildlife Fund

“*Never Search Alone* provides practical step-by-step instructions for building a Job Search Council that is like your best friend when dating — they will tell you how to go for the “right one” AND make sure you are set up to succeed when you get there. Phyl offers real-world examples of how this method has worked time and again. It’s proven, approachable, and will surely become a go-to manual for professionals everywhere.”

— **Ashley Moran**, Executive Director of Experience Design, Comcast

“*Never Search Alone* is a groundbreaking book that offers a powerful and unconventional approach to finding a great job. Further, it’ll not only help you find the best new job, but will strengthen and expand your network in a powerful way.”

— **John Seebeck**, Vice President and GM, Digital, CDW

“Do you want clarity on your career path *and* amazing jobs with higher pay and increased satisfaction? Then follow this book’s step-by-step approach. It will change your life.”

— **Andy Cerio**, VP Product, Target

“Phyl’s approach not only made it possible for me to get this great job, but it set me up to hit the ground running. This book is a *must* read.”

— **Justin Cinicolo**, VP Game Design, Dapper Labs

“Lots of wisdom here and sound advice for any job seeker.”

— **Rob Schmuts**, General Partner, Blockchange Ventures

“For most of my early career, being part of a job search felt like being swept away in a river — getting caught up in the current, ping-ponging downstream until I just “landed.” Enter the remarkable Phyl Terry. I have been lucky to

have Phyl's mentorship and coaching as I've navigated recent career moves. Having Phyl's framework and community-driven expertise applied to a job search will completely shift the way you think about job opportunities. What is the "right" fit? How can you find that sweet spot where your skills are being utilized and your goals are being fulfilled? Phyl's techniques can be used in the earliest part of a career (honestly, the sooner the better) and as someone navigating a seasoned career. It is time to reimagine how we invest in this critical process and connect job searching to a proven methodology. It is time to *not* go it alone. And it is time to feel good once you land."

— **Debbie Kristofferson**, VP Consumer Marketing, Included Health

"This book is required reading — a 10 out of 10. The logic, the stories, the steps provide everything needed to find and negotiate a great promotion or new job!"

— **Aaron Cooper**, CEO, Groupon

"For years now, Phyl's advice has helped me grow my career. That's why I say that *anyone* looking to get promoted or find a new job needs to buy, read, and put this book into practice!"

— **Peter DeFrancesco**, SVP, Head of Personal Investing, John Hancock

"Follow this book step-by-step, and it will transform your job search and your career."

— **Lance Willett**, Chief Product and Technology Officer, Tumblr

"This is one of the *best* books on the job search. It's practical, inspiring, fun to read — and helped me tremendously. I recommend it to anyone looking for their next job (or promotion)."

— **Sarah Kasten**, Chief People Officer, Elation Health

"Engaging and insightful, *Never Search Alone* is a helpful, practical guide for anyone looking for their next job (or promotion)."

— **Andy Chu**, SVP Product and Technology Incubation, Providence

“I owe a huge debt of gratitude to this book and to its core recommendation to set up a Job Search Council — that led directly to a great job that I’m loving. The groundbreaking methods of this book will soon be known as best practices for anyone looking to truly evolve their professional life!”

— **Rob Anderson**, VP Product Experience, Mayvenn

“*Never Search Alone* has a ton of tools and resources that helped me every step of the way and ultimately led to a new role that I am incredibly excited about. If you are starting a job search, this book is a must have.”

— **Cathleen Swallow**, Director of Product Development, Well Health, Inc.

“This book is an excellent guide to help you think about your career objectives, learn how to ask for help, and get what you need for your own personal growth and success.”

— **Kathy Marryat**, Business Coach and Strategic Leader, 20+ year American Express executive

“I have worked with Phyl for more than 15 years. I have seen him consistently provide thoughtful, substantive, and truly pragmatic help to many people in their quests to further their careers. This book is an incredibly valuable collection of all that expertise and advice in one place. I strongly recommend it.”

— **Martin Murrell**, Senior Managing Director, Silicon Valley Bank

“Job searchers — whether in business, academia, government, or non-profit — who read Phyl’s book will learn to leverage the wisdom of others and thus handle better the tricky but necessary work of finding a new job.”

— **Paul Cartledge**, A.G. Leventis Professor of Greek Culture Emeritus, University of Cambridge

“It’s brilliantly simple, and it works! Apply this proven playbook that consistently delivers world-class products to your own job search (or internal promotion).”

— **Darren Brelesky**, SVP Product, CBS Sports

“Heartfelt and uplifting are not usually the first words that come to mind for a jobseeker’s guide, but they are for this one. Well-structured, with principles and ideas that stem from Phyl’s expertise in coaching leaders, this book helps not just job seekers but those looking to grow *in* their jobs. I often come back to Phyl’s wise insights to guide my relationships with colleagues, students, and friends. A joy to read!”

— **Johanna Bokedal**, Religious Studies Lecturer, NLA University College
(Norway)

“Wish you had a team of advisors to help with your next big career move? Phyl’s book offers actionable guidance to deliver your career dreams!”

— **Nicole Cox**, VP of Marketing, 1800Contacts

“*Never Search Alone* is the book you’ll wish you’d read years ago. With wise and empathetic advice for anyone looking to figure out their next move (and aren’t we all?), Phyl’s book provides hard-won lessons from his massive network of successful executives. If you’re part of the Great Resignation or just looking to get ahead, get this book now.”

— **Bruce Upbin**, VP Policy & Communications, Zest AI; former Managing Editor, Forbes

“*Never Search Alone* helps you identify your passions, interests and, most importantly, your value. It’s the career-growth mentor that you didn’t know you were missing!”

— **Emily Teter**, Product Manager, CDW

“I’ve learned how asking for help and building a village of support can be a way of life, and that has changed everything for me — including finding great jobs *and* making me happier.”

— **Heather Fisher-O’Neill**, Writer, Poet, Editor, Adjunct Professor

“This book provides advice you won’t find elsewhere — how to truly fortify your job search (or life change) with your own panel of experts, build confidence and shape your plan, and achieve results better than you’d have

sought on your own. Phyl's advocacy of the "asking for help" model has done wonders in my own career — widening my aperture with every new pursuit!"

— **Summer Koide**, Senior Director, Hybrid Work, Target

"*Never Search Alone* not only gives you the insight and plan needed to land your dream job, but also the tools to make sure you're going to be a success in that role. Phyl has written a book filled with extraordinary job search wisdom that you will no doubt pass on to your family and friends."

— **Mike Stacy**, CEO, ID90 Travel

"*Never Search Alone* challenges conventional thinking on how to take the next step in your career. Phyl's thoughtful approach provides the framework and tools to find the job of your dreams."

— **Craig Sauerwalt**, Vice President, T. Rowe Price

"Jam-packed with useful tools, innovative exercises, and a wealth of wisdom, this book will not only change the way you search for your next job, but it will also completely transform your professional journey!"

— **Sara Meis**, Director of Client Engagement, Goosman Law Firm

"A refreshing and insightful perspective on approaching and succeeding in the modern-day job search. Forming a Job Search Council (JSC) was a game-changer, and Phyl's advice on negotiating paved the way for an offer that recognized my full potential while positioning me for success in my new role."

— **Mike Parker**, SVP Transportation and Logistics, Wave6; 17-year veteran of Union Pacific Railroad

"*Never Search Alone* is a great guide for how to tap into the power of community to navigate your career."

— **Bonnie Lai**, General Manager, Lumere

"This book will help you build a job search plan, ask for help to make that plan even better, *and* help others along the way. It's a thoughtful, structured, and

human-centered approach to searching for a new job that I have found invaluable!”

— **Tabitha Dunn**, Chief Customer Officer, Ericsson

“A must-read for those who are hardwired to do things on their own, Phyl’s book provides a practical step-by-step plan to get the best results out of your next job search!”

— **Andy Wadhwa**, VP Product, Freedom Financial Network

“An absolute joy to read, this book provides practical examples and resources that will teach you how to ask for help to develop your academic or business career.

— **Jessica Jane Nocella**, Postdoctoral Fellow in Linguistics, University of Modena and Reggio Emilia (Italy)

“The world will help you find your dream job when you harness the ideas and strategies in this playbook.”

— **James Patterson**, CEO Dreamteams

“Never Search Alone is a brilliant collection of Phyl’s time-tested best practices to figure out who you want to be professionally, get a great job, set you up for success in a new role, and get the critical emotional support needed for this journey.”

— **Peter Nush**, Vice President, Product Management, Comcast Cable

“Phyl’s been a constant real-world innovator in executive peer councils since I first met him more than 20 years ago, and now he’s brought that same thought leadership to finding and landing your perfect next job. This book is a must-read for anyone who ever plans to have a ‘next job.’”

— **Lou Weiss**, CEO, SubMachinery

“Phyl Terry is an amazing individual and has put years of knowledge into one book. I have personally benefited from Phyl’s coaching and the exercises he lays out so well for readers to digest and act on to achieve their career goals.”

— **Bill Staikos**, SVP — Industry Solutions, Medallia

“Phyl’s philosophy and practical advice have helped me throughout my career, from small steps to big leaps, and I continue to benefit enormously from his mission to help others succeed.”

— **Jason Randall**, President and CEO, AppFolio Inc.

“*Never Search Alone* transforms the job-search process from a confusing and individual effort into one that’s clear and community-based. The creative and well-founded approach will really open your eyes. Follow the guidance here to enjoy the search process *and* get a better outcome!”

— **Morgan Hays**, Construction Solutions, Autodesk

“This is a wonderful book not only in helping you find and succeed in your next job search, but also in turning yourself into a humble and a happy person.”

— **Tomoya Nakamura**, President, GLOBIS USA

“Anyone who wants to maximize their chances of landing their next best job should read this book — now. It’s helped me, and I know it will help you.”

— **Isabelle Meyer Stapf**, SVP, Product, Well Health

“*Never Search Alone* gives readers the tools to slow down and take deliberate actions. As a high school student looking forward to securing a summer internship, I find the strategies helpful for my search!”

— **McKenzie W.**, Phillips Academy Andover ’24

“Phyl has given us a gift that leverages his super-powers as a human being. He understands that mutual respect, reciprocity, love, and kindness are the characteristics that are the hallmarks of the future world. In this case the gift is this book that I plan on recommending for everyone considering a new job whose path I cross. This tool is like a secret unlock that will guide those using it to a seemingly unfair advantage in the job marketplace.”

— **Pedraum Pardehpoosh**, Director of Product, Airbnb

“My career advice to anyone looking for a job is simple: buy Phyl’s book. It’s full of practical advice and real world 21st-century examples that will help anyone find a great job in this digital economy.”

— **Mandy Ginsberg**, Board Member Uber and ThredUp, former CEO Match Group

“When I was thinking of taking what I had learned after several years at Amazon and accepting a great opportunity at a start-up, I turned to Phyl and his great advice, which helped me think about what I love to do in my work and put the start-up opportunity in the right perspective. If you are thinking of next steps in your career, buy this book!”

— **Elvis Dieguez**, Chief Technology Officer, unybrands

“Looking for a job is often a lonely and tortuous affair. But it doesn’t have to be. Phyl Terry teaches you how to build a support council that can guide you every step of the way — helping you assess the right roles, preparing for interviews, and negotiating an offer. Read this book, and you’ll never face the job-search process alone again.”

— **Teresa Torres**, Author, *Continuous Discovery Habits*

NEVER SEARCH ALONE

The Job Seeker's Playbook

PHYL TERRY

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Never Search Alone: The Job Seeker's Playbook

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For information about this title or to order other books and/or electronic media, contact the publisher:

Collaborative Gain, Inc.
1350 Avenue of the Americas, 2nd Floor
New York, NY 10019
<https://collaborativegain.com/contact/>

ISBNs:

979-8-9854090-1-7 (hardcover)
979-8-9854090-0-0 (softcover)
979-8-9854090-2-4 (eBook)

Cover design by Charlee Riggio and Erica Johnson

With love and thanks to Chic



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FOREWORD

by Marty Cagan

I've spent my career helping people develop into strong members of product teams and strong product leaders.

I've often explained to new managers that their product is no longer **their product**. **Their product** is now **their people**.

Which is to say that I take developing the skills and abilities of people very seriously.

Probably because of that, many people come to me for career advice.

I know firsthand the power of a person finding the right role at a good company, where they can contribute meaningfully, continue to grow in their career, and reach their full potential.

Sadly, because so many people are in jobs that they don't love, they find themselves working on something that doesn't matter, for someone who does not care about them or their career.

As I write this, a record number of people have decided they have had enough, and that it's time to take charge of their professional life.

But how best to do this?

There has been a great deal published, by me and many others, on how companies and hiring managers can do a better job of recruiting, staffing, and coaching.

But what's always been missing is a serious treatment of the job-search process from the perspective of the person searching for the job.

Obviously, people know how to search a job site and fill out an application online. But is that the best way to find the right fit for your unique talents and career goals?

Not even close.

And when most people do get an offer and want to negotiate a fair compensation package, they are completely unprepared to represent their interests.

The company has a whole staff of lawyers and compensation specialists looking out for their interests. Who do you have looking out for yours?

And even beyond finding a good job, will you be set up to succeed in your new position? Will you receive the training, coaching, and resources you will need?

The time to figure this out is not after you start, when you've lost most of your leverage. It should be a key part of the job-search process.

Hopefully, now you have a better sense of what I mean by most people being completely unprepared for the demands of the job-search process.

For more than 20 years, I've encouraged people who are serious about their career to meet Phyl Terry.

Yes, Phyl is one of the best-connected leaders in the industry.

Yes, Phyl is a genuine human being who truly cares about you personally and your career.

But what really sets Phyl apart is that he understands how to harness the power of community.

This book is all about scaling the magic that is Phyl.

I have seen Phyl and the techniques he advocates dramatically improve the career trajectories of countless people.

And not just people who are in mid-career, dissatisfied with their current job, and want to find better.

These techniques are at least as valuable for new college graduates looking for that all-important first professional job.

Or another very difficult but increasingly common situation: older employees who find themselves in need of a new job, yet encountering systemic ageism at every turn.

Which is to say, nearly everyone in the professional workforce can benefit from the techniques in this book.

And one more pro tip: it's a good idea to learn these techniques before you need them.

When you are able to find a job that you truly enjoy, that leverages your unique skills and talents, where you can receive the coaching necessary to continue to grow and develop to reach your potential, and where you can make a real contribution, you have meaningfully improved your life.

My hope is that this book will help countless people to improve their lives.

— **MARTY CAGAN**

Founder, Silicon Valley Product Group

December 2021



HOW I BUILT THIS BOOK

Before we begin, I'd like to share with you how I built this book — and I use the verb “build” because I treated this like a software-development project with English as my programming language.

As such, I did not write this alone. Instead, I did a lot of iterative testing.

In fact, the methodology in this book — Social Search — is based on coaching more than 2,000 job and promotion seekers over the last 20 years.

Then, five years ago, before I started to write this book, I conducted 200 in-depth interviews with college students, entry-level employees, mid-career leaders, CEOs, and Board members.

After that, as I began writing, I asked more than 200 job seekers to read and put into practice early versions of this book. Along the way, those readers provided more than 2,500 pieces of feedback, which I then used to iterate through more than 400 major and minor drafts.

As a result, this 401st draft represents lessons and input from thousands of job seekers, facing the same challenges and fears — and with the same hopes — as you.

It worked for them.

That's why I know *Never Search Alone* will work for you.

— PHYL

P.S. Visit PhylTerry.com for additional resources and support.



HOW TO READ THIS BOOK

Keep in mind that this job search playbook is like a cookbook.

You don't get the nutritional value from reading.

You get it from putting it into action.

With that in mind, here are a few tips on how to read *Never Search Alone* and act on my recommendations, depending on your situation:

1. If you just left or lost your job:

- Start with my “Checklist If You Just Left or Lost Your Job” (Free download on my author site: PhylTerry.com). Key lesson: Take a break. It's hard to lose or leave a job, even voluntarily. In addition to rest, I also recommend you get a therapist or coach, eat well, drink less (not more), exercise, and set up regular routines. I also give you some advice on how to navigate the painful geography of business friendships when you are out of work (short story: some friends help, others don't).
- Then, when you are ready to start your search, read the whole book and apply it to find the best job you can.

2. If you are interviewing or negotiating now:

- Read Chapter 12 on interviewing and, most importantly, create a Job Mission with OKRs — this is one of the top recommendations in the book and can set you up well for interviews.
- Then read Chapters 13 and 14 to learn to ask for all four legs of the negotiations stool: salary, budget, resources, and support.

3. If you have been invited to join a Job Search Council and want to learn more:

- Read Marty Cagan's Foreword, my Introduction, and then Chapter 1 to understand the benefits of Social Search, the five-step *modern* job search that I have developed over 20 years.
- Then read Chapters 2–3 to understand the mechanics of Job Search Councils (Step 1 of Social Search).
- Skim the rest of the book to get an idea for the whole Social Search process.
- Then read it chapter-by-chapter with your JSC as you go through the job search together.

4. If you are in a job and thinking about starting to look:

- Read/skim through the whole book, starting with Marty Cagan's Foreword.
- Focus on Chapter 8 closely, because, if you are still working and have not yet started looking, then it's critical you begin building relationships with recruiters. When a recruiter calls, answer. Get to know them. Introduce them to people in your network for jobs you are not interested in.

5. If you have been looking for a while and are getting frustrated and demoralized (and have not set up a JSC):

- Read the Foreword, Introduction, and Chapter 1 on the job search roller coaster.
- And, of course, read Chapters 2 and 3 so you can go start a Job Search Council as soon as possible. Your JSC will help convert your frustration into hope and set your search on a whole new trajectory.
- Then put special emphasis on the Listening Tour in Chapters 4–8 because, if you are having trouble getting a job, then there is likely something missing in your understanding of your Candidate-Market Fit.

6. If you are looking for a new job inside your company (or a promotion):

- Hack this book and apply it to your promotion.

- Set up a Job Search Council (JSC) with others also looking for new roles/promotions/raises inside their current companies.
- Pay close attention to Allison Mnookin's story in Chapter 4.



INTRODUCTION

This book, *Never Search Alone*, provides a powerful — and in the words of many early readers, a *groundbreaking* method for finding a new job (or getting a promotion).

Most job seekers start with working on their resume and *then* networking and interviewing.

Though this is the conventional approach, it's *not* the best approach.

Instead, if you want to find a good job (or promotion) faster — one that fits your best self *and* a key market need — want help negotiating more money, and want the support you'll need to succeed in that new job, then my one *main* recommendation is simple:

Never search *alone*.

I will tell you how to form a mutual support group — what I call a Job Search Council (JSC) — made up of peer job seekers who agree to search *together*. Don't worry: I will show you not only how to set up such a group, but also how to find and recruit fellow job seekers.

Then, together, you will use my five-step Social Search methodology focused on doing something almost no job seeker ever does: determining your “Candidate-Market Fit” — i.e., the intersection between your hopes, dreams, *and* market realities.

When looking for a new job, *you* — or, more specifically, your skills and expertise — are the “product” you are offering.

Just like companies need to understand customers to figure out their “product-market fit,” you, as a job seeker, need to understand the job market so you can figure out your *Candidate-Market Fit*.

If you skip this key step, then you can either spin your wheels or receive suboptimal offers.

Take DD, for example.

DD, an executive who had been a Chief Data Officer at a public company, left her job to find a Chief Technology Officer (CTO) role. She spent 12 months looking the old-fashioned way: update the resume, network, and then interview.

But this talented leader searched alone and received no offers.

By the end of the year, she was lonely and on her way to financial, and emotional, difficulty.

She then reached out to me and asked for help.

I told her to stop doing interviews for the moment and, instead, set up a JSC, and, with the support of 4–6 fellow job seekers, follow the Social Search process.

She took my advice and followed the five steps of Social Search, which are simple: 1) form a JSC; 2) conduct a Listening Tour 3) craft a Candidate-Market Fit; 4) *then* start networking and interviewing; 5) get help to negotiate offers.

After Step 2, DD quickly discovered why she was getting no offers. She had her Candidate-Market Fit all wrong. The market did not view her as a fit for traditional CTO roles.

She learned, however, something she did not know: she was a *perfect* match for the new trend of companies hiring CTOs with heavy data backgrounds. And given her work experience, she would be a great fit for midsize banks looking for just such a CTO.

By doing research to figure out her niche *before* jumping into networking and interviewing, she eventually ended up with *two* great offers within two months.

That’s the power of never searching alone.

This approach comes from working with thousands of job seekers, and from two key influences: 1) my decades of work helping companies understand their customers; and 2) my nearly lifelong association with building peer

councils; it turns out that bringing people together in mutual support groups like this is my family business.

Let me explain the second influence first.

My mother, “Chic” to her friends and family, started her first “peer” council in 1960 (for elementary school teachers). Learning from her, I started my first council in college for student leaders. Then, when I was getting my MBA at the Harvard Business School, I assisted McKinsey & Co. in setting up the Internet Business Forum for Internet CEOs.

Since that time, I have gone on to build councils for thousands of product and general management leaders from companies like Amazon, Apple, Airbnb, and Google, as well as many traditional companies, midsize and smaller high-growth startups, plus emerging leaders. I even turned this into a successful business: Collaborative Gain Councils, or what I’ll refer to in the book simply as “CG.” CG runs “Career Councils” designed to help leaders *in* jobs make a positive impact on their customers, companies, and careers.

And along the way, many CG members have lost or left their jobs, and I’ve helped thousands of them find new roles they love.

The complement to my expertise in building councils is my 15 years as CEO of a pioneering strategy and customer experience consultancy, Creative Good. My team and I ran more than 400 projects helping Internet and technology companies focus on their customers and build good product-market fit (i.e., designing a product that fits a real customer need). That work, with many of the same companies involved in our councils, was described in my first book, *Customers Included* (co-authored with my then-business partner), and deeply informed the development of Social Search.

The biggest challenge we faced in these projects was convincing companies to include their customers when building products and services. They wanted to skip this step and instead quickly shove products out the door.

Job seekers feel the same pressure to act quickly and, thus, make mistakes driven by multiple anxieties.

One job seeker, who I’ll talk about in Chapter 1, told me that she had three anxieties that made her want to skip my recommendations and “just” go find a job.

First, she was anxious about not making money (and this was true, despite having enough money to take her time to look for her next job).

Second, and this is key, not having a job meant she had a low sense of self-worth. As a result, her insecurities were running wild.

Finally, her third anxiety came from believing that she should be able to handle the job search on her own: she shouldn't have to ask for help.

Based on my experience working with thousands of job seekers, I can confidently say that these three anxieties plague nearly everyone.

As a result, many skip slowing down to think about what they want and what the market wants, and instead, immediately get busy to quell their anxieties. So, they begin networking, interviewing, and sending out resumes without a clear understanding of what they want or what the market wants. This is why the conventional approach is so popular: people want to relieve their anxieties.

There's a *better* way.

Social Search helps you find a *good* job fast, often faster than the conventional approach.

But it does require you to slow down at first, and that can trigger the anxieties noted above.

If you form a Job Search Council (JSC), however, your fellow job seekers will help you convert those insecurities and fears into hope, confidence, accountability, and motivation to find a *good* job.

This works because we are social creatures, and discovering we are not alone itself improves our emotional state and unleashes the power of what I call "mutually reinforcing activity," or "job seeker see, job seeker do," which I will explain in Chapter 1.

I'll say one more thing about JSCs. When you interview and negotiate with companies, you are often at a disadvantage. They have HR and recruiting talent, compensation specialists, attorneys, and others. But who do you have representing you? Most are alone. But you, I hope, will have a village of support behind you.

WHO IS THIS BOOK FOR?

Originally, I thought this book would be primarily for mid- and senior-level executives in digital product management looking for a promotion or a new role outside their company.

But then something interesting happened as I tested the book with the more than 200 readers who were given early drafts not only to read but to use in their job searches.

Public company CEOs thinking about their next jobs found it helpful.

College students in my Warren Buffett Reading Group (WBRG) program used it to help them find their first full-time role.¹

Career switchers who wanted to leave business and go into the nonprofit sector found this book helpful.

Chief People Officers, well-versed in recruiting talent, found the approach revolutionary for their own careers (and reverse-engineered it for their companies to use in recruiting others).

To my delight, people *in* jobs found it useful for getting promotions and navigating internal politics, including a seemingly random selection of folks, like early-career sales leaders, Chief Technology Officers, first-time university professors, and, of course, many, many product leaders at all levels.

As a result, Marty Cagan, founder of the Silicon Valley Product Group, and author of the Foreword for this book, strongly encouraged me to broaden the focus to reflect what I was learning from early readers about this book's product-market fit. He was right.

So, now the intended audience of *Never Search Alone* is broad.

Whether you are a college student, an experienced VP of Product, a CEO, Board of Directors candidate, a poetry professor, or, based on my beta test, almost anyone looking for a better job (or promotion inside your company), then this book will help.

I have one caveat, however: if you are still in a job but unhappy, first see if you can get help to change things so you are happier.

DON'T QUIT YET

If you are employed and thinking of leaving, I do *not* recommend that you start looking yet.

Despite (or because of) my decades of coaching leaders, I have a contrarian point of view on this topic.

I have come to believe that you should try asking for what you want before you start looking.

Too many people stew, don't ask, and then start looking for a new job (and sometimes end up in a worse situation at a new company).

Your boss likely doesn't know what you want (especially if you have not told them).

Make it easier on both of you.

Tell them.

If that doesn't work, then proceed with the five steps of Social Search.

THE FIVE STEPS OF SOCIAL SEARCH

If you have decided to look, or simply want to read this book to understand a better process for a future job search, then know that Social Search has five main steps around which this book is organized.

	Step 1 JSC	Step 2 Listening Tour	Step 3 Candidate- Market Fit	Step 4 Networking/ Interviewing	Step 5 Negotiate	Total Time
Full-time job seekers (i.e., those unemployed)	1-2 weeks	2-3 weeks	1-2 weeks	4-8 weeks	1-2 weeks	2+ mos
Part-time job seekers (i.e., those still employed)	2+ weeks	4+ weeks	2-3 weeks	4+ weeks	1-2 weeks	4+ mos

I recommend that you take these steps in order, though, as pictured above, this is not a so-called “waterfall” process, where each step is discrete. Your Job Search Council (Step 1) and your Listening Tour (Step 2) are constant and iterative throughout the whole process.

One more thing: If you have just left or lost your job, download my checklist for what to do *before* you begin the job search from my book website (see the “Tools and Templates” section at the end of this chapter).

Here are more details about the five steps of Social Search and the chapters they correspond to in the book.

Step 1: JSC (Chapters 1–3)

Duration: Setup: 1–2 weeks — perhaps, longer if you are still working; then regular meetings throughout

Your JSC is your mutual support group that will help you throughout the whole job search. One of the most important goals of the JSC is to give you the emotional support to keep looking for the right job (and then negotiate well). Every job seeker — whether they are looking for their first job or are an experienced CEO — needs a *community* of support.

Step 2: Listening Tour (Chapters 4–8)

Duration: Initial tour: 2–3 weeks — longer if you are still working; then regular listening and learning throughout

The Listening Tour is focused on doing market research on yourself (it is *not* networking for a job). This is a creative moment of transition — a ‘liminal’ phase where I’ll urge you to be open-minded and curious. This is one of the most radical suggestions, and the most difficult *emotionally*. Job seekers get anxious and believe the best way to deal with their fears is to get a job quickly. I’m going to urge you to slow down to get *better* results.

Note that the length of time your Listening Tour takes may be longer if you are looking while still working, or making a major career change — for example, if you are going from business to nonprofit field work.

I also recommend that college students form a JSC in their sophomore year and take the next two years (and summer internships) to see how their Candidate-Market Fit evolves as they discover what they want and don’t want.

Step 3: Candidate-Market Fit (Chapters 9–10)

Duration: 1–2 weeks — longer if you are still working

In Step 3, you create your Candidate-Market Fit statement (based on the research from Step 2) and then synchronize it with your LinkedIn profile and resume. The most challenging part of this step is creating a practical, clear, and focused statement. Whereas in the Listening Tour, I want you to be open-minded, curious, and explore various possibilities, now I want you to box yourself in with your Candidate-Market Fit. Many job seekers want to keep the door open. That’s fine to do while exploring possibilities, but not when you get ready to begin networking and interviewing. As I’ll explain in Chapter 9,

strategy is about making hard choices and tradeoffs, and no choice is more important in a job search than determining the cozy little box that I call your Candidate-Market Fit.

Step 4: Networking and Interviewing (Chapters 11–12)

Duration: 4–8 weeks

With your Candidate-Market Fit set, and with your LinkedIn profile and resume synchronized, you are now, at last, ready to move on to the activity that most job seekers begin with — i.e., networking and interviewing.

I'll ask you to prepare for interviews by diving into the strategy, financial strength, culture, and products of a potential hiring company, as well as examining the values, quality, and history of its leadership. This research is even more critical, and yet harder to do, with high-growth startups and other private companies.

Further, I'll ask you to create a Job Mission with OKRs (“objectives and key results”), which will help clarify alignment, impress the hiring manager, and set the stage to negotiate well. As such, this is one of the most important tools in the book.

Step 5: Negotiating (Chapters 13–14)

Duration: 1–2 weeks

Once you receive an offer, use the support of your JSC, and leverage your Job Mission with OKRs to help you negotiate compensation *and* the budget, resources, and support you'll need. There are four legs to the negotiations stool — it's not just about salary. This second point is critical: to succeed in your job, you need not only to be paid well, but to have the budget, resources, and support to execute on the Job Mission and OKRs you've agreed to. More people these days negotiate money. Almost no one negotiates these other three components.

The good news is research shows that, if you ask during negotiations, you will receive (83% of the time!).²

Finally, it may be obvious, but perhaps it's worth being clear. I call this whole process Social Search not because it will primarily happen over social media. It will not. It is social, however, because, at every step of the way, I will

ask you to build a community of support, as Marty Cagan alludes to in his Foreword, and as I will show you how to do throughout this book.

Let's now turn to Chapter 1 where I'll explain in more detail *why* you need a Job Search Council.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

- Read this book, and apply it.
- If you just left or lost your job, download the checklist on my book website for what to do first.
- Buy and read *The Manual: A Philosopher's Guide to Life*. It will take you about 90 minutes to read, and it will set you up well for the job search (see “Tools and Templates”, below).

TOOLS AND TEMPLATES

Checklist If You Just Left or Lost Your Job

(Available online at PhylTerry.com)

Key lesson: Take a break. You need at least a few days, a week, or even a month. I also go into suggestions on a few key items to do before you begin, including get a therapist or coach, establish a routine, exercise regularly, eat healthily, avoid “rebound” jobs (hint: like “rebound relationships,” they don’t last long), navigate business friendships, and set up your search “office.”

The Manual: A Philosopher's Guide to Life

I highly recommend that all job seekers read another short book at the beginning of their job search: *The Manual*. The book is a synopsis of Stoic thinking and will help you and your fellow job seekers let go of all that you do not control and focus on the few things you do. This helps manage the emotional challenges of looking for a job (I’ll go over that more in Chapter 1). It will also help you cultivate some objectivity around yourself and how the market sees you.

Three others books I recommend

If you like my book, you may also want to check out *Wisdom @Work* by Chip Conley, *Designing Your Life: How to Build a Well-Lived, Joyful Life* by Bill Burnett and Dave Evans, or a recent favorite of mine because it shows the joys and limits of reinvention, *Re-educated* by Lucy Kellaway, who in her mid-50s

left her job as a *Financial Times* journalist to become a public high school teacher.

STEP 1

Set Up a Job Search Council

	Step 1 JSC	Step 2 Listening Tour	Step 3 Candidate- Market Fit	Step 4 Networking/ Interviewing	Step 5 Negotiate	Total Time
Full-time job seekers (i.e., those unemployed)	1-2 weeks	2-3 weeks	1-2 weeks	4-8 weeks	1-2 weeks	2+ mos
Part-time job seekers (i.e., those still employed)	2+ weeks	4+ weeks	2-3 weeks	4+ weeks	1-2 weeks	4+ mos



CHAPTER 1

MANAGING THE JOB SEARCH ROLLER COASTER

The job search is a roller coaster.

And sadly, the downs are intense and longer than the ups because, in my experience, every single job seeker, whether CEO or college student, struggles with insecurity, fear, and anxiety.

Here's my key finding: the most important thing you need to control for during your search is neither the quality of your resume (or LinkedIn), nor your interviewing, networking, or negotiating skills.

All of that is important — and I'll give you great advice on how to do each of those things better — but your ultimate success hinges on something else: your emotional balance.

Sophia, for example, who followed the book's recommendations and landed a great job, struggled at the beginning of her job search.

Yet, in our debrief call, she said, "I can't believe how easy that was."

I laughed and reminded Sophia that was *not* how she had felt at the beginning.

She thought about it and, upon reflection, said:

True. My confidence was at an all-time low at the beginning of this search. My previous boss had constantly criticized me and undermined my work. Without the support of my JSC, I could never have rebuilt my confidence. And, without that, I don't think I would have performed well in the interviews or received the offer I just accepted. If I had somehow made it to an offer, I certainly would not have negotiated for more money, or for the resources I needed to succeed.

I start with Sophia's story because I want to validate for you that 1) yes, this is hard emotionally on everyone; and 2) what I'm recommending will allow you to manage your emotions and help you find a good job.

But you may not want to follow my recommendations at first.

Every electron in your body will just want you to push forward as quickly as possible.

I'm going to continuously urge you to resist that, and, instead, trust my most important time-tested recommendation: build a Job Search Council which can give you the emotional support to find the right job for you.

Before we continue, let me address a key skill that is fundamental to everything I'm recommending: the art of asking for help.

LEARNING TO ASK FOR HELP DURING THE JOB SEARCH

During your job search, I will encourage you to ask for help from your Job Search Council (JSC) members, from former colleagues, from your network, and from recruiters.

Asking for help will not only give you great insights and advice, but the act of asking for help builds community and trust, among other things.

In fact, this habit of asking for help is so powerful that I will even recommend you ask for help in asking for help.

Ken Chenault, longtime CEO and Chairman of American Express, told me that learning to ask for help helped him get promoted all the way up to the top job — and, once there, he set up a council of Fortune 50 CEOs to reinforce and deepen his skill at asking and learning from peers (note: he's now retired and Chairman of the venture capital firm General Catalyst, and board member at Berkshire Hathaway, among other companies).

Allison Mnookin, whose story I will tell in Chapter 4, asked for help to find a new job, and discovered that that skill helped put her on a trajectory to become a CEO.

David Krauter, whose story I will tell in Chapter 6, asked for help and transformed his career, catapulting him into COO and CEO roles.

Heather Fisher-O'Neill, a poet and adjunct professor whose story I will tell in detail in Chapter 7, not only asked for help to get a job that transformed her career, but also found that it became a way of life.

These are just some of the thousands of job (and promotion) seekers I've worked with who have learned to ask for help.

But lots of job seekers find asking for help hard and want to go it alone.

Some may have previously asked in the "wrong" way (I'll explain how to avoid that later in this chapter) and gotten burned.

And many do not ask because of emotional barriers, including the fear of looking weak or vulnerable.

I understand.

In fact, my work on asking for help with thousands of job seekers agrees with what Brad Klontz, a psychologist who primarily works with CEOs and billionaires, shared in an interview with the *New York Times*. One of the biggest differences between CEOs/billionaires and the rest of us, Klontz said, is that they "are not afraid to ask for help."³

The 200+ in-depth interviews I conducted for this book show that 85% of executives who make it to senior management say not only that they ask for help, but they credit it and their community of support with playing a key role in getting promoted into, or staying within the senior ranks.⁴

At the same time, 85% of the people who do *not* make it beyond a junior or mid-level role, say they do *not* ask for help often. Their support networks are, therefore, weak, and they can get stuck.

Their most cited reason for not asking for help is not having enough time, though many also report that fears and anxieties get in the way.

Take Olivia.⁵

She decided to leave her longtime Director of Product role at a Silicon Valley company to join an earlier-stage startup as a VP of Product.

So far so good, but that new job ended up being a "boomerang job." Olivia lasted only three months until she boomeranged back out because she was

unhappy with the culture, the CEO, and, well, with everything.

She then asked me for advice.

I talked her through the steps of Social Search, and she said she didn't have the time to do it.

I pointed out that while Social Search slows you down at first, it is faster at getting a good job than simply getting out there and doing interviews.

She still didn't want to take the time upfront.

I sensed there was more, so I asked "Why?" again. I mentioned her answer in the Introduction. It's instructive and comes up often in my work with job seekers, so it's worth going over it again.

She explained that she had three anxieties that were inhibiting her from following my recommendations. First, she was anxious about no money coming in. Second, not working lowered her sense of self-worth. Finally, her third anxiety came from believing the myth that asking for help was a weakness — that she should be able to handle the job search on her own.

Understood!

My last point about Olivia is my first point. Her scattershot process was *not* quicker, but slower.

I told her that if she counted the months she spent at the boomerang job, her job search had lasted at least nine months. Social Search would have likely been faster than that.

Again, she heard me but was still feeling like she had to get out *now*. So, she did and got a second boomerang job, which lasted just less than a year. When last I checked, she had had a total of 4 jobs since 2015, all lasting about a year.

And she kept complaining about her bad luck.

Contrast Olivia with Mara Castro.

The first employee at Warby Parker, Castro started as an operations manager. Over time, she was promoted to Senior Director of Customer Experience and ran a team of hundreds of people as the company grew quickly.

Along her journey, she joined CG (note: Collaborative Gain is the private leadership community my team and I run, in which product and general management leaders come together in "Career Councils" designed to help them make better, faster decisions and get promoted).

In her first meeting, she was blown away by how open and vulnerable the senior-level executives were with each other.

Here she recounts that experience:

It was refreshing to see that this group of more senior folks were open to asking for help. It was a very powerful experience, eye-opening, and I thought to myself, Hey, maybe I should open myself up a little bit more. I don't need to have everything figured out myself. I can ask for help more.

Fortunately, Castro did learn to get over her anxiety about asking for help and about building a community of support around herself. That community, including her CG Council, aided her advance at Warby Parker, and then played a critical role when, after 10 years, she decided it was time to look for a new job.

Even though she felt the same emotional anxieties that Olivia had experienced, Castro took the time to follow Social Search, and she asked for help a lot, and, in so doing, not only received help managing her anxieties but found a great job.

Even more importantly, after vetting the culture, the management team, and negotiating to set herself up for success, she is now very happy.

Yes!

If asking for help is so powerful for people like Castro, why is it so hard for people like Olivia?

To answer that, we must examine what I call the “obstacle.”

THE OBSTACLE

In high school and college, we get rewarded primarily for the grades we get on tests. In our formative years, we thus learn that asking for help is cheating.

But then, when we move into the job world, that changes, and we tend to get promoted for our skill at working with others, including, and especially, our ability to ask for help. Some learn early in their careers that asking for help builds better teams and teamwork, builds relationships, and helps teams focus on a common purpose or goal.

Here's the problem, however: few “get the memo.”

As a result, many mistakenly think they cannot ask, or they think they can ask for help only once. Thus, they put up a wall, or obstacle, between them and asking for help.

One job seeker, Diane, worked for one of the top venture capitalists earlier in her career. We'll call him Tom. When I recommended she reach out to Tom for help, she was resistant. She thought it would be an imposition.

Not true.

Interestingly, I happened to separately know Tom, and so I interviewed him. Without telling him about Diane and her reticence to ask, he *volunteered* during our conversation *his* own frustration that more like Diane do not reach out to him.

He told me that he likes to be asked for help by people who are serious and have done their homework, and certainly by anyone he's worked with or known in the past.

In fact, he likes to think of himself as someone who gives back to younger people.

But he finds that job seekers don't realize the joy they bring to *him*.

This dynamic of a job seeker (Diane) being reluctant to ask for help from someone (Tom) who is more than willing to help is very common.

It's too bad, because multiple research studies show that, if you ask someone for help, you honor them, you deepen the relationship, and you create an opportunity for them to be *giving*, which we humans love doing.

For example, what I've come to call *the gratitude effect* was made clear in 2010, when Professors Adam Grant and Francesca Gino published a paper in the *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*.⁶

THE GRATITUDE EFFECT

The professors' research demonstrates that, when a requester asks for help, receives advice, and then shows gratitude, that makes the helpers "experience stronger feelings of self-efficacy and social worth."

That's academic-speak for helping the helpers feel happier, more confident, and more willing to help. This is a big reason I ask you to set up a JSC. When your fellow job seekers ask you for help, and you help them, it will improve *your* confidence during the job search (and vice-versa).

Wow.

This is what Tom was talking about.

But again, for most people, it's counter-intuitive when they are in the *asking* position.

Mandy Ginsberg's career journey provides an example of both the resistance to learning to ask for help and the power of putting it into practice (*and* why everyone needs a safe space like a council to start doing it).

Ginsberg was the CEO of Match Group ([Match.com](https://www.match.com) and other properties) and is now a Board member at Uber and ThredUp. But she told me that she had been terrified to ask for help earlier in her career, and it took some effort to overcome that.

"I've seen this for women and myself: early in our careers, we are so afraid of being 'found out' that we do not ask for help. I would think, 'If I ask a question, someone's going to think I'm not smart enough.'"

That changed for Ginsberg as she joined CG, and then later YPO (formerly known as Young Presidents Organization, another organization running councils and forums — note I'm also a member of YPO and former chapter officer) and saw other smart women asking for help.

I remember when Ginsberg first joined CG. She was initially reluctant to open up and ask for help, but, as she saw other smart leaders on her council do it, she eventually embraced it herself. This is the power of a "mutually reinforcing activity," which I'll come back to in a moment.

And as she asked for help from her peers on councils and forums, her career accelerated dramatically.

Some lucky people get taught to ask for help on the job.

For example, Brad Smith, the longtime Intuit CEO, got some great help to ask for help.

Earlier in his career, Smith had all the same anxieties most others have. He thought that he should not *have* to ask. That he should figure it out on his own. He had grown up, he told me, in West Virginia, where self-reliance was a strong part of the culture. It seemed weak to ask for help.

As I've explained to CG members over the years, asking for help done well *is* a form of self-reliance and expresses confidence (note: there *are* counter-productive ways to ask, which we'll discuss later in this chapter).

In Smith's case, because his individual contributions were so good, he was eventually promoted and became a leader of one of the divisions of Intuit, but he had still not learned the art of asking for help, and that led him to make a major mistake.

We talked years later, and he told me what happened.

He decided, against the advice of his team and others, to re-write the code of a key application. He ended up wasting two and a half years on that project until he eventually shut it down. That decision cost \$40 million, he told me.

He thought his career was over.

But then something interesting happened.

The founder of the company, Scott Cook, and the Board explained to Brad the importance of asking for help. And with their support, he was able to start learning to ask.

And because of that, he was eventually promoted to the CEO role, where he became well-known for his humility and willingness to ask for help. At that point, he joined a CEO Council to deepen his ability to ask for help. I'll note that Smith's tenure was so successful that he not only oversaw a major transformation of the company, but also helped increase the stock price by *seven* times. That's the power of asking for help.

The key to learning to ask for help like Smith and others I've cited here comes from what I call "mutually reinforcing activity."

MUTUALLY REINFORCING ACTIVITY

You may have read several self-help books over the years. You may also have read other job search books or listened to podcasts or watched Tik Tok videos.

For example, you may have learned elsewhere about the importance of asking for help. You've also probably heard about Brene Brown's work on vulnerability, and you've likely run across Carol Dweck's work on growth mindsets.

But you may have noticed something along the way: *knowing* how to grow or change does *not* often help you to change.

This is the most important problem facing psychology and human development.

The intellectual knowledge of how to improve ourselves often does nothing for us.

Dr. Thomas Insel, the longtime Director of the National Institute of Mental Health — the nation's leading psychiatrist according to the *New York Times* — published a book, *Healing*, in which he says that all the "new insights

... have done little to help.”⁷ Interestingly, he says the main solution, which he ignored for many years, is “connection,” *not* knowledge.

Yes!

Humans are a social species, and we grow in relationship to each other.

If we create a context where we can connect and support each other to do new things, and where we can see each other do new things, then we can take the great work of psychologists like Brene Brown, Carol Dweck, and many others, and actually put what they are saying into practice — i.e., bridge the knowing-doing gap.

This is why peer councils, forums, and mutual-support groups of various kinds are the next wave of leadership and human development. They solve this problem at the heart of psychology — that it’s really hard to apply intellectual breakthroughs to our daily lives.

This is also why my first and most important recommendation is for you to create a Job Search Council. If you do that, then it will not only help you learn the *theory* of asking for help and the five-step Social Search process, but it will also help you *apply* what I’ve learned from thousands of other job seekers just like you.

Having said that, let me address a different but important issue: there is a way to ask for help that I want you to avoid — it can backfire and hurt, not help, your job search.

THE WRONG WAY TO ASK FOR HELP

Let me just say a few words about how *not* to ask for help.

The key is what academics call “independent” vs. “dependent” forms of asking.

How do you know the difference?

“Independent” means that you are asking for help as a learner constantly looking to improve. You do it as a self-reliant person who wants advice and perspective. You do your homework (note: I will give you homework in Chapter 4 to do before you go out and ask for help in shaping your Candidate-Market Fit).

You give thought to the problem or opportunity, and then reach out to get advice to make the best decision.

I sometimes refer to “independent” asking for help as “do it with me” — i.e., “give me advice, perspective, and support so I can achieve what I want to achieve.”

The asker retains independence, autonomy, and self-reliance.

There is a paradox in this formulation.

To ask for help this way requires *independence* of thinking; to *not* simply follow what everyone else is doing.

In other words, I’m not asking you to ask for help during your job search because I want you to give up on taking responsibility for making your own decisions. Quite the opposite. I want you to become better at taking responsibility and accountability for performing a good job search.

Learning how to get advice and perspective from others is fundamental to what it means to take responsibility for making your own decisions (and, as I’ve shown, to advancing your career).

Or to put it another way, I’m not suggesting that you listen to the wisdom of your various crowds. Very often there is little wisdom in any crowd. Instead, I’m asking you to build a curated crowd of fellow job seekers and others you trust.

Most importantly, I’m not suggesting you outsource your thinking at any point or become *dependent*.

Dependent ways of asking for help are often exemplified by asking but not learning; by simply complaining, and not changing your approach. Think of Olivia at the beginning of this chapter.

Olivia continually asked me for help but would not act on it and instead blamed bad luck for the constant yoyoing from job to job. She would never take responsibility for her part in the predicament she faced.

Every time she lost a job, however, she called me. I finally stopped taking her calls.

I’m sure you’ve interacted with people like Olivia. It’s frustrating.

Or, perhaps, you’ve received random requests for help from people you don’t know, who likely did not do their homework, or who simply reach out, hoping to outsource their work to you. This is the kind of asking for help you should avoid.

Let’s now leave the topic of asking for help and move on to examine the many emotional benefits of setting up a mutual-support group while looking

for a job, including the all-important concept of managing the emotional roller coaster.

MANAGING YOUR EMOTIONAL BALANCE SHEET

“Emotional balance sheets” — just like financial balance sheets — have assets and liabilities. Assets include hope, confidence, motivation, trust, and seeing through blind spots, while liabilities include envy, insecurity, unhappiness, dejection, and fear.

In our market-driven world, many job seekers typically face the heartless market alone, as individuals, who, no matter how accomplished, have emotional balance sheets that tip to liabilities.

Every job seeker (or internal promotion seeker) needs to increase the asset side of their emotional balance sheets because we all feel envious that others are much better than we are — that our mistakes are too big, that we smile too much or not enough, that we are too poised or not poised enough, that our LinkedIn profile is too promotional or not enough, that we need to take the first thing that comes along or nothing else ever will, that no company *we* want will want us, too, and that we might be too old, or too expensive, or that our skills might be out of date (or need to be reframed).

One senior executive I was speaking to about this during my research made a good point. He said he found that high performers are the ones who suffer impostor syndrome more than anyone else.

The truth, of course, is that we *all* have our various strengths and weaknesses.

If our inner critic were simply the emotional soundtrack that accompanied but had no impact on the success of our job search, then it would be no big deal. I could just tell you to ignore it and get out there and do some interviews and networking.

But I’ve yet to meet anyone who doesn’t have an internal critic in their head that is able to do some real damage by blowing up confidence, and undermining motivation.

Again, I understand your fears and the pressures you experience.

Stay with me here.

Doing a good Social Search will increase the odds of you finding a *better* job (or promotion) *faster*. You can’t remove the inner critic, but through Social

Search, you can offset it by *adding* other voices.

And those voices, that community of support, will provide hope, confidence, trust, and empathy.

HOPE, CONFIDENCE, TRUST, AND EMPATHY

Hope is everything in the job search.

Without hope, then you drain the asset side of your emotional balance sheet (and increase your liabilities), undermine your prospects, and even sabotage yourself.

Interestingly, if you put a small group of forlorn job seekers together, then, simply by coming together, they convert their fears and insecurities into hope and confidence.

Just seeing that we are *not* uniquely screwed up improves our emotional balance sheets because that shared experience reduces envy, that great amplifier of insecurity and destroyer of hope.

In 2017, three professors conducted a meta-analysis on the growing evidence for the positive impact of peer support and said that peer groups deliver a “positive impact on levels of hope [and] empowerment . . .”⁸

Yes!

For readers (optionally) interested in understanding more about *why* mutual-support groups like JSCs can be so powerful, I recommend reading Stanford University Professor Irvin Yalom’s classic text, *The Theory and Practice of Group Psychotherapy*, co-authored in the recent 6th Edition with Modyn Leszcz.

Yalom shows how we’re wired to operate in small groups because it’s how we’ve always conducted ourselves throughout the thousands of years of human evolution. These settings, he says, have shaped our “need to belong,” and they generate a “powerful, fundamental, and pervasive *motivation* [italics added].”⁹

This is group dynamics powered by our social brains.

And this is what we’ve been seeing for years at CG.

For example, a recent VP-level marketer was looking for a job while continuing in her old role. I gave her this book and suggested she run a Social Search and start by setting up a JSC. She did that. And when she got to the point of doing interviews, she ran into a problem.

After her first round of interviews with a public company in Silicon Valley, she texted me the following update:

Wow, that was intense. Moving to the next round of interviews, though. I'm doubting my performance, but I usually beat myself up after interviews.

Almost every job seeker I've worked with does the same. They beat themselves up, believe others to be much better than they, get demoralized, and lose hope.

I asked her to share this with her JSC and get some help.

She told her fellow members what happened. They asked clarifying questions about the interview, and, as they talked, it became clear to everyone, including her, that she had handled the interview well. As a result, she dialed down her insecurity and felt more energized and confident (and got an offer from this company a few weeks later).

Then something else happened: her fellow job seekers, by helping her, received the motivation and confidence to go out and do the same thing.

This example brings up another question: how is trust quickly created on a JSC?

Even though I've been bringing strangers together on councils of various kinds for nearly 40 years, I didn't quite understand why trust formed so fast until Harvard Professor Mario Luis Small published some groundbreaking research in a book, *Someone to Talk To*, in 2017.¹⁰

Here's his radical finding: almost 50% of the time, we speak about our serious worries *not* to close friends or family, but to strangers or so-called "weak ties."

But you might wonder, as I did, how that's possible without the trust that comes from people you know well or so-called "strong ties."

Importantly, relative to "weak ties," Small was not suggesting we just ask anyone on the street. One of the key concepts to come out of Small's research, and one that I now, in retrospect, see underpins the last 60 years of my mother's and my work with councils, is a phrase you'll hear me use a lot — jargon alert — "cognitive empathy."

Cognitive empathy is not conventional empathy, nor is it sympathy. It's connecting with someone who has been (or is) in your shoes.

If you do that, then Small says immediate trust is created.

Small shows many examples of this quick trust creation. For example, mothers of kids in the same preschool who do *not* know each other often will spontaneously entrust their children to each other in a pinch.

One early reader who formed her own JSC of acquaintances wrote this to me after just two weeks:

It's been only 2 weeks of my JSC, and I have already seen amazing levels of trust created.

Connecting with strangers or acquaintances who are also searching for jobs uses cognitive empathy to create immediate trust.

And that trust creates hope, which leads to motivation and accountability, and the cycle of mutually reinforcing activity during the job search.

Another benefit of bringing strangers together with cognitive empathy is that, surprisingly, we sometimes listen to strangers *more* than we listen to close friends and family.

THE POWER OF WEAK TIES

Perhaps it goes without saying, but you want all the members of your JSC to be job seekers like you.

Because it's unlikely that many close friends will be job searching at the same time, you'll need to recruit a mix of strangers, acquaintances, and contacts.

Surprisingly you'll find it easier to recruit strangers than you might imagine (I'll review just how to do this in the next chapter).

And strangers bring benefits.

When each member of a JSC is *not* a close friend, then that means they each bring a different set of experiences *and* different networks. This diversity is key. You will need people who have different connections, experiences, cultural biases, and perspectives.

So, with strangers or near acquaintances, you get the trust environment you need, and the combined network is much larger; that *multiplies* the potential help. This simple insight about the power of information and connection

sharing with strangers during a job search was first explained in a groundbreaking paper in 1972 by Mark Granovetter.¹¹

Granovetter's breakthrough was that so-called "weak ties" — social relationships with strangers, acquaintances, or contacts — could help with information like referrals to jobs. He was right.

Recently, five CG members who were otherwise strangers (they had not been on the same council) lost their jobs during the pandemic and formed a JSC. They immediately started providing a lot of support to each other, including some sharing of networks.

The members realized they did not know much about the private equity (PE) world, and this was important because the growth of PE — trillions in assets — meant that they needed to understand that world. One of them, however, knew a CG alumnus who worked at a PE firm and offered to interview him and bring back the learnings, which is what he did.

This not only helped everyone understand the PE market but also directly led to two of the members getting jobs in PE-backed companies.

Had these weak ties not sought each other out and found common ground in a JSC, they would not have created the opportunity to learn about the PE market as they did, nor would they have found the contacts and job leads that led to great roles.

But your peer JSC members can do even more for you than multiply your networks. They can also help you do the impossible: see through blind spots that hold you back.

BLIND SPOTS

In 1969, while many young people were protesting the Vietnam War, Professors Daniel Kahneman and Amos Tversky began a countercultural effort of a different kind. They believed that humans are "predictably irrational" and eventually won a Nobel Prize for their work. Now, they and colleagues have identified hundreds of cognitive biases that affect judgment and decision-making.

No leader or decision-maker, or human for that matter, is immune. Still this large body of work in behavioral economics has not been widely adopted by leaders who want to improve their own decision-making.

The reason is something I've come to call Kahneman's Conundrum.

Kahneman summarized the challenge succinctly in his 2011 international bestseller *Thinking Fast and Slow*. Kahneman says that he himself has no idea when he's making any of the cognitive mistakes that he's spent a lifetime identifying: "My intuitive thinking is just as prone to overconfidence, extreme predictions, and the planning fallacy as it was before I made a study of these issues."¹²

Might there be a way for leaders to at least *know* when they are about to make a mistake based on a bias?

Kahneman says NO: "We would all like to have a warning bell that rings loudly whenever we are about to make a serious error, but no such bell is available."

I almost fell off my chair when I first read those words. The knowledge of these biases does not seem to matter. The expert knowledge gained from decades of research does not even help the co-founder of the discipline. We humans are destined to make the same kinds of mistakes repeatedly, to be blind about our blind spots.

It's simple but true. We all know that we can easily see the errors in others while being frustratingly blind to our own.

One of my CG members told me this dynamic reminded her of dating. She said, "I recognize issues in others' relationships, and I even know how I need to change — but can't do it."

True!

Spouses can see the mistakes that their partners make repeatedly. CEOs can see the errors that their peers make. Product managers can see more clearly the errors or weaknesses in the products of a competitor than they can in their own. And job seekers can see the biases and blind spots that impair each other's job search (note: many of the exercises in this book will be paired exercises with fellow JSC members, who will be able to see you more clearly than they can themselves, and vice versa).

But the question is: who is an objective observer in our job search who we will listen to and whose advice we will act on?

If you've been reading along, you now know the answer: your fellow JSC members.

One job seeker, Andre, talked about a job offer to his JSC, which was full of strangers and near acquaintances. The offer did not meet his requirements

(see Chapter 4 for creating your list of requirements or “must haves”), so he turned it down. He thought that was the end of the conversation.

The company came back twice with revised offers, the last one meeting Andre’s requirements. He told them he would consider it and took the story and the offer back to his JSC to ask for help on whether to accept this offer.

This story, however, is not about Andre, but about Juana.

Juana, a fellow member of Andre’s JSC, was shocked by his story.

Hearing Andre talk, Juana realized that, in her career, she had *never once* asked for more. In fact, unlike Andre, she would have likely said yes to that first offer, even though it didn’t meet her requirements. Further, she realized this kind of mistake explained a lot of her job hopping. She took jobs she didn’t want, for too little money, got disappointed, and left. Again, and again.

Here’s the point: Juana had read books about impostor syndrome and about how to negotiate. But she couldn’t see her own blind spot about it!

And didn’t realize this was even a problem until she heard Andre’s story.

So, after Andre shared his story and got help, Juana then shared *her* story and asked the council for help overcoming her now-visible vulnerability to accept whatever offer comes first.

Let me explain one more important benefit of building a community of support around yourself before we end this chapter: the playfully named Orangutan Room.

ORANGUTAN ROOMS

Just being forced to explain your problems verbally can itself help you see the solution. I call this dynamic the Orangutan Room, in homage to my distant mentor (meaning I don’t know him) Charlie Munger, Vice Chairman of Berkshire Hathaway and longtime partner of Warren Buffett.

Here’s what Munger once said:

*[I]f a smart person goes into a room with an orangutan and explains whatever his or her idea is, the orangutan just sits there eating his banana, and at the end of the conversation, the person explaining comes out smarter.*¹³

Munger proposed this to Katharine Graham, then CEO of The Washington Post Company, after she had told him that Buffett had been so

helpful. Munger replied that at least part of the benefit was hearing her own question and she would have likely come to a good answer even if an orangutan were sitting there rather than Buffett himself.

Graham thought about what Munger said and agreed.

So did Buffett.

In fact, Buffett told her that he was happy to be her orangutan.

Warren claimed to be my orangutan. And, in a way, he was. I heard myself talk when I was with him, and I always got a better idea of what I was saying.

Many Social Searchers tell me they get enormous benefits just from having a safe space to think out loud, to describe challenges or situations. And sometimes they know the answer before they are even done asking.

Hope, motivation, accountability, new sources of information, trust, identifying blind spots, and the Orangutan Room: these are a few of the ways a JSC will help.

With that said, we are done with theory.

Let's now turn to recruiting job seekers to join you in a JSC.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

- Move on to the next chapter, and begin the work of setting up your Job Search Council.

TOOLS AND TEMPLATES

Personal History by Katharine Graham

One of the best memoirs of the last 30 years, Graham's *Personal History* is a must-read for anyone interested in business. The first woman CEO of a Fortune 500 company, Graham writes honestly about the 20th century, including the obstacles, and the help she asked for and received. In fact, I consider her a mentor of mine relative to the art of asking for help. I've studied her closely, interviewed many in her family, and will be writing more about her in the future. Get this Pulitzer-Prize winning memoir during your job search. It will reward and inspire you.



CHAPTER 2

RECRUIT STRANGERS (OR ACQUAINTANCES)

As you begin to imagine the power of a mutual support group for job seekers, you are likely asking yourself another question: *Who, exactly, is going to join my JSC?*

You may not have close friends or colleagues who are 1) peers to you in terms of career, and 2) looking for a job *now*.

Thus, you may be wondering who (and how) to recruit.

The short answer is: strangers.

And the good news is that 80% of the early readers of this book had no trouble recruiting strangers and acquaintances to join them in a Job Search Council.

They made it easy for themselves by first finding just one other person.

FIND YOUR FIRST MEMBER

To start, simply ask people you know: “Who else do you know — at my level, more or less — who is looking for a job?”

Ask around in your personal network.

Ask former colleagues, friends, and anyone you can.

Use LinkedIn to post publicly (if you are comfortable doing that) or to send private messages. (You will find email recruiting templates on my book website.)

If you have a distant friend who you know is looking, invite them.

If you have a colleague from a past job who is looking (and you trust them), then you can invite them.

If you don't know anyone directly, don't worry. I recommend you recruit strangers for the unexpected gifts they bring — like broader networks and seeing through blind spots — as I suggested in the last chapter.

Further, your fellow members do not have to be in your exact discipline/industry.

You should keep an eye out for diversity of backgrounds, genders, etc. Again, that diversity will bring added benefits, including broader networks and different points of view.

The one kind of diversity I do *not* recommend is mixing job seekers who are out of work with those who are still working.

The reason is that these two types of job seekers have different speeds.

Job seekers out of work typically want to move fast, so their JSCs meet weekly, and they move quickly through the five steps of Social Search.

Still-working job seekers, on the other hand, need to juggle their job searches with their current jobs, so those job seekers choose a slower cadence.

Let me pause to acknowledge that recruiting is a bit more challenging for job seekers who are still working.

RECRUITING FOR PEOPLE STILL IN JOBS

People who are still working often need to keep their job search quiet and confidential. So, their recruiting usually goes slower (and can be more difficult than for out-of-work job seekers).

If you are still working and looking for a job, then, to keep confidentiality, I recommend you reach out to a few close friends outside your company at first. Ask them if they know anyone who is still working who might be thinking of looking. Emphasize that they should not use your name but simply say that a friend of theirs at an “x” kind of company, in a “y” kind of role is thinking about looking for their next job and is looking to speak to others in similar situations.

Further, if you are a member of an industry association, alumni network, or other such group, you can often quietly look for peer job seekers in those networks.

RECRUITING FOR COLLEGE STUDENTS

On the one hand, college students tend to find it easy to recruit and set up JSCs since they have a built-in peer group already looking, but, unlike professionals already in careers, they have additional challenges.

The questions college students ask me include the following.

When should they form a JSC? Sophomore year, I suggest. That will give them the time they need to figure out both what they want and what the market wants.

How do they figure out what they want, given they have not had full-time jobs yet? See above. That's why I recommend they begin in the sophomore year. That will give them time to conduct the Listening Tour, take internships, participate in clubs related to their potential interest, etc.

Should they invite only people on campus, or can it be cross-campus? Cross-campus gives the power of weak ties that we discussed in the last chapter.

Should they invite only people looking for the same kind of jobs, or should it be a mix? I recommend a mix to reduce any competitive overlap.

TROUBLE RECRUITING?

What if you have trouble recruiting?

I have two suggestions: 1) ask for help from friends, colleagues, or others whom you trust; 2) go to PhylTerry.com and sign-up for my free JSC matching service.

WHAT TO SAY TO A POTENTIAL RECRUIT?

Once you identify a potential member, then set up a call or coffee and tell them you are forming a mutual-support group where job seekers can be open, vulnerable, and ask each other for help during their search. You can then also add that the group will be using this book for each step of the search.

The most important thing to emphasize is that your JSC will be a place to “ask for help.”

Over the years, as I've recruited thousands of leaders for CG, I've discovered that simple phrase has a magical quality: it compels the humble and repels the arrogant.

My mother first taught me this, and Annie Duke's research supports it.

Duke, who is one of the top poker players in the world, and author of multiple books on applying probability to decision-making, points out in her book *Thinking in Bets* that peer support groups work if members share a willingness to ask for help and a willingness to then listen to a diversity of perspectives.¹⁴

Once you find just one other person, then your next step is to set up the charter for your council. The two of you will do this together.

CHARTER

To make it easy, I've set up a charter template that you can download and go through with your first member.

You'll want to agree on the focus — e.g., out-of-work job seekers, in-work job seekers, or career-switchers — and on willingness to ask for help, confidentiality, attendance, and, most importantly, the commitment to be there for each other through your job searches.

Once the two of you have established your charter, then you each go to your networks and each recruit one more person.

RECRUIT TWO MORE PEOPLE

You each ask the same question of your networks: "Do you know anyone with my tenure of experience who is looking for a job?"

Then, once you each identify prospective new members, you review the charter and, again, emphasize asking for help as the main activity of this mutual support group.

When you have at least four members, you are ready to launch, which is what we'll discuss next.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

- Recruit your first member of your JSC.
- Create your charter (download the charter template at PhylTerry.com).
- Recruit two more members.

TOOLS AND TEMPLATES

Email Recruiting Templates

(Available on my author site: PhylTerry.com)

Get these templates so you can be guided in how to reach out to recruit potential members.

JSC Matching Service

(Available on PhylTerry.com)

If you don't want to recruit members yourself, then visit my website to sign-up for my free Job Search Council matching service.

Charter Template

(Available on my author site: PhylTerry.com)

Get the Charter template so that you and your first member can review it and make some decisions on the design of your JSC.



CHAPTER 3

LAUNCH YOUR JSC

You have recruited at least four members, you have agreed on a charter, including frequency of meetings, commitment to ask for help, attendance, etc.

Congratulations!

You are now ready to get the benefits of a council of peers, just as thousands of CEOs do every day. In fact, you are on the cutting edge of the next wave of leadership development.

COUNCILS: THE NEXT WAVE

Today, millions of people do *not* know about private peer-support groups like JSCs or Career Councils, or any other private peer council or forum.

In fact, these are one of the best-kept secrets of the business world.

Peer councils are at the same level of acceptance today that executive coaching was about 20 years ago, when most executives had not yet had a coach. And thus, participation provides the same kind of advantage that those with coaches had early on — an uncommon edge.

Pioneers of councils popped up in mid-20th century America, led, in part, by my mom, and by organizations like Vistage. Then in the 1970s, the Young Presidents Organization (now known as “YPO”) started running small mutual-support forums for Presidents and CEOs of companies.

Today, YPO and other similar organizations like my own Collaborative Gain (councils for product leaders and GMs in tech) have more than *150,000* members and are growing fast.¹⁵

Mo Fathelbab, who was the first Executive Director of EO, estimates that membership of CEO peer-learning organizations will grow to around 2 million in the next decade. That's just the CEO groups and not counting other organizations.

This category is clearly exploding.

Fathelbab himself has now worked with everyone from CEOs to high school principals, to college students. Several years ago, he co-founded the Alumni Services Group, which is bringing peer forums to alumni at all levels from schools like Harvard Business School, UC Berkeley, and other universities.

A group of YPO leaders recently co-founded another organization to develop an online service that will make it easy for anyone around the world to start and form a council. At the same time, a longtime YPO member, Dan Hoffman, has created [Circl.es](#), a global web platform aimed at making virtual councils and forums possible.

Further, YPO has developed materials and resources so that their 30,000 CEO members can run forums inside their companies, while Vistage has launched a pilot program to run cross-company councils for the up-and-coming leaders in their CEO member companies.

One more point: many business leaders have been quietly running their own private councils for decades.

For example, when Warren Buffett started to wind down his hedge fund in the 1960s and was wondering what to do next, he reached out to peers he trusted and formed a kind of private council with the aim of providing “mutual support.”¹⁶

When Karen Wickre, author and Google veteran, lost her job after the first dotcom bubble burst, she put together a small group of job seekers to help figure out next steps in their respective careers.¹⁷ That was Wickre's JSC, though she didn't call it that.

Finally, in the last decade, YPO, Vistage, and other organizations like Lean In Circles (started after the publication of Sheryl Sandberg's book, *Lean In*) and my own Collaborative Gain have seen their fastest growth yet.

So, in addition to the critical help you'll receive on your job search, your JSC will also give you experience in this cutting-edge leadership development approach.

Now, I will briefly review some practical issues you'll need to begin meeting. I'll review the standard meeting format and then provide pointers to the first 10 meeting agendas, which you'll be able to find on my book website.

But, first let me address the question of moderation.

MODERATION

As the founder of the JSC, you should be the moderator.

Let me just say that again. You as the founder are the moderator.

If you are practiced at moderating and running effective meetings, then you are ready to go.

If you are *not*, then don't worry.

While it's true that it takes a lot of practice to become a great moderator, you do *not* need to be great, or even good for the JSC to work its magic.

So, relax.

You've got this.

If you are nervous about moderating, let your JSC members know, and ask for their patience and help. That's what councils are all about.

Many people resist this recommendation and think they need extensive training in moderation. That is truer for ongoing Career Councils. But for JSCs, where everyone is invested in finding a good job fast, moderation tends to take care of itself.

If you just get a group of job seekers together, they will go out of their way to help each other, especially if everyone is reading this book and following the five steps of Social Search.

To moderate a JSC, you just need to run a simple three-part meeting format.

THREE-PART MEETING FORMAT

Each JSC meeting will have a simple three-part structure:

- Updates, including results of any individual homework exercises from the book
- Short requests for help (RFHs)

- Long RFHs and joint exercises from the book

I'm deliberately saying less rather than more about moderation because I want to emphasize again what I've seen over and over: if you bring eager job seekers together, then they jump in and help each other, making running the meetings relatively easy.

The key is simply to keep the meeting running on time and focused.

The agenda template on my website will help: it provides step-by-step instructions for running the meetings alongside the exercises and homework that appear throughout the chapters of this book.

The template also goes over this three-part meeting structure in more detail, including more about RFHs, with some examples.

Finally, I'll note that I have written an extensive essay showing a JSC in action. You'll find it in the "Tools and Templates" on PhylTerry.com. I recommend you and your fellow members download and read it to get a sense of how a good JSC operates.

MEETING AGENDAS

On my book website, I provide you with comprehensive agendas for your first ten meetings.

You may not need that many meetings. You may need more.

Each job search is different, depending on your tenure, state of your network, and, most importantly, how ruthless you are willing to be when it comes to defining your Candidate-Market Fit.

One job seeker started a JSC, recruited great people, and then watched all of them get jobs while he continued to look.

His problem?

His Candidate-Market Fit did not reflect the realities of how the market perceived him. So, be on the lookout for how your fellow JSC members or you may have this problem (and read Chapter 9 closely).

The first 10 agendas walk you and your fellow members through figuring out your Candidate-Market Fit and then starting to network.

The agendas and exercises for meetings 11+ will be determined by you and will be based on whatever members need at that point.

Let's now briefly discuss the next steps in the Social Search process.

NEXT STEPS

Over the decades, I have worked with thousands of CG members to hone Social Search.

You will see the fingerprints of many leaders all over the stories and tools that I share in the following chapters.

In fact, the rest of this short book is designed around the remaining stages of the Social Search process.

I recommend that you and your fellow members go through the steps, which begin with you creating the Mnookin Two-Pager, named after Allison Mnookin, a professor at Harvard Business School, whose story I'll tell in Chapter 4. This first step allows you to articulate what you enjoy doing, as well as your "must haves" and "must nots." Once you have that done, then prepare for your Listening Tour with an exercise and some tips (Chapter 5).

The Listening Tour, a way to understand how the market sees you, involves three different kinds of conversations: Reverse Exit Interviews (Chapter 6), The Golden Question (Chapter 7), and then Recruiter Interviews (Chapter 8). Once you complete this research, you then create your Candidate-Market Fit (Chapter 9), which will then guide the revamp of your LinkedIn profile, resume (Chapter 10), and everything else you do (and remember, never stop listening to and learning from the market as you proceed forward).

A note of caution: the Listening Tour can be hard emotionally. It requires being open to listening to feedback, including feedback which you may not agree with, or which may be hard to hear.

You do not want to do this alone.

Your JSC will play a very important role in helping you manage your emotional balance while going through this important phase. As you'll learn from the stories in the chapters to follow, your JSC will also help you parse the feedback and figure out what matters and what does not.

Once you have listened and clearly understood and embraced your Candidate-Market Fit, then you can set a strategy for your job search. This step is critical to everything you do next. Only then do you start your networking engine (Chapter 11). To help you, I show you how to ask for (and make) warm and cold introductions, as well as a few other important networking tips. In Chapter 12, I give you advice on how to prepare for and conduct interviews. The most important thing is this: when you start to get into serious interviews

with a company, you should create a Job Mission with OKRs that will guide your final interviews and set you up well to negotiate compensation as well as the budget and resources you'll need (I explain what this means in Chapter 12 and provide examples of Job Missions in the Additional Resources for that chapter).

To negotiate with prospective employers, the most important recommendation I make in Chapters 13 and 14 is connected to what I wrote above: leverage your Job Mission to help you negotiate *both* your salary *and* the budget and resources you will need to succeed. Negotiating well like this can lead to hundreds of thousands of dollars in salary, bonus, stock, and the positive effects of getting set up to do well.

Once you have your new job, I give you some advice in Chapter 15 on how to prepare for starting the new role.

Before you begin your Listening Tour, let me address a few concerns you may have.

FAST JOB OFFERS?

Occasionally a job seeker will get an offer for a job while setting up their JSC and before they begin their Listening Tour.

If you get a good job offer, then run it by your JSC, and be sure you aren't missing any red flags. Be wary of "boomerang" jobs. Job seekers are inclined to take the first thing that comes along, and then those boomerang jobs tend not to work out.

Having said that, if you are one of the people who gets a *good* offer right away, then speak to your JSC, and get their help to create a Job Mission with OKRs, evaluate the company, negotiate the offer, and set yourself up to succeed (again, read Chapters 12–15 for more detail).

SKIPPING THE LISTENING TOUR?

If, on the other hand, you don't have an offer, but you are thinking that you'd prefer to skip the Listening Tour and go right to networking, don't do it.

Recall the story of DD from the Introduction.

The Listening Tour that she finally did opened new possibilities she would not have otherwise imagined.

Further, even if you already know your Candidate-Market Fit and are making a lateral move in the same industry or function, you will still get important help if you follow the steps of Social Search.

For example, a Chief Product Officer, Carson, of a software company in Silicon Valley, left and decided to find a new CPO role in another B2B software company.

His Candidate-Market Fit was obvious, and he had a good network.

Nevertheless, he still decided to set up a JSC, go on a quick Listening Tour to gain any additional nuanced insight into his Candidate-Market Fit.

He was surprised by how helpful the whole process was, especially the emotional boost he got from his fellow members.

Starting a JSC was a GREAT idea and worked incredibly well. In my case, I ended up needing just some slight changes with my Candidate-Market Fit, but I still found the emotional support and chance to go through the process with a trusted group to be revolutionary (and resulted in negotiating more pay!).

Yes!

And Carson's experience goes to the other question that job seekers often ask:

Can't I just read the book and do these steps on my own?

DO YOU REALLY NEED A JSC?

Of course, you, the reader, get to decide, but, if you ask me, then do not attempt these steps on your own.

Build a community of support around yourself, not only for the duration of your search, but also for the long run. By using the Social Search methodology, the people in your JSC as well as those you meet along the course of your job search become — and remain — a foundational part of your network, adding value to your career and life for years to come.

Yes, it may seem annoying now to imagine recruiting members, scheduling meetings, and keeping up with everyone's searches.

But the alternative is *much* harder and leaves you prone to getting demoralized, even when things go relatively well, as with Carson above.

Let's now move to Chapter 4 and begin the preparations for your Listening Tour with what I call the Mnookin Two-Pager exercise.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

- Download meeting agendas.
- Download and read the story of a JSC in action.

TOOLS AND TEMPLATES

Meeting Agendas

(Available on my author site: PhylTerry.com)

This document comes pre-set with agendas for your first 10 meetings, including the homework you should do (the homework ties to exercises in subsequent chapters in this book).

Imani Smith's JSC in Action

(Available on my author site: PhylTerry.com)

This addendum tells the story of a JSC in action. Through the story of Imani Smith and her JSC, you will get a great example of how these meetings work and the kind of help you can expect to receive.

STEP 2

Conduct Your Listening Tour

	Step 1 JSC	Step 2 Listening Tour	Step 3 Candidate- Market Fit	Step 4 Networking/ Interviewing	Step 5 Negotiate	Total Time
Full-time job seekers (i.e., those unemployed)	1-2 weeks	2-3 weeks	1-2 weeks	4-8 weeks	1-2 weeks	2+ mos
Part-time job seekers (i.e., those still employed)	2+ weeks	4+ weeks	2-3 weeks	4+ weeks	1-2 weeks	4+ mos



CHAPTER 4

THE MNOOKIN TWO-PAGER

Now you begin Step 2, the Listening Tour, which should take 2–3 weeks for out-of-work job seekers and longer for those who are in jobs (and remember, you continue listening and iterating throughout your whole job search).

Keep in mind that this Listening Tour is *not* networking for your job. This is “discovery” work on your own Candidate-Market Fit. You will deepen relationships and lay the groundwork for great networking by doing this, but you are not ready to network yet.

Know also that this is the most difficult of all the steps of Social Search.

It’s not difficult because the work is hard.

It’s difficult *emotionally*.

When most of us start looking for a job, no matter who we are, our insecurities and anxieties take over.

As a result, most of us want to find a job quickly to quell those inner critics.

And, thus, the idea of slowing down sounds terrible — just the thing to stoke anxieties.

Yet, if you simply start networking and interviewing, you can spin your wheels and further demoralize yourself.

The solution I’ve developed to this Catch-22 — i.e., the fact that you’ll be anxious if you slow down, or you’ll likely be unhappy with the results if you speed up and skip this — is to set up a Job Search Council, which will give you

the emotional support you need to go through this ‘liminal’ or transition phase.

This is potentially a very creative moment — a moment of self-discovery through conversation with others; a moment where new opportunities you had not even imagined (think DD from the Introduction) become possible; a moment where you can begin to learn the practical steps to realizing your hopes and dreams (even if they will take a few steps).

But again, if you are like most of the job seekers I’ve worked with, you won’t want to do this.

You’ll want to edit your resume and jump quickly in to networking and interviewing.

Resist that temptation.

What I recommend here is not a long process, but it’s a very important one for the success of your job search.

Your first step will be to create a first draft of a document that outlines your initial thoughts on what *you* want, what you love doing, and your career goals. I call this “The Mnookin Two-Pager,” named after Allison Mnookin, a professor at Harvard Business School, whose story I will tell in this chapter.

Importantly, know that your first draft of your two-pager is just that — a draft. You do not need to get it exactly right. In fact, feedback from your Listening Tour will help you hone your understanding of not just what the market wants, but also what *you* want.

Let me make that last point again in a different way.

Social Search addresses a problem that plagues many job searches, which is that seekers often don’t know exactly what they want.

There are two reasons for this: 1) Kahneman’s Conundrum — the concept we discussed in Chapter 1, which is the idea that you can’t see yourself clearly, but others often can; and 2) learning what’s possible in the job market from others helps you *discover* what you want.

Traditional career advice often centers on the job seeker thinking alone to come up with what they want (or taking an unhelpful quiz) and then going out and interviewing. Sometimes it includes “informational interviews,” which can be helpful and are a step in the right direction, but often amount to asking for job leads.

Nothing, however, can replace the power of first doing some discovery work. This is a moment to be open-minded, curious, and not focused yet on

getting job leads or interviews.

The job search is not just about you or what you theoretically want. There's a job market with companies and hiring managers who obviously play a key role in all this. What are they thinking? How do they see you? What possibilities are they aware of that you had not even considered?

To be fair, many job seekers understand this, but then make a related mistake. They use their initial networking and interviewing as 'research.'

Right idea, wrong implementation.

If you interview for a job to practice or to better understand the market, then you run two risks. First, you may find that you are not a fit for the job and get rejected. Rejections even for jobs you don't want undermine your confidence and can thus negatively affect your whole search.

A job seeker, we'll call her Krista, did just that. She read a draft of my book, but wanted to 'get out there' and so started doing interviews with a random company that called her. Krista didn't want the job, but she wanted to practice her interviewing skills and, as she later admitted, get a 'revenge offer' to prove to her current boss, whom she was mad at, that she deserved better treatment.

Krista, however, got quickly invested in the outcome of the interviews. She forgot it was 'research' and when they did end up rejecting her, she called and told me she feared that 'no one would want me.' She was dejected and resigned to staying in a job she didn't like.

That's the risk of the interview-as-research approach.

In this case, I happened to know the hiring manager, so I asked Krista if she would mind if I spoke to them. With her permission, I reached out, and they confidentially confirmed my hunch. They were impressed with her skills and experience, but could tell that she didn't really want the job, and so did not make an offer.

But that's not how Krista understood it. She thought it was rejection of *her*.

I'll note that the only thing worse than getting rejected by a company you are practicing with, is the opposite. You get an offer for a job you don't want, but find it hard to say no, accept it, and then are miserable.

That's why I want you to slow down and do some market research on what you want and what the market wants *before* you begin networking or interviewing.

If you agree to this radical suggestion, then your first step will be to do some homework (recall again from Chapter 1 that doing homework is an important part of asking for help well).

Your homework is to create a draft of The Mnookin Two-Pager, a document which will have four sections: (note: even though I call it a “two-pager,” you can sometimes make it a one-pager).

- What you love and hate doing
- Your “must-haves”
- Your “must-nots”
- Your career goals (short-term and long-term)

Let’s get started.

WHAT DO YOU LOVE DOING?

Ask yourself: what do I love doing?

Allison Mnookin, current Harvard Business School professor, found herself at a crossroads in 2010 during her then-career at software company Intuit. The division she helped to run had just bought another company, and it was becoming clear that the new management team was not going to include her, though that was not yet totally obvious to Mnookin.

Fortunately, a friend, mentor, and former boss, Hilarie Koplow-McAdams, happened to come for a visit, and they got to talking. Part of Mario Luis Small’s research — I briefly mentioned him in Chapter 1 — shows that half the time we need help we do *not* realize it. Small found that, in those cases, people often get help by simply bumping into someone, which is what happened here.

As they started catching up, Koplow-McAdams helped Mnookin start to realize the help she needed.

At that point, it wasn’t clear to me what to do. One of my colleagues wanted me to stay. But as Hilarie and I started talking, it became clear fast that there wasn’t a good role and that, as Hilarie put it, I ‘should not want to stay.’

This was helpful. Koplow-McAdams was helping Mnookin see what *Mnookin* wanted.

The Listening Tour conversations that I'm suggesting you have are meant to help you understand the market *and* help you better understand yourself, like what happened here with Mnookin.

Koplow-McAdams also gave Mnookin something else: the motivation and accountability to *act*.

*"Hilarie said to me, 'Allison, you got to get on the stick because you must figure out what's next for you.' That was great because I needed that 'kick in the a**.'"*

After that conversation with Koplow-McAdams, Mnookin decided to do what we now encourage all job seekers to do: she created a Two-Pager.

"So, with that kick in the butt from Hilarie, I then ended up putting together a little two-page thing. I listed out what I thought I was particularly good at, what I do not want to do, and what I enjoy doing."

Once she finished a draft of her first two-pager, she then went out and conducted research on herself and the market. Since she was looking for a new job *inside* her current company, the tour was focused on Intuit employees. She started each conversation by sharing the two-pager and then asking a version of the Golden Question (Chapter 7): "How would you think about my options if you were in my shoes?"

She also asked a series of good follow-up questions, including:

1. Do you think my Two-Pager is a good description of me — i.e., is it accurate in terms of what I'm good at and enjoy — and what I don't like? Is there anything missing? (Remember, you do these conversations in part to get help to understand what *you* want.)
2. In terms of jobs here at Intuit — is there anything going on that you think could use my skills?
3. Is there anyone else I should talk to?

Along the way, one idea kept surfacing: consider go running Quickbase.

At the time, Quickbase was a small Boston-based division of Intuit, and Mnookin was living in Silicon Valley.

She had not seriously considered that as an option, but several people helped her see it was a better opportunity than she realized and one that fit her must-haves and must-nots quite well.

If Mnookin had sat alone and thought about what she wanted, she would never have come up with this all-the-way-across-the-country option to run a small non-core division for Intuit.

With the help and insight she received during her Listening Tour, however, Mnookin came to realize that this might be exactly what she wanted.

Yes!

That's what I'm talking about.

And so, Mnookin decided to go ahead and move her family and become General Manager for Intuit's Quickbase software.

This "market-informed" choice turned out to be a great decision that had a major impact on her career.

She ran and grew the Quickbase business for several years, and then spun it out and became the CEO of the separate Quickbase company.

After retiring from that role, she then joined the faculty at Harvard Business School (HBS), where she is today.

Today, in addition to teaching at HBS, she also sits on the boards of several high-profile public companies.

She would never have achieved as much, however, if she had not asked for help to understand what she wanted and what was possible back at that critical juncture in 2010.

Eleven years after Mnookin created her first two-pager and ran her Listening Tour, Justin Cinicolo decided to follow in her footsteps.

Like many job seekers I've worked with, and, like Mnookin herself, he found it quite helpful.

"The simple idea that I should step back and evaluate what in the past did not work (and I did not like), and equally what is important to me led to the realization that, for me, 'culture is king.' I had never stopped to think about that. And that changed not just my job search, but how I carry myself, how I lead, how I now run meetings. Everything."

In fact, the exercise and the Listening Tour that followed led directly to his great job as VP of the Game Division for Dapper Labs, a leading blockchain games company.

Thinking about what you want (and do not want) is *obviously* not a new concept.

The new concept here is my suggestion that you slow down and do this research with others in a structured Listening Tour *before* you begin networking and interviewing.

Let's now turn to creating your first draft of the Mnookin Two-Pager.

1: WHAT YOU HATE (AND LOVE) DOING EXERCISE

Because it can be hard to draft out what you want or love doing, I begin helping you create your Mnookin Two-Pager with an inversion exercise where I will ask you to imagine what you would hate to do next.

It's always easier to start with what you do *not want*.

So, what would you *hate* to do next? What kinds of things do you *not enjoy*?

Mnookin did this back in 2010 and realized some important things.

My idea of hell back then was sitting in an office alone and thinking deep thoughts. So, I included that and clarified that my next step will not be a solo spot or an analytical job. Neither should it be a strategy job that is not about a team. I got joy from seeing stuff implemented.

Of course, what you love and hate changes over time. That's why it's important to keep doing these exercises every time you change jobs. At this point, Mnookin is a professor who, in fact, does sit in her office and think "deep thoughts" as well as sits on boards and helps with strategy rather than implementing stuff. But that was not true in 2010.

And, of course, considerations outside work will play a role in this process. Is it important that your work week be flexible? Do you want to coach your child's sports team or be able to be part of the carpooling group? Do you want to be remote, in-person, or a hybrid? Do you need more exercise and meditation time?

So, the first exercise in creating your Two-Pager will be the “What you Hate (and Love) Doing” exercise; you do this paired up with another member of your JSC.

1. Pair up with a member of your JSC.

2. Interview each other about what you hate doing.

When you are paired up, you then interview each other about all the kinds of jobs, industries, functions, etc. that you hate and do not love doing. What about past jobs did you dislike? Why? Your partner should take notes on what you don't like doing. Then, in the next steps, you will get the copy of their notes to review it.

3. Review your list separately.

Get your list of what you hate doing from your partner in this exercise. Each of you spend 15 minutes reviewing your own lists and adding anything.

4. Then invert to what you *love* doing.

Now each of you invert your own lists. If you put down that you hate business travel, then invert that to you love jobs with little travel (and try to get more specific — maybe, you love running teams in one location, rather than national or global teams). And keep in mind that, if you hate doing something, you will not always necessarily like doing the inverse. You may just be satisfied with the absence of the thing.

In this exercise, be as open and honest as you can. Keep in mind that you can be good at something but *not love it*. For example, I'm quite good at finance, but coming out of Harvard Business School, I made a very clear choice *not to go to Wall Street*. I did not like the typical 1990s macho culture of those firms.

Also, look for opportunities to be creative.

Let's say you love to travel but do not like business travel. Could you find a way to combine those two things and improve your work/life balance in a way that allows you to love your job more?

Once you have done this exercise, now move to the “Must-Nots.” This is a related but different exercise. There is some overlap, but here, you are going the next level down. Maybe you know that you love media and would love to work for a streaming company in a marketing role that requires little travel.

2: THE MUST-NOTS EXERCISE

1. **Pair up with a different member of your JSC.**

2. **Interview each other about what you do *not want*.**

When you are paired up, interview each other about all the things you do *not want* in your next job. For example, you might say that you don’t want to manage more than 10 people, you don’t want a boss who micromanages, etc.

3. **Use what I call the “bad bosses” prompt.**

If you are having any trouble getting your partner to articulate “must-nots,” then ask them again about past roles — “Have you ever had a bad job or a bad boss? If yes, what did that teach you about what you do *not* want in a boss, culture, etc.?”

4. **Review your lists with each other.**

The irony of inverting and looking at the negative is that it’s a positive and fun experience.

We’ve done two inversion exercises so far in this chapter.

Let me pause before the next exercise to say a few words about the power of inversion, because it’s a great thinking tool that I’ll use throughout the book (and that I’ll encourage you to use throughout your career).

INVERSION EXERCISES

“Invert, always invert”¹⁸

— Carl Gustav Jacobi

Jacobi was a 19th-century German mathematician who made fundamental contributions to elliptic functions, differential equations, and number theory. Importantly, he was also known for his commitment to turning things upside down to understand tough problems. I first learned about Jacobi through reading the speeches and writings of Charlie Munger.

For my last book, *Customers Included*, I applied Jacobi to the design of the 300 book talks I gave.

At every one of these talks, the attendees were expecting me to address how to make a good customer experience, which, of course, I was there to do. But I also knew that, if I wanted to help them understand how to make a good customer experience, then I should start with focusing on how to make a terrible customer experience.

So, I began with an inversion exercise.

I asked the audience, “If you want to guarantee a terrible customer experience, what would you do?”

They loved it.

They leapt out of their seats with answers.

Everyone *knew* how to create a bad experience.

I then showed them that their knowledge of how to create a *bad* experience was a terrific road map for how to create a *good* experience (knowing what not to do can sometimes be more important than knowing what to do).

In order not to *fail* at each step of your job search, you have to be able to *invert* your thinking. Doing so allows you to look at things from a new perspective, see things you might not have thought of, have empathy for others in new ways, come up with creative solutions for challenges you face, and rediscover what you already know.

Relative to the Mnookin Two-Pager we are creating in this chapter — if you take inversion seriously and try to enumerate everything you do *not want* (or *hate*), then you will also clarify some key aspects of what you *do* want or your “must-haves,” which is what we’ll focus on next.

3: YOUR MUST-HAVES

Most job seekers tend *not* to think about their Must-Haves, especially if they are out of work.

That's a mistake. You'll want to go through the process of determining your must-haves.

So, with the same partner from the second exercise, run through these steps.

1. **Review your Must-Nots.**

Begin this exercise by reviewing your partner's Must-Nots from the last exercise. Again, these can be a road map to your must-haves.

2. **Invert the Must-Nots into Must-Haves.**

Then help your partner invert their Must-Nots into potential Must-Haves. For example, if a Must-Not is "frequent travel," then a Must-Have would be something like "travel no more than once a month."

3. **Each separately refine your Must-Haves.**

Then you should each review the first pass on your Must-Haves that your partner created for you, and make any edits or changes.

4. **Present your Must-Haves for Discussion.**

Then return to your partner and present your Must-Haves for discussion and feedback. Discuss each item. Ask what might be missing or should be edited.

4: YOUR CAREER GOALS

Look over the results of the three exercises above, and then sit down and ask yourself, "What kind of job do I want now and in the long run?"

Do you want to get promoted from Director of Product to VP of Product?

Do you want to become a Chief Operating Officer or a CEO?

Whatever the answers are, write down both your short-term career goal (i.e., what kind of job do you want next) and your long-term career goal (i.e., what you want eventually).

Don't worry if you are not sure what your short- or long-term goals are.

At this stage of Social Search, I recommend you put down two or three ideas for your goals *unless* you are crystal clear on what you want.

Take, for example, Sonya.

Sonya is a Director of Product who has worked at several high-growth software startups.

While creating her Mnookin Two-Pager, Sonya identified two to three short-term career goals, including Group Product Manager (GPM) at a bigger startup in an adjacent industry, a Senior Product Manager at a big consumer tech company, or independent startup consulting that she would do on her own for 12 to 18 months.

In the long run, Sonya hopes to be either a GM, CEO, co-founder, or venture partner, and any one of these short-term options could work for her to get to that eventual goal.

So, she included all her three short-term and three long-term goals in her Mnookin Two-Pager.

Eventually, after doing a Listening Tour and getting input from others, she decided she wanted to focus on looking for a GPM role at a bigger startup.

CREATE YOUR MNOOKIN TWO-PAGER

Now with the results of these exercises having been completed, you can create your Mnookin Two-Pager.

Remember, your Two-Pager will have four sections: (in whatever order you prefer)

1. What you love and hate doing
2. Your “must-haves”
3. Your “must-nots”
4. Your career goals (short-term and long-term)

Bring your Two-Pager to your next JSC meeting, and share it with everyone else. Ask for additional feedback, and read everyone else's.

Once you have shared your Two-Pager and gotten their feedback (and learned about their Two-Pagers), you are almost ready to begin your Listening Tour, where you can discover your Candidate-Market Fit.

First, however, let's do several things in Chapter 5 to prepare you for your Listening Tour.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

- Download the Mnookin Two-Pager Templates and Examples
- Complete your four-part Mnookin Two-Pager exercise.
- Create a draft of your Mnookin Two-Pager to take out with you on your Listening Tour.

TOOLS AND TEMPLATES

Mnookin Two-Pager Templates and Examples

(Available on my author site: PhylTerry.com)

Get this template, which includes several example two-pagers from other job seekers.



CHAPTER 5

GRATITUDE HOUSE

In this chapter, I will go over a few more ways to prepare for your Listening Tour.

I begin by exploring an important issue.

You may be wondering who you should speak to during your Listening Tour.

To help with that, I recommend you complete an exercise I call Gratitude House.

GRATITUDE HOUSE

This exercise is designed to do two things: 1) help you think about people to talk with during your Listening Tour; and 2) improve your confidence and mood.

As I pointed out in Chapter 1, research shows that when you thank people for the help they've given, you make them happy, and they want to help you even *more* — and you make yourself happier and more confident.

Remember, managing your emotional balance is critical to running a good job search.

So, with that in mind, here are the simple steps of the Gratitude House exercise:

1. Find a quiet place.

Sit down with pen and paper in a quiet place with no distractions, no screens, phone off.

2. Reflect.

Ask yourself: Who has helped me along the way? What did they do?

3. Make a list.

Write down names, approximate year, company, team, or other context, and any other details you remember.

4. Note anyone who has a great network or can be helpful to you.

Everyone in your Gratitude House is important, but do note those who can be more helpful to you during your job search. And then, when we get to your Listening Tour, we'll focus on those first to reach out to.

5. Write thank-you letters (on paper), but do not send.

The final step is to write unique letters to each person who has helped you in the last decade or two, but don't mail them. Not yet. Some of these will be people you can ask for help in your job search, so you don't want to send a gratitude letter followed two weeks later by a request for help. Instead, keep the letters ready to send at the end of your job search.

That's it.

One job seeker told me that he thought writing these thank-you letters might be too much work.

"It is work," I told him, "but it's worth it."

He called me back a few days later and said, "You were right. Writing these letters improved my state of mind."

Yes!

This exercise expands your mind, quiets your inner critic, and reminds you how much you rely on others. By reminding you who has supported you and how much help you've gotten along the way, this exercise will also help you see that you are bigger than your insecurities and that lots of people care about and root for you.

This exercise will also show you that you have always had a community of support, and recognizing that will improve your confidence, which is always in short supply during job searches.

Finally, this exercise acts as a first step in identifying people you can reach out to for your Listening Tour. In the next chapters, I'm going to give you assignments to "discover" how the market views you and what others see as your options (and whether your career goal is attainable now or what the path might be to achieve it).

But again, for many the question is: who to go speak to? The Gratitude House exercise will help you build a list.

Let me switch gears and say a few words about listening and about follow-up before I ask you to begin your Listening Tour.

LISTENING

First, remember that the Listening Tour is a way to learn from the marketplace how you are perceived and what your "fit" might be.

Again, this is not networking. This is user research on yourself as the "product."

The most important thing you will need to do throughout your Listening Tour is *listen*.

Show each person you talk to that you are willing to hear whatever they want to say about the market and about you. This is challenging, as well as enlightening. I'm asking you to leave your ego behind and get curious.

In some cases, you will *not* agree with what you hear from the various Listening Tour exercises I provide in the following chapters.

The goal is to understand, not necessarily to agree. Those are two different things. So, focus on listening and understanding what each person says.

And not every person's opinion is important. They might have had an atypical experience.

Remain curious, open, and focused on understanding.

Your demeanor and facial expressions should reflect that. Be friendly. If you feel defensive or upset about anything anyone says, then know you will have time with your council to reflect on what you are being told (and what to listen to, as you'll see in Chapters 6, 7, and 8).

Again, you are not looking for right or wrong, nor for agreement. You are listening and understanding.

This is not easy. You will need emotional support, as well as a third-person, dispassionate ear to hear what is said.

That's part of the role of your JSC. They will help give you the emotional equanimity you'll need to do this, as you'll see from the stories I share in the following chapters.

FOLLOW-UP

After every conversation you have in your Listening Tour, send a thank-you note *and* add that person to a regular update that you'll send out.

Here's a simple two-step follow-up process:

1. **Send a thank-you note.**

Right after the conversation, reach out and thank them. Cite some specific things they said, and then let them know you'll keep them updated. See my book website for some sample thank-you notes (and update notes).

2. **Update everyone you've spoken to.**

Every month or quarter, you should send an email to everyone you have met with.

The biggest mistake job seekers make is to *not* send thank-you notes *and* not update the people they've met with. Updating deepens relationships and strengthens your community of support throughout your job search and beyond. It's also part of living a life of service to others.

One Director of Marketing read this and, for the first time, started doing follow-up notes after every conversation she had during her job search. She was surprised at how important this simple step was. It not only directly led to a job through her grateful and excited network, but it's still paying off in former potential hiring managers now wanting to work for *her*.

Updates can include just simple observations or that you have figured out "a" and "b" but not yet "c." Or, if you are working while doing this exercise,

you can even say that you have been too busy to take the next step but that you plan to do so soon.

The update does *not* need amazing information. It's quick, to the point, and is a way of continuing to include them in your journey. And even if you don't hear back right away, you've shown gratitude by keeping them posted and thanking them along the way.

A former employee of mine, Kristen Kmiec, who impressed me with her self-motivation and dedication to continuous learning, decided she wanted a new job *but not with me* (primarily because we are a remote company, and she no longer wanted to work from home).

I coached her on getting her next job. And then on how to navigate the environment there so she could continue to challenge herself. She has done well.

The point of this story is not, however, that you should always ask your boss for help finding a job outside your current company (that does not work in many situations).

No. The point is that Kmiec is good at updating me, asking for help each step of the way, and including me in her journey.

In fact, after a few years at her next job, she ended up switching to a high-tech company during the pandemic. And for that job search, she again asked for help from me and others.

And I reminded her that by doing so she's bringing *me* great joy.

Let's now move to the next chapter and start your Listening Tour by asking former colleagues for their perspective on *you* in Reverse Exit Interviews.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

- Complete the Gratitude House exercise.
- Write, but do not send, thank-you notes to people you list.
- Use your list of people from the exercise as the starting point for your Listening Tour.
- Download sample thank-you and update notes.

TOOLS AND TEMPLATES

Sample Thank-You and Update Notes

(Available on my author site: PhylTerry.com)

View sample thank-you and update notes.



CHAPTER 6

REVERSE EXIT INTERVIEWS

Now you begin your Listening Tour.

I'll ask you to start with a "Reverse Exit Interview."

Look at your Gratitude House list. Do you have a former colleague or boss that you worked with either recently or in the last several years?

Then set up a time to talk with them. Bring your Mnookin Two-Pager and ask:

1. "What did I do well?"
2. "What could I have done better?"

Then ask detailed clarifying questions.

Try to do 3–5 of these conversations.

Prioritize first people from your Gratitude House list, especially those with stronger networks or who you think can be helpful.

If you are out of work, you can set up one or two conversations a day. If you are working, you will have to spread them out more.

I first learned this simple but effective exercise more than a decade ago from CG member David Krauter, Director of Customer Experience at then-startup SmartBargains in Boston.¹⁹ When he announced he was leaving to join

TripAdvisor as a Senior Director of Product, he turned around and asked his SmartBargains colleagues for help.

He simply said, “How could I have been a better leader here?” and “What can you tell me that I can improve upon in my next job?” In other words, he conducted what he called a Reverse Exit Interview.

Companies will often do exit interviews to learn from their employees who are leaving. Krauter reversed that so he could do the learning himself.

It’s difficult to get honest feedback from colleagues. 360-degree feedback can be helpful, but often participants mask their real thoughts. By not uncovering hard truths, those formal feedback mechanisms can leave leaders even more lonely and unclear about how they are perceived.

There are, however, a few key moments when colleagues are willing to be frank with you. After you’ve announced you’re leaving, or after you’ve left, turns out to be one of the very best moments for honest feedback. The internal politics are minimized, the people you ask for feedback are often pleasantly surprised, and, as per previous discussions, honored to be asked.

So, you get great insights for your job search *and* deepen your relationships with your former colleagues.

When Krauter did this, he learned an important lesson that no one had yet been honest enough to tell him: he needed to get much better at prioritizing.

A colleague said:

You’re smart. You work hard. You get a lot of stuff done, but you fight for everything, and you need to start picking your battles because they all don’t matter as much as you think they do.

Krauter applied that advice, and it “allowed me to open many more doors” and eventually to run a 300-person division at TripAdvisor. Today, Krauter credits that 2008 reverse exit interview with contributing to his “continued success,” including helping him “care less about being right and more about being effective.”

Melanie Penna, Senior Vice President, Human Resources Operations at Comcast, shared that a senior leader left several years ago and did some reverse exit interviews. “It was the first time in our culture I’d ever experienced a leader doing that, and it impressed me, because, in this case, he had been fired.”

Penna told me that after it was announced that this person was leaving (and everyone knew that it was not voluntary), “he doubled back and asked several of us ‘What could I have done differently?’” Penna found this “courageous and self-aware . . . he could easily have packed up his belongings and just headed out and blamed us and the culture.”

I asked Penna if this person was open to honest feedback.

She said, yes, he was, even though she gave him some frank feedback. For example, she told him that he had “messed up” in part because he “didn’t know his own team . . . didn’t know anyone’s name beyond his direct reports.” She also told him that he had “underestimated the power sources within the company and didn’t take the cues of where decisions get made.” Finally, she noted that this leader was “brilliant and ahead of their time . . . if they had been patient and worked the culture differently, it could have been a very different outcome.”

One of the benefits of doing this market research at the beginning of your job search is that it will give you practice in seeking feedback that you can use later, after you’ve landed your next job. That will help you avoid the mistake this person made in being impatient and not listening to his colleagues.

CG members will often ask me if they can do these reverse exit interviews even years after leaving a job. The answer is yes. Our brains and memories are built to remember people and social situations so you can get good insights even years later.

Reverse exit interviews can even apply when you are looking for a new job *inside* your company.

For example, in 2002, Beth Comstock was a VP of Corporate Communications at GE and was being considered for the Chief Marketing Officer role. As part of that process, and before Beth understood she was a candidate for promotion, GE did an exhaustive six-month interview process with her team. “They interviewed 30 people with whom I had worked, both inside and outside the company. They went deep,” said Comstock. In other words, they conducted the reverse exit interviews for her.

When she got the report, she was shocked. “The negative part of the report said that I didn’t ask for help and went it alone too much.”

At first, she didn’t believe it. One of the benefits of doing the reverse exit interviews yourself is that it’s harder to dismiss the feedback when a colleague is

talking to you. Though she didn't do the interviews herself, Comstock decided she had to listen.

In fact, she went one step further. She went back to her team and told them, "Thank you for this feedback. I accept it." And then she said the magic words: "I need your help."

This was a "career-defining moment" for Comstock. There were problems with her personal brand that she had not been aware of until that point. Acknowledging those issues and working on them led to her promotion to Chief Marketing Officer.

In retrospect, she said, "I am not sure I would have gone further in my career if I had not listened."²⁰

There's an important caveat, however, that I must warn you about.

Not every conversation will go well. Some may be demoralizing and hit your emotional balance sheet hard.

Again, this is where your Job Search Council is important. They can help you hear the feedback and figure out what the valuable nuggets are — and give you some more of that *real* hope.

Armen, a COO at a publicly traded bank, helped form a JSC with other senior leaders looking to make their next move. His first Reverse Exit Interview was with a former boss at a credit card company, whom we'll call Bob. When Armen asked Bob what he could have done better, Bob said that he was a "Type B" personality and was not "aggressive" enough. He was too laid back, which is not a good fit for most companies.

This was hard on Armen emotionally.

He did not think of himself this way, and it started to make him feel that maybe his whole career had been misguided. In a conversation I had with him, I could hear the confidence leak out and see the liabilities pile up on his emotional balance sheet.

Fortunately, he was not searching alone; he brought this story to his JSC and asked for their help to understand the feedback.

The group had a great conversation about it.

One member thought that Bob was wrong about Armen and perhaps had an old score to settle.

“This is ridiculous feedback, Armen. You have a PhD from Harvard in astrophysics, you did a successful stint at hyper-competitive consulting firm Bain, then you spent the last decade rising in financial services to eventually becoming the COO of a publicly traded bank. None of that happens by being laid back.”

Several others agreed, reminding him that not every conversation is worthwhile. Some feedback you have to throw out.

Then the newest member of the group, Cynthia, added something helpful.

“Maybe the takeaway here — the nugget of the truth — is that you should be more thoughtful about the culture and environment of your next job; that perhaps you would do better at a company that has less of a cutthroat environment.”

Pow!

This conversation helped Armen go from thinking his whole career might have been a mistake to instead discovering something positive and helpful in what Bob said.

And Armen’s fellow members got the confidence boost from being helpful.

It’s remarkable how a simple 10-minute dialogue in a JSC can change a sense of hopelessness into insight and energy to move forward.

SHARE YOUR MNOOKIN TWO-PAGER

At the end of the Reverse Exit Interview, share your Two-Pager.

A talented digital marketer, Kerty, recently did some reverse exit interviews and, in one case, a former colleague, Jane, seemed to have an ax to grind that had nothing to do with her. That clouded the interview, but, at the end, Kerty shared her Two-Pager and, to her surprise, received some helpful feedback.

Jane pointed out that she thought there was a disconnect between Kerty’s goals (get a startup job) and her preference for work-life balance. This made Kerty rethink her focus and led eventually to a new approach. She decided, in part because of this conversation, to focus on privately held, family-run companies that needed digital transformation help. And that eventually led to a great job.

So, at the end of your Reverse Exit Interview, share your Two-Pager, and ask these questions:

1. What do you think of this Two-Pager?

Do you think my Two-Pager is a good description of me — i.e., is it accurate in terms of what I'm good at and enjoy — and what I don't like? Is there anything missing? (Note: this question is only for people who know you well).

2. Career Goals?

What do you think of my short-term career goals? Is there any one of these (if there are multiple) that you believe I'm a better fit for? Or where there's a greater market demand? Or both? And is there anything else going on in the market — any trends or new roles, etc. — that you think I would be a fit for?

3. Who else?

Is there anyone else I should talk to? This last point is key because you will need help to keep expanding your network as you run your Listening Tour.

Finally, I recommend that you keep a journal of detailed notes from every conversation.

And after each of these interviews, take note of what they say, thank them orally, send a written thank-you note, and keep going.

You will review these notes several times, including, importantly, when you get to finalizing your Candidate-Market Fit statement in Chapter 9.

Keep in mind that listening to the market is a constant and iterative process. Just as in doing customer research you will learn and sometimes adjust your thinking right in the moment.

So, if one of these interviews clearly changes your thinking, go ahead, and update your Mnookin Two-Pager, which is what Kerty did (from the example above) after she spoke to Jane and realized she was focused on the wrong kind of job.

Meanwhile, let's continue this process by now moving to a different kind of conversation: the Golden Question.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

- Set up one to three Reverse Exit Interviews.
- Complete at least one of those interviews.
- Send thank-you notes to each person you interview.
- Continue to send periodic updates to everyone you've spoken to along the way.



CHAPTER 7

THE GOLDEN QUESTION



Your Listening Tour continues now with the “Golden Question,” one of the simplest, yet important exercises that I’ve done to help job seekers figure out their Candidate-Market Fit.

What is the Golden Question?

It’s simply this:

If you were in my shoes, how would you approach this job search?

That's it.

You ask them to walk in your shoes. You put them on your side of the table. You ask them to see the world from your perspective.

This question leads to a much richer conversation than if you were to simply ask: what kind of job should I look for?

And it's fun for you and the person you ask.

For your Listening Tour, I recommend you do at least 3–5 of these conversations with a range of people in your network. Start with people from your Gratitude House list.

Also, consider including 1 or 2 whom you do not know well.

If your network is small, ask each person you speak to for introductions to more folks you can speak to (as we discussed in the previous chapter). Keep in mind that you can also ask your JSC for help. Do they have people they know that they could introduce you to?

For those who are out of work, these interviews can be scheduled fast over the course of a week. If you are working, you'll have to spread them out (unless you decide to take a week off, which is something I recommend).

And remember that asking the marketplace for help can be a roller coaster: surprising, exciting, and sometimes emotionally hard. Stay in close touch with your JSC as you go through these conversations. Ask for help! Share what you are learning. Get their help to keep you balanced.

Finally, I know you are feeling pressure to get out there and interview *now*.

Urgency is important, especially if you need income. But you should temper that urgency with a willingness to invest in yourself and do this research on your Candidate-Market Fit.

It's worth it.

In fact, this approach is so powerful that it's even helped underemployed poets.

Take, for example, Heather Fisher-O'Neill.

Fisher-O'Neill is a smart, well-educated poet, writer, and adjunct teacher. Fisher-O'Neill and I first met in one of her writing workshops. A year after the class, she reached out to me to ask for help.

She and her wife were getting divorced, and she had a problem. She was certain she'd have to leave New York because her income as a poet and part-

time writing teacher was not enough to raise two children in Brooklyn. But her whole life was in New York, and she wanted to stay.

Fisher-O'Neill knew about my mission to help leaders build great careers.

So, we met at Brooklyn's Four & Twenty Blackbirds, one of New York's best pie shops, and after getting a slice of their fantastic salted caramel apple pie, we sat down to talk.

Fisher-O'Neill explained her problem.

If she were going to stay in New York, she would need to make more money, and she had no idea what kind of job she could get that would pay better.

In other words, she had to switch careers.

I went over everything in this book, and Fisher-O'Neill turned out to be good at asking the Golden Question.

AGENDA FOR GOLDEN QUESTION SESSIONS

Here's a quick agenda for these Golden Question sessions.

1. Context on yourself.

Provide context on yourself. Say a few words about your career and how you are doing research to understand where there might be job opportunities for someone like you.

2. Ask the Golden Question.

Then ask: "If you were in my shoes, how would you approach this job search?" And resist the temptation to say a lot after asking this. Be quiet. Listen. Let them think and reflect.

3. Share your Mnookin Two-Pager.

At the end of the meeting, share your Mnookin Two-Pager, and ask the same questions I advised you to ask at the end of your Reverse Exit Interviews.

- a. What do you think of this Two-Pager?
- b. What do you think of my short-term career goals?
- c. Is there anyone else I should talk to?

Remember, some answers you may decide to disregard, but the key is to take everything in and see the patterns in what they all say. And to let their answers help you understand the way the market sees you.

Years later, as I was writing this book, I circled back to Fisher-O'Neill to talk to her about the exercise.

First, she told me that, initially, she had been hesitant to follow my advice.

She was hearing the same internal voice many job seekers face — e.g., “stop dilly-dallying around and get your resume out as soon as possible.”

“I was thinking, I’m a successful poet. I have a graduate degree, and I’m a mother of two. Why should I do all this work, including going out to do research on myself? I should know what to do, and, further, I don’t have time to go talk to 15 people. I just need to get my resume out there.”

Because of her trust in me, however, she decided to slow down and try this process.

Quickly, she discovered that doing this market research was remarkable and surprising.

Asking the Golden Question like this disarms people and gets them engaged in helping you.

Each of the first three people she interviewed mentioned something called *long-form copywriting*. Fisher-O'Neill did not know what that was but jotted it down.

Then, when she was meeting with one of her private students, an interesting thing happened. Her student made a passing comment about long-form copywriting. As the teacher, Fisher-O'Neill would not typically ask a student for help, but she was getting more practiced at asking for help, and so she decided to pause and ask.

Not only did the student explain long-form copywriting, but she offered to connect Fisher-O'Neill to a senior leader at an advertising agency that hired long-form copywriters for special projects.

Pow!

This conversation led directly to a completely new Candidate-Market Fit that she would never have come up with on her own.

Yes!

Fisher-O'Neill discovered she could use her terrific writing and editing skills to get long-form copywriting jobs, which she had no idea existed and turned out to pay well.

Wow!

She would never have gotten this insight if she had skipped the Listening Tour and gone right to doing interviews.

So, Social Search took several short weeks *and* led her directly to a career she would never have pursued because she didn't even know it existed.

Today, Fisher-O'Neill is living in New York, has remarried, publishes new poetry, teaches part time, but also juggles multiple corporate clients who pay her to write their annual reports and other long-form materials.

Further, all the people she met with during her Listening Tour are still active members of her community of support. In fact, she can trace all her current work and key relationships today back to Social Search.

While she's doing better financially than she ever imagined, that's not the best part.

I asked her, *What could possibly be better?*

"I've learned how asking for help and building a village of support can be a way of life, and that has changed everything for me, including finding great jobs and making me happier."

Well said. That is part of my goal here. As I mentioned in Chapter 1, I want to help you get a job *and* help you get better at asking for help, which will help you go further in your career than you might have thought possible.

CAUTION — DANGEROUS CURVES AHEAD

Keep in mind, like with Reverse Exit Interviews, not every Golden Question conversation will be a good one. Some are duds, while others are mixed.

For example, take DD, whom we first met in the Introduction.

DD had master's degrees in both computer science and in data science and had been a Chief Data Officer at a midsize publicly traded company. She left that and went to work in private equity. Two years into that, she left after discovering she did not like the PE world.

But since then, she had been getting interviews but no offers.

We spoke a year into her job search, and I recommended she set up a JSC and start a Listening Tour. She did that, and, in meeting eight of her JSC, she brought the results of one of her Golden Question exercises. This conversation was with a friend of a friend who was now in a similar job as one that DD might eventually want. And, even better, he had just finished his own job search.

They met via Zoom, and when she asked him what he would do if he were in her shoes, he didn't answer the question. Instead, he bluntly blurted out, "You are too poised. You need to relax."

His tone was aggressive and dismissive at the same time, and DD felt hurt.

One of the challenges of doing a Listening Tour is that sometimes you get feedback that's not helpful.

After working with thousands of senior-level women, I hear all the time that they are either "too poised" or "not poised enough," that they are "too casual" or "not casual enough." I rarely hear any of these things about men.

So, yes, when you do the Listening Tour, you open yourself up to this kind of feedback blurred by sexism, racism, or other forms of bias. That's, in part, why you have a JSC. Like we saw with Armen in the previous chapter, you will need your JSC's help to interpret what you hear.

After DD shared her story, one of the JSC members said the following:

"There might be a kernel of truth here, but before we get to that, I just want to acknowledge that the tone and way he said it does sound hurtful. Further, and ironically, the business world tells women that they are often not poised enough. That's likely the message you've received your whole life, especially given what you shared about how you grew up (DD had grown up in a commune with hippie parents and didn't get formal schooling until college)."

Others agreed, and a woman in the group added:

"I find that men often use a different tone with women. They often unintentionally operate as if they can say whatever to us in whatever tone. I could imagine that, if you were a man, and Bob had had similar feedback, then he might have said, 'Look, you have an impressive background, amazing education, and experience. I might suggest you relax a bit. You come across as

too formal. Be a little more informal if you are open to that.’ And I think that you would not have felt hurt had he said it that way.”

As I said, I have heard stories like this play out many times in the job search, and it’s why job searching can be even harder for women, people of color, and LGBTQ+

That’s why I recommend everyone get a JSC, and when we get to the interviewing chapter, I talk a lot about how to figure out 1) the culture of your potential employer, and 2) how to do backchannel research.

But that comes later. Right now, we are focused on seeing what we can learn from the marketplace about our fit.

With that in mind, one other woman on the JSC had an interesting response that helped uncover a nugget of truth and gave DD more hope.

“Perhaps because of both your hippie childhood and of institutional sexism, you may overcompensate, and, perhaps, that can come across as overly formal. That’s the seed of the truth in his feedback that might help in your job search.”

DD laughed and readily agreed.

Then, with the asset side of her emotional balance replenished, she decided to get back out there and, importantly, talk to some recruiters, which is what we’ll explore next.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

- Set up one to three Golden Question sessions.
- Complete at least one of those sessions.
- Send thank-you notes to each person you interview.
- Continue to send periodic updates to everyone you've spoken to along the way.



CHAPTER 8

RECRUITERS

The next step of your Listening Tour is to speak to recruiters, including, depending on your focus, venture capitalists and private equity executives who recruit for their portfolio companies.

And remember, the job of listening and learning from the marketplace never ends. As you network, interview, negotiate, and start your job, you will continue listening, learning, and iterating on your understanding of the market, and of your Candidate-Market Fit.

But to finish this Listening Tour, you must go speak to recruiters.

Try for at least one good recruiter conversation. It's better if you can speak to two or three.

However many you speak to, you are going to ask them questions that few ever ask.

Recruiters are accustomed to being asked for help in transactional ways during job searches. But they are not accustomed to being asked for their objective expertise.

As a result, when you ask a recruiter these questions below, they are often thrilled to be asked (finally) for their expertise and judgment in an open way. They feel honored and trusted, and they usually have fast and very accurate answers.

The only problem with this step is that *many* job seekers have not cultivated relationships with recruiters during their careers. As a result, they have no one to call.

This is a big mistake.

If you are reading this and you are not yet looking for a job, then the next time you get a recruiter call, take it, and, if you don't want the job, help them find another candidate. Cultivate that relationship. You'll need them in the future.

If you are now in the job search and do not know any recruiters, then your best bet is to see if your fellow JSC members can share a recruiter contact with you (or perhaps a former boss, colleague, etc., can help).

Again, I also recommend you consider asking anyone at venture capital (VC) or private equity (PE) firms that you may know. One of their biggest jobs is to recruit for their portfolio companies so you can ask them the same questions I suggest for more traditional recruiters (and they may often have a direct lead for you).

In fact, VC and PE firms increasingly have "human capital partners" who want to talk to job seekers in the hopes they can be of use to the portfolio. They also have people in operating/consulting roles, which at times help find talent.

Once you find a recruiter (or a VC or PE person) to speak to, tell them that you are at the beginning of your job search and you do not yet know what kind of job you want, but that you'd like some advice and input. Make it clear you are not asking them for a job, but for their hard-won experience to help you understand how the market might see you.

Simply share your Mnookin Two-Pager and then ask . . .

In your opinion, what kind of jobs . . .

1. . . . **could I get tomorrow with no effort?**
2. . . . **might be possible but would be a stretch?**
3. . . . **would be out of my league?**

That's it.

In general, I find that recruiters *love* being asked these questions.

Typically, few job seekers ask for their insights like this.

Instead, many hound them to get a job for them or complain that they are not getting a certain kind of job.

But I seldom see anyone step back and simply ask for the recruiter's hard-won expertise.

So, recruiters love this, and then, because they know the market so well, they sometimes give you your Candidate-Market Fit.

Take for example, Walt.

Walt was a Chief Product Officer for media companies, and he wanted to move into a President role outside of the media world.

He spoke to a recruiter, Martin, shared his Mnookin Two-Pager, asked the recruiter questions, and discovered there were several issues.

First, Martin pointed out that the language in Walt's Two-Pager was abstract.

Walt said he was looking for "human-centric companies" and wanted a "leadership role where he could effect change."

Martin said he didn't know what that meant and certainly that it did not focus the search.

Second, Martin said that if Walt wanted to move into general management, then he should stay in the media industry where he could best leverage his network and experience. Then once he had a senior role in that industry for several years, then he could more easily move into a role outside of media.

Pow!

Walt revamped his Mnookin Two-Pager and, after a few more conversations, went right to the exercise in Chapter 9: crafting his Candidate-Market Fit statement, which now was simple, focused (and non-abstract).

I'm looking for a President or GM role in a midsize media company that wants to leverage my product management skills to help them build their digital business.

Without Martin's advice (and other people's, including members of his JSC), Walt could have looked unsuccessfully for a long time.

Fortunately, however, Walt did not search alone and instead got advice and help that helped him shape his Candidate-Market Fit and then led directly to *three* offers within a few weeks of this conversation with Martin.

These are the kind of results I've been seeing for years from job seekers. They slow down at first to do research on their Candidate-Market Fit so that they can eventually get a better job *faster*.

I'll note that while this success was great for Walt, it was also great for his JSC. They saw what happened when he took the time to understand the market and figure out a Candidate-Market Fit.

And when he got the offers, that bolstered everyone's confidence.

In fact, another member of the JSC, Antoine, had also looked for a year before joining the group.

He had participated in each step of the process but had been reluctant to ask a recruiter for help. He wanted a CEO role, and he was afraid the recruiter would tell him that he was not yet ready for that. After several CEO interview processes, none of which resulted in getting an offer, and after seeing Walt's experience, he finally went and spoke to a recruiter.

Here's what the recruiter said after he asked the three questions:

Thank you for asking. No one has ever just come out and directly asked me questions like this. I have reread everything you have shared with me, and with you promising not to take this as gospel, and with that major proviso, here goes!

What kind of job could you (or another recruiter) place me in tomorrow with no sweat?

All future-facing "thinking" roles — strategy, business development, in a nutshell, figuring out what the issue is and how to tackle it. Whether for a brand-new offering or reconfiguring an existing business. Understanding the market and the competitive set and the trends. You have a fantastic track record there.

What's a stretch?

I may have this one wrong, so forgive me. Roles where you would be the Chief Revenue Officer, across sales and marketing, for example. Where you are fully accountable for the profitability of a business. This could be CEO roles, etc. I think you'd certainly be viable, but you'd be up against people with deeper

track records in that space. It would depend on what the client was seeking — someone with fresh eyes, strategy to bring, etc. and a reworking of an existing business (you) or someone who has run big sales teams for 20 years (less you!).

COO roles — I think you are feasible, but it always depends on the profile of the CEO, and, ideally, you'd want to work with someone who had a complementary skill set to you. Also — COO covers a lot of ground; it can range from very operational (legal, finance, HR, etc.) to strategy and business building. I think it would depend on what appealed to you at the time.

What's out of my league?

Probably the high-creative, editorial roles, where it is all about the content. I could see you having this responsibility reporting to you but not see you in the weeds, so to speak.

Hope that helps!

Sally

He was very excited to share this feedback with his JSC and almost immediately landed several interviews with several companies hiring “thinking” roles, as Sally outlined in her answer to the first question.

Note that she did not rule out Antoine getting a CEO role. But what she said (and she didn't know about his failed prior attempts) perfectly explained his frustrating attempts.

Her answers motivated him. It was helpful to have a clear view of the market that also reinforced his Golden Question and Reverse Exit Interview discussions and his own personal experience trying to get a new job.

The best part is that, within weeks, he had a great offer for a job that fit.

Next, we'll take everything you've learned from your Listening Tour and do the hard work of crafting that cozy little box that I call your Candidate-Market Fit.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

- Set up one to three recruiter interviews
- Complete at least one of those interviews.
- Very important: *If* you are not looking for a new job yet, then immediately start cultivating relationships with recruiters. *Do not wait until you start looking.*
- Send thank-you notes.
- Continue to send periodic updates to everyone you've spoken to along the way.

STEP 3

Form Your Candidate-Market Fit

	Step 1 JSC	Step 2 Listening Tour	Step 3 Candidate- Market Fit	Step 4 Networking/ Interviewing	Step 5 Negotiate	Total Time
Full-time job seekers (i.e., those unemployed)	1-2 weeks	2-3 weeks	1-2 weeks	4-8 weeks	1-2 weeks	2+ mos
Part-time job seekers (i.e., those still employed)	2+ weeks	4+ weeks	2-3 weeks	4+ weeks	1-2 weeks	4+ mos



CHAPTER 9

CANDIDATE-MARKET FIT

Everything we've done so far has led to *this moment*, where we create your Candidate-Market Fit and compare that to your short-term career goal. If the two are aligned, then your strategy is simply to follow the rest of the steps in this book.

Sometimes you get a wonderful surprise and find out that your Candidate-Market Fit is better than your goal. Think of Fisher-O'Neill from Chapter 7.

But what if you learn that your goals might not be reachable yet?

A goal, hope, or aspiration is *not* a strategy. Strategy is *how* you achieve that goal, hope, or aspiration.

You may set a goal to be a VP of Product, a CEO, or simply to find a better job, but the question is *how* do you do that?

If you *learn* that your goal may not be reachable right away, but do not *adjust*, you can spin your wheels for months or years. This kind of disconnect is one of the biggest reasons job seekers fail to find a good job.

So, keep in mind that Social Search is *not* about helping you do the impossible.

Rather, it's about finding the best *possible* job for you *today* given your goals, skills, experience, and what the market wants now.

Take, for example, the story of Robert.

ACCEPTING REALITY

Robert, a senior executive of a traditional media company, had real trouble when he tried to find a job at a tech company after being laid off. Robert worked on his Mnookin Two-Pager and decided he wanted to leave the media industry and bring his skills in general management or product management to a pure-play technology company.

But as he did his Listening Tour, he discovered that his experience from that old-style New York media environment was not highly valued by tech companies in California.

Instead, Robert learned that his Candidate-Market Fit meant that at best he could seek a lower-level product manager role in a prominent high-tech company.

So, what did he do?

With the help of his JSC and of the Social Search methodology, Robert decided that his strategy would be to go ahead and take a lower-level product job for a few years until he could gain the credibility in Silicon Valley that would allow him to get promoted back into a higher-level role.

As you might imagine, this multi-step strategy was not easy to embrace.

He had previously run a team of hundreds, been paid very well, had limousines at his disposal, traveled first-class, and worked from a spacious private office. If he returned to an individual-contributor role, he would lose all that, at least temporarily.

Note he could have chosen a different strategy. For example, he could have given up on his goal of going to Silicon Valley, and instead looked for another job at an old media company. In that case, he would have been able to get a higher-level job, but he would have left behind his dream of moving out of that industry.

Recall that, in Chapter 8, we talked about Walt, who wanted to get a President-level role outside of media. A recruiter, however, helped him see that it would be much more difficult to get that job in an industry where he had no experience or network. So, Walt decided to stay in media where he could get a C-level role immediately.

Robert, however, decided he did very much want to get out of media and into technology.

So, his JSC helped him put his ego aside, and take a junior product manager role for a very successful Silicon Valley company.

Several years later, after proving himself in that role, he was, indeed, able to get a great offer for a higher-level role from another tech company. While he's in a great spot now, he could never have executed this difficult strategy alone.

This is not an unusual situation. As more job seekers leave their jobs voluntarily than ever before, more people are looking at the same moment that the job market is having trouble matching candidates with good roles.²¹

Your Candidate-Market Fit tells you what kind of job you can get today.

It does not guarantee that you can immediately get to your career goals.

Robert wanted a senior-level role in high tech, but he could not initially get there. His approach was to take a junior-level role, gain credibility, and then get a new, higher-level job.

Or take another CG member, Andy.

When Andy reached out and told me he wanted a COO role with a midsize software company, I suggested he set up a JSC and follow what I describe in this book.

He declined. He said he already had a goal to become a COO and that he simply needed to get out there and interview a lot.

As we've previously discussed, this approach to job searching can be quite frustrating.

Yes, many job seekers can *get* interviews. But without a clear understanding of Candidate-Market Fit, many end up like DD in the Introduction — interviewing but getting no offers.

Andy did decide to do *one* element of Social Search: he reached out to recruiters he knew. But, to his frustration, most did *not* think he was ready for the COO role.

Instead, he was told that he should go for VP of Product or VP of Strategy jobs, and then, once inside a company, he could move into a GM role. After a few years of GM experience, he would then have a shot at getting good COO roles.

That would have been an effective multi-step strategy for Andy that reflected the reality of the job market at that moment.

But he didn't want to hear it.

Listening to the market does not mean that you will necessarily get the answer you want. Quite often, it's the opposite. You may find out that your goal is beyond your current market fit.

That may *sound* demoralizing, but please don't take it that way. Try to distance your ego from this feedback; it isn't meant personally. Take it in the way it is intended: it is intended to be helpful, realistic, practical, and, most importantly, to help you find a real way to *get* to your dream job.

Thus, doing this work with the support of your JSC can create the conditions for hope that's more grounded in reality.

Andy had to learn this the hard way.

He ignored the market's message that he was not ready yet to be a COO and, instead, went out and interviewed with 50 companies, including early-stage startups, turnarounds, and later-stage high-growth companies.

That's a lot of interviews.

This took 18 months.

18 months of not working and not making money.

None of those 50 offered him the job.

Then, he met the 51st.

It was a publicly traded, fast-growing software company whose stock had gone from \$30 to \$150 in a year, and he was very excited about it.

And they offered him a COO role.

Great, right?

A good example of setting a goal and then meeting it, right? Who needs to do a Listening Tour to figure out Candidate-Market Fit?

If he had been in a JSC, they would likely have asked, "Are there any red flags? Have you done any research?" (We'll go over this in Chapter 12.)

Sadly, he had chosen to search alone.

And since he was alone, he did not do a sanity check on this offer with anyone.

So, he accepted.

Then, 10 days after he started, the SEC announced an investigation. It turned out there was fraud. The company's stock tanked, and he quickly left.

When we later discussed what had happened, he said:

I didn't want to hear what the market was telling me. I was dead set on getting that COO role, and, as a result, I pushed aside all the red flags about

their bad culture and never questioned why they were the only company willing to offer me a COO job.

Creating a realistic strategy is possibly the most difficult part of the job search. Andy's goal was to become a COO, but, again, a goal is *not* a strategy. A goal is a destination; strategy is how you get there.

After this bad experience, Andy did agree to slow down and accept his Candidate-Market Fit.

He took a VP role at a large software company. Last year, he was promoted to a GM role. And his plan now is to stay in that role for two years and then look for a COO role in a smaller software business.

Yes!

That's a great example of how to use market insight to devise a way to realistically achieve your goals.

While writing this chapter, I spoke to a digital consultant — we'll call her Melissa — who had, earlier in her career, run marketing and product development at several Internet companies. Now her goal was to get a co-founder role in an early-stage, well-funded startup. And while she got interviews, she did not get job offers.

I asked her what she had learned on her Listening Tour. She told me that many had warned her that early-stage startups were not going to value her years of consulting and that her previous startup experience was too long ago and held less credibility.

Further, they warned there was a lot of ageism and sexism in Silicon Valley that would work against her, which helped to explain some of her recent interviewing experience.

She could get interviews in early-stage startups, but no offers.

What offers could she get?

Recruiters had told her that consumer packaged-goods companies going through digital transformation might find her a compelling candidate.

The problem there, though, is that pre-digital companies — “legacy” businesses — often have a lot of internal politics and bureaucracy.

So, Melissa had to decide: was she willing to put up with the dynamics of a legacy business, or did she want to keep trying with startups? Maybe she'd find the rare startup that valued her.

Eventually, Melissa decided to look for medium-sized, privately held Internet companies that did not have venture capital backing and were not “rocket ships” but reasonably run businesses that needed some new thinking about how to grow.

And that led directly to a great job, which she accepted as I was finishing writing this book.

Recently, a VP of Sales at a large Internet media company reached out to me. He had spent his whole career in media sales, and he wanted to become a CEO. Yet when he asked recruiters for advice, they told him it would be very difficult to get a CEO role.

Like Andy in the earlier story, Bill decided to ignore that and just go out and do a bunch of interviews.

After many conversations, he got an offer from a private equity (PE) firm to turn around one of their troubled portfolio companies. He asked if they would give him incentives that would kick in if he were successful. They said no. He was getting the standard CEO package. So, he called to ask for my advice.

I explained to him that non-traditional CEO candidates like him do not get offered good CEO roles. That is not their Candidate-Market Fit.

Instead, they often catch “falling knives” — i.e., turnaround situations that have little hope of success (and which experienced CEOs would not touch).

In fact, a strategy for becoming a first-time CEO is to accept an offer like this. The reason is even if the company fails, future job offers will typically be only for CEO roles. It turns out that investors prize CEOs who have gone through hard times.

So, that’s a viable strategy, but it does require a willingness to go through a bad experience of running a failing company first. That takes an emotional toll that most cannot handle. It drains the emotional balance sheet.

I asked Bill if he thought he could handle that.

He said no.

You need to figure out *how* to get to the job you want. To do that, you need to know how the job market sees you. You may not like how they see you. Andy wanted a COO role right away. He was not happy that it became clear that the only viable strategy to get there was going to require several years. Melissa wanted a startup co-founder role but had real trouble finding

one. Bill wanted a CEO position right away, but the only viable strategy was to accept a “falling knife.”

Not only do candidates have to come to terms with market realities, but they must make hard decisions with trade-offs when determining their Candidate-Market Fit.

CREATING YOUR CANDIDATE-MARKET FIT STATEMENT

Once you have done your Listening Tour, then creating your Candidate-Market Fit statement takes no more than two weeks if you are out of work (again, it could be longer if you are balancing a full-time job).

You take the combination of what you want and what the market wants and make a hard decision:

Take Cynthia, a senior in college looking for her first full-time job.

She went through her Listening Tour and figured out several important things: 1) she wanted to be in healthcare; 2) she wanted to be in consulting, initially (so she could work with a range of healthcare companies); and 3) she did *not* want a big firm.

Importantly, Cynthia could have gone for consulting roles at large firms like McKinsey, Bain, or BCG. She was top of her class and could have gotten an interview and probably an offer.

And, if she had done that, her offer would have been for more money. So, she had a hard decision to make: did she want more money, or did she want her first job to be at a company with a better fit — where the culture and healthcare focus would be more aligned to her goals?

Cynthia smartly decided — with the help of her JSC and Listening Tour — to focus on the boutique healthcare-oriented firms.

So, her Candidate-Market Fit statement, honed after two years of internships and research, was simple: look for small healthcare consulting firms with a great culture.

Cynthia’s statement then directed all her marketing, communication, and networking.

As a marketer of you, you do not want to present a muddled message with multiple different possibilities. Instead, you should focus and synchronize everything like Cynthia did.

Like Cynthia's above, the best Candidate-Market Fit statements can be said in a phrase and certainly not more than a sentence, and, again, here's the hard part for most people: these statements put your candidacy inside a clear box that provides direction to you, your network, and to your potential employers about the best jobs for you.

Here are some examples of Candidate-Market Fit statements:

- Find a Chief of Staff role in a medium-sized financial services institution
- Find a VP of Communications role in an artificial intelligence startup with a social mission
- Find a VP of Marketing role in a medium-sized, privately held company *not* backed by venture capital or private equity
- Find a VP of Product role in a larger company, and then move into a GM role once inside, and then, after two years, find a COO role in a startup (Andy's eventual strategy after he failed to find a good COO role)
- Find a product manager role in Big Tech, work there for a few years, and then go back out with that new addition to the resume and find a senior-level product role at another tech company

So, to figure out your Candidate-Market Fit, pair up with a partner and run through the 90-minute exercise below.

PAIRED CANDIDATE-MARKET FIT EXERCISE

1. **Pair up with a member of your JSC who has also completed their Listening Tour**
2. **Present findings — especially whether your goals and Candidate-Market Fit are in alignment**
Present your Mnookin Two-Pager, your key career goal, your notes/journal, and what you learned about your Candidate-Market Fit. Include any notes on the disconnect between what you may want (your career goal) and what the market sees for you today.
3. **Brainstorm a one-sentence statement**

Run a simple brainstorming session. If you aren't familiar with some simple brainstorming techniques, then the firm IDEO has some great brainstorming resources online here:

<https://www.ideo.com/pages/brainstorming> (or just search for “IDEO brainstorming”). If you are meeting with your JSC partner via Zoom, then I also recommend you consider using a tool like Mural, which can make brainstorming easy.

4. Outline a multi-step strategy if you can't get to your goal right away

If your goal is out of reach right away, then figure out a multi-step strategy to get there the way that Andy did in the story above.

5. Switch

Now do the same three steps for the other member.

6. Bring your potential statements to your next JSC to present

If your strategy is not as obvious as in some of the examples I've shown, then perhaps plan on holding a few sessions with your JSC partner.

Whatever you do, avoid fluff, jargon, or abstract words.

Make your statement concrete and focused, like the examples above.

Sometimes your statement will be multi-part, like it was for Robert. More often, however, it will be focused just on the role you are looking for now.

You will know you have a good statement when it's simple and focused enough for just about anyone to understand — and, if it acts as a guardrail to guide you in what you should or should not be looking for.

Once you've created your statement — and multi-step strategy, if relevant — then you are ready to move through the rest of the Social Search process.

As you go through the remaining chapters, stay focused and disciplined. Don't just take the first thing that comes along if it does not reflect your Candidate-Market Fit and the other important elements of your Mnookin Two-Pager, especially cultural considerations.

At the same time, if you learn new insights about your Candidate-Market Fit, then run those by your JSC to see if what you are hearing will impact your search (or if it's just noise in the marketplace).

Let's now synchronize your LinkedIn profile and resume to your Candidate-Market Fit.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

- Draft your Candidate-Market Fit statement.
- Complete a paired exercise helping one of your fellow members improve their statement (and vice versa).
- Finalize your statement before you rehab your LinkedIn and resume in the next chapter.

TOOLS AND TEMPLATES

Good Strategy/Bad Strategy by Richard Rumelt.

This terrific book is worth reading in full. It will help you understand what a good strategy is and is not — and apply that now to your job search and throughout your career. In Chapter 12, I will ask you to read Rumelt's third chapter about bad strategy to help you identify potential employers to avoid.

IDEO's Brainstorming Resources

<https://www.ideo.com/pages/brainstorming> (or you can search for "IDEO brainstorming").

Mural Whiteboarding Tool

Look it up at [Mural.co](https://mural.co).



CHAPTER 10

LINKEDIN/RESUME SYNCH WITH CANDIDATE-MARKET FIT

Most job seekers need help with their LinkedIn profiles and resumes. These are your most important pieces of marketing collateral.

But the help should come only when you've developed your Candidate-Market Fit statement.

The conventional job search *starts* with working on your resume and LinkedIn. But, as we've seen, that makes no sense. You do not yet know the intersection of what the market wants and what you want.

But that's not you. Now you know your Candidate-Market Fit and are ready to focus your LinkedIn and resume on that.

Everything on LinkedIn — your "About" section, your job descriptions, your posts — must synchronize with and reflect your Candidate-Market Fit.

Let's be clear: recruiters search LinkedIn. They run filters. If you don't have the attributes they are looking for, then you won't get found. Like with consumer products, you never should lie. But you need to make sure that you position yourself to be found. Synchronize your skills and experience to the job you are looking for.

One job seeker I worked with, Maslyn, wanted to find a VP of Marketing role. The problem, however, is that her profile showed almost no marketing experience.

If you had spoken to Maslyn, she would have told you that in her non-marketing jobs, she was also in charge of marketing. But that was nowhere on her profile.

And it kept her from being found by recruiters, and from being seriously considered by any employers who did find her (one hiring manager dinged her in about 30 seconds, even though I explained in the email that she had done marketing work).

It's just plain hard for most people to update their own LinkedIn profile and resume.

We all tend to see ourselves through a distorted funhouse mirror, which makes working on our own profile hard.

At the same time, however, we can see others very clearly, and we can easily edit *their* profiles and resumes.

That's the basis of the "LinkedIn/Resume Rehab" session.

LINKEDIN/RESUME REHAB SESSION

Pair up with a fellow JSC member, and do the following. Start with your LinkedIn profiles, and then follow the same process for your resumes:

- 1. Together, read the example of a LinkedIn Rehab Session below**
- 2. Then share each other's Candidate-Market Fit statements and Mnookin Two-Pagers**
- 3. Then take a quick look at both profiles**
Pull up each profile, and look at it together. Make general comments. Be open and vulnerable. And be gentle. In other words, use the listening and relationships skills you honed on your Listening Tour.
- 4. Pick one partner to go first**
- 5. Together, go to their profile, and examine each section**

Start with the “About” section; then go through job titles, job descriptions, advisory boards, boards of directors, etc.

Ask your fellow JSC member questions like:

- “How does this language reflect your current Candidate-Market Fit?”
- “Please describe your current job and scope in the plainest language possible (look out for company-specific or even industry-specific jargon — the less jargon, the better)”
- “Do these descriptions of past jobs accurately describe you and your skills/experience? If not, what is missing?”
- “And how about previous jobs?”
- “Do you have internal (or external) peers of yours whom you respect and whose profiles we could look at to compare?”

6. Make editing suggestions

For each section, write down suggested edits in the simplest, clearest language possible. Again, see detailed example below.

7. Then, switch, and review the second partner’s profile

8. Final step: after you complete your LinkedIn rehabs, then do the same thing with each of your resumes

EXAMPLE OF A LINKEDIN REHAB SESSION

For a recent LinkedIn Rehab Session, I invited Sally, who works at one of the five big tech companies, and Brett, who works at a large tech company but not one of the big five. (Note: both names are pseudonyms, but the quotes and issues come directly from this session.)

They both are in senior management roles that did not exist before cloud-storage services and before the proliferation of subscription-based business models. Further, neither had updated their LinkedIn profiles in at least 10 years.

After quick introductions, we went to LinkedIn and took a quick look at each profile.

“I’m embarrassed by this. It’s so out of date,” said Sally.

“It looks like I’ve had the same title and same role for the last eight years,” said Brett. “But I’ve had six different roles at six different levels, from the time I was a junior product manager to SVP today.”

You might be wondering why senior leaders would have out-of-date profiles and why they might be embarrassed. Just update it, right?

Well, as I mentioned above, it’s a little more complex than that.

It’s hard to see ourselves, and most of us find it nearly impossible to effectively update our own LinkedIn profiles.

We took an in-depth look at Sally’s profile with Brett in charge.

He started by asking questions.

He asked Sally about her current scope of work and about her job title. He thought it seemed way too junior to reflect her scope of work.

Sally agreed and explained that her company has title *deflation*, which means that her title does not adequately communicate the scope of her role.

So, Brett decided to focus on that first and suggested we look at the LinkedIn profiles of some of Sally’s internal peers who have the same problem and see how they handled it.

Sally suggested one person, and so she and Brett went and looked at that person’s LinkedIn information.

They found a single word on that other person’s profile which better communicated her scope of work.

Then he turned to Sally’s “About” section.

Sally had a long “About,” but it had been written more than 10 years earlier and had nothing to do with her current role.

So, Brett asked Sally to just talk to him in plain English to describe her current scope of work and range of experience.

Sally answered.

But it was hard at first to understand what she was talking about. She was using too much internal jargon.

“We need to talk about what this is rather than the labels, which mean less outside your four walls,” said Brett.

That carried a lot of weight with Sally. Brett was not some random person. He was a peer who couldn’t understand what she was saying.

Sally responded by describing her job in plain English.

After Sally helped him better understand her role, Brett then reviewed several “About” sections from her peers and found one who seemed to have a

compelling yet simple “About” section.

Brett found one he liked, copied their language, and then added, “I might even use this phrase in my profile.”

Having taken these steps, Brett started to draft Sally’s “About” section.

- He got specific.
- He removed words that were over-the-top — i.e., hype or jargon-laden language (unless the jargon was spot-on to the strategy and to the language recruiters might use).
- He pointed out that he had seen some profiles that were so exaggerated that they were a total turnoff. It hurt rather than helped credibility.
- He adapted effective language from other profiles.
- He avoided jargon and instead used standard words.
- He focused on words like well-known product names, channels — web, mobile, etc. — and common business-model names (note: this is important for several reasons, including because search plays a big role in how LinkedIn works; therefore, choice of words should be in synch with current search terms).

And, in about 10 minutes, Brett came up with an improved “About” section that described Sally well.

It is *so* much easier to edit a peer’s profile than to do your own.

“That is a great ‘About,’” said a relieved and happy Sally.

Then we turned to Brett’s profile, where we faced a different problem with his title.

Brett had an SVP title — but of what? At the time, he had a new role in his current job that was hard to communicate, and he and his HR team had not yet come up with a good title.

This is where Sally came in. Because her role was like Brett’s, she knew the language and where to look for examples at other companies, including her own. Within 10 minutes, Sally had looked at the titles of internal and external peers of Brett’s and had come up with a good title for him to run by HR to use on his LinkedIn.

She then worked on Brett’s “About” section.

In just one hour, Sally and Brett had rewritten each other’s LinkedIn profiles.

You might be thinking, *This all sounds good, but why not simply hire an expert to do it for you or tell you what to do?*

Obviously, you can do that. There are many LinkedIn experts and articles to read on this subject. They can certainly be helpful.

But there are several limitations.

LinkedIn experts may have some general expertise about LinkedIn, but many will not know your job. So, they don't have the specificity that a peer can bring.

Working with a trusted peer on your council relieves anxiety about how to improve your profile, for several reasons: 1) you tend to trust peers because they have walked in your shoes; 2) you discover you are not alone in having trouble editing your LinkedIn profile; and 3) editing each other's profile gives both of you greater clarity and confidence.

Peers can be fast. Bringing two job seekers together to rewrite the *other's* profile is delightful, effective, and fast.

The same is true for your resume.

While most of the job seekers (or hiring managers) I work with no longer use resumes and primarily rely on LinkedIn, it's still smart to have a good resume prepared.

In fact, you need two resumes: 1) the Internet Search Bot version and 2) the in-person leave-behind version (also often used as email attachments to direct contacts).

YOUR RESUME

Using the Rehab exercise outlined above, you and your JSC partner should have created a resume that reflects your Candidate-Market Fit and compels the interviewer to remember you after you have left their office.

Note that this should not be a flashy, colorful document, but rather a serious, professional document filled with achievements and outcomes (just like your LinkedIn profile).

THE INTERNET SEARCH BOT RESUME

Some readers may want to create a version of their resume that works with Internet search bots. These are used for posting on online job boards.

Keep in mind that most jobs, 87% according to one source, come through networking.²²

Having said that, you may elect to post your resume online.

If you do, then get the latest advice on best practices in making your resume search bot readable (go to sites like TheLadders.com for good advice).

You'll learn how to optimize your Internet search bot resume to be found via keyword algorithms that seek word combinations specific to job postings.

One recommendation many experts make is to “overstuff” your resume with repeated instances of the critical functional words that describe your skills and job functions, including titles and work outcomes (similar to what I'll ask you to do with the “Job Mission” in Chapter 12). Keywords and outcomes will help the bots push your resume to the top of the pile.

I am deliberately restricting my comments here on how to create an effective resume for the bots because it's not my expertise. Most CG members find their next jobs through their networks and not through automated resume screening. Chances are that will be true for you as well. Nonetheless, there's a lot of good advice online for how to gear your resume to being found via these kinds of tools.

Further, as a reminder, my main recommendation throughout the book is recursive: ask for help. If you keep asking for help at every stage, you will get the support you need, including here with your resume.

Once you have updated your LinkedIn profile and resume, synchronizing them to your Candidate-Market Fit, you are now finally ready to move to where most job seekers typically start: networking for a job.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

- Run your LinkedIn/Resume rehab session with a fellow JSC member.
- Optionally consider asking a recruiter to review your LinkedIn profile/resume for any additional suggestions.

TOOLS AND TEMPLATES

LinkedIn editing tips

Google editing tips for your LinkedIn profile. LinkedIn is constantly changing its algorithm, and experts are constantly updating their recommendations for improvements to LinkedIn profiles.

Resume resources

Consult this guide — *The Ladders: Ultimate Resume Guide: Your Guide to Making a Professional Resume that Matters* — <https://www.theladders.com/resume>.

STEP 4

Start Networking and Interviewing

	Step 1 JSC	Step 2 Listening Tour	Step 3 Candidate- Market Fit	Step 4 Networking/ Interviewing	Step 5 Negotiate	Total Time
Full-time job seekers (i.e., those unemployed)	1-2 weeks	2-3 weeks	1-2 weeks	4-8 weeks	1-2 weeks	2+ mos
Part-time job seekers (i.e., those still employed)	2+ weeks	4+ weeks	2-3 weeks	4+ weeks	1-2 weeks	4+ mos



CHAPTER 11

NETWORKING

Now we finally turn to where most people *start* their job searches.

You, however, have set up a JSC, conducted a Listening Tour, crafted a Candidate-Market Fit, and updated your LinkedIn and resume.

You are ready.

Networking, and then interviewing, which we will cover in the next chapter, will likely take you two to eight weeks, depending on job-market conditions and the quality of your Candidate-Market Fit (i.e., if you've identified a real market need that you can fill).

Everything you have done up to this point has been designed to make your networking and interviewing efficient and effective.

You have done the research on yourself and on the market, and created your Candidate-Market Fit. In the process, you strengthened your network by running the Gratitude House exercise and then going out and asking your network for help. You've also been updating them along the way and priming them to turn into listening posts for you if job opportunities come their way. You have updated your LinkedIn profile so that, when recruiters or employers learn about you, they can quickly see why you'd be great to speak to.

Keep your mind open to continuously discovering new things about the market and about yourself. Determining your Candidate-Market Fit is a non-linear and recursive process that continues throughout your whole job search.

With that said, let's start networking.

Networking is critical to finding a job. That's why most job-seekers want to jump in and get networking right away without doing the self-research first.

As mentioned earlier, most new jobs are found via networking, not through online sources. And many of these jobs were *not* even *listed* online. This is the "hidden job market."²³

The work you did on your Candidate-Market Fit was not just to help you focus, nor was it just to help potential employers understand you. Importantly, it was also done to help your network understand you better and find appropriate jobs for you *faster*. This is where that work can pay off. And this result holds true for nearly all the success stories I have shown in this book.

In other words, your network becomes a force multiplier to find you the opportunity that fits you best. The work you've already done to strengthen your relationships (through the Listening Tour, thank-you notes, and regular updates) and craft your Candidate-Market Fit mean that lots of people are ready to act as "listening posts," helping identify opportunities. As a result, you'll get more leads and *better* leads because they know what to look for.

Recall the story of DD, who I first talked about in the Introduction and then referenced several times in the Listening Tour section of the book. She spun her wheels for a year without a clear understanding of her Candidate-Market Fit. Once she had that, she had two job offers within two weeks, in part because her network knew with clarity what she was looking for.

The first rule of finding a good job in the hidden job market is to figure out your Candidate-Market Fit. The second rule is to network, network, network (but not before figuring out your fit).

I could write a whole book just on the art of networking.

Fortunately, I don't have to do that because Karen Wickre has already written *the* book: *Taking the Work out of Networking*. Her book, which began with a blog post that went viral, was written for *introverts*, which means it works for introverts, extroverts, and everyone else.²⁴

Among other things, Wickre talks about how to request "warm" introductions, as well as how to reach out to people without any introduction or connection. These will be key parts of your networking process, as we'll review below.

I'll quote from her in several of the following chapters, but take my advice: get her book, and read it along with mine. And remember, as part of your Social Search, you are always looking to learn from and leverage the wisdom of others. So, keep your eyes out for other sources of good tips and advice on networking to find your job. For example, as I'm writing this, Tik Tok is emerging as a vehicle for networking for younger job seekers.

The first step for you and your JSC is to create what I call the "Megibow Dashboard" — this is a simple Google Sheet that will help you track everyone's activity.

THE MEGIBOW DASHBOARD

Joe Megibow, a longtime CG member, joined a JSC for CEOs looking for their next gig.

When they reached the stage of networking and interviewing, Megibow and his fellow members realized that they needed a way to encourage and track their activity. They discovered it was important to always be doing two things: 1) setting up new future meetings; 2) conducting meetings.

The challenge was that they each would get busy with having meetings and forget to schedule more. As a result, they would swing from busy weeks to quiet weeks. And quiet weeks not only slow the process down but demoralize everyone.

So, he built what I now call the Megibow Dashboard that helped to keep them all accountable to scheduling new meetings while also conducting meetings (Note: See PhylTerry.com for the template).

There are five activities you'll track in the Megibow Dashboard:

- Outreach — Any email or message initiated by you, including warm and cold introductions, updates, follow-ups, etc., to a recruiter, target company, or networking person, with the intent of supporting your job search.
- Scheduled — Any new meeting with a person in your network, recruiter, or company individual that has been formally scheduled on your calendar.
- Networking call — Any call/Zoom meeting/in-person meeting with someone from your Listening Tour, or from your network/industry who is neither a recruiter or at a target company, nor related to active work or consulting.

- Recruiter call — Any call/Zoom/meeting that occurred with an independent recruiter.
- Company call — Any call/Zoom/meeting that occurred with a representative (e.g., board member) or employee at the target company.

Once you have your Megibow Dashboard set up, I encourage you to use another tool created by an early reader — a spreadsheet that I now call “Jeff’s Opportunity Screener.”

JEFF’S OPPORTUNITY SCREENER

This tool is designed to help you evaluate opportunities against your Candidate-Market Fit and Mnookin Two-Pager (and for those still working — against your current job).

So, go download this free tool on my author website, and personalize it.

Then as you network and potential jobs come your way, fill out the rows to help you figure out what to consider and, even more importantly, what to ignore.

One of the most important benefits of Social Search is helping you pass up jobs that do not fit. Discarding those will free up time and energy better used investigating the jobs that you may really want.

Having introduced these two tools, let’s now start the actual networking by updating the people you spoke to during your Listening Tour.

UPDATE YOUR LISTENING TOUR

Reach out again to the same people you identified during your Gratitude House exercise as well as those you ended up meeting with during your Listening Tour (note: you may decide *not* to meet again with a few of them because the conversation was tense or not helpful).

The main difference between this conversation and the earlier conversations during your Listening Tour is that, now, you have a strategy and are focused on finding a job that fits that focus. You’ll use the Golden Question but in a new way, *and* you’ll ask for specific information on networking groups and on anyone in their networks they can introduce you to who can help you find a job.

Here are the steps you should take:

1. **Send an end-of-listening-tour update/request for another conversation**
Thank them again for their help, tell them about your Candidate-Market Fit, and ask if you could arrange a phone call or coffee.
2. **When you meet . . .**
Thank them again for their help, reiterate what your strategy is, and then ask the Golden Question again but in a slightly different way. Ask: “If this were your Candidate-Market Fit, how would you approach finding such a job if you were in my shoes?”
3. **Be curious and open-minded**
Ask questions to better understand their answers. And remember, listening well and being curious does *not* mean *agreeing*. You do not have to agree with everything they say. But you do want to understand it.
4. **Ask them for any networking groups they think you should join**
Do they know of industry associations, online groups, etc. that are relevant to your Candidate-Market Fit? Or, if you went to (or are going to) the same college, ask if they have used any student/alumni job-placement/assistance services.
5. **Ask them for people they think you should talk to**
And, of course, ask for people they know you should talk to who can help you. And with anyone they refer, ask if they can make a *warm introduction* (see below for the details of how to do that).
6. **Ask them to act as a listening post**
With your Candidate-Market Fit clearly articulated, you have made it easy for them to be a “listening post” — i.e., to keep you in mind for jobs that fit your focus.
7. **Ask them about target companies**
Ask them to help you build a target list of companies that align to your Mnookin Two-Pager and your Candidate-Market Fit.

TARGET COMPANIES

Create a list of target companies that align with what you are looking for. And, as noted above, ask your network for recommendations of additional companies to add.

JOIN EVERY RELEVANT NETWORKING GROUP

While you are meeting with your Listening Tour folks, join every relevant-to-your-strategy networking group on Slack, LinkedIn, Twitter, Facebook, etc. There are even old-fashioned ones that meet in real life.

Also, find out what your college or graduate school can do to help. Note that most colleges now have *free* online (and offline) job-placement services for students and alumni. Typically, you can find out everything you need from the relevant section of your college's website. Go check to see what your college or graduate school offers.

Consider subscribing to services like TheLadders or ExecThread, or anything suggested by your JSC and through your conversations. And, again, keep your eyes and ears open for new networking groups, online or off.

If you are like me and don't love networking, then: 1) read Wickre's book, *Taking the Work out of Networking*; and 2) rely on your JSC to support you. Your JSC will give you the hope, motivation, accountability, and energy to keep getting out there.

THE ART OF ASKING FOR WARM INTRODUCTIONS

One key to better networking is to get better at asking for warm introductions.

Karen Wickre, in her aforementioned book, *Taking the Work out of Networking*, writes at length about how to ask for or make warm introductions. Chris Fralic, a venture capitalist at First Round Capital, does the same in a *Forbes* article he wrote and in an interview we did for this book.²⁵

They both suggest avoiding making or receiving cold introductions. In other words, the introducer should always ask permission to connect you from both parties *before* making the introduction.

Let me say this again.

If someone offers to introduce you to some third party, ask them if they would get that person's permission first — and then, if and only if that third party agrees; then your contact should send an introductory email. This is a warm introduction, and it makes a huge difference.

I have noticed a simple pattern regarding cold vs. warm introductions.

Anytime someone introduces me to a third party without getting my permission first, it's almost always someone I do *not* want to talk to. On the other hand, when I am asked first, then it's almost always someone I *do* want to talk to.

And, importantly, with a warm introduction, context is provided. The worst networking connections are where neither side is exactly sure why they have been connected.

So always ask for warm introductions, and realize that, if the introducer (the person you are asking) does not want to make a warm introduction, then there's an increased risk that the third party (the person you want to be introduced to) will not want to meet with you. Just keep that in mind.

BASICS OF WARM INTRODUCTIONS

1. Ask the introducer to ask the third party first (and do not cc you)

If you are the one *requesting* an introduction, then make sure the person you ask — we'll call them the *introducer* — first obtains permission from the third party you want to meet.

2. Optionally, you may offer to draft a note.

You can offer to make it easy for the introducer by first sending them a draft email in their voice for them to consider, edit, and ultimately send to the third party. If you go this route, you can let the introducer know that you won't get their voice right and that they should edit it, but you wanted to send something they could work from. Keep the draft note *short* and warm.

3. Ask the introducer to connect you once the third party says yes

Then the final step — assuming the third party agreed — is for the introducer to send a simple introductory email connecting you and the third party.

Rob Schmults, General Manager at venture capital firm Blockchange Ventures, is a “big believer” in good warm introductions, especially when there's some shared context.

I'm a big believer in how valuable these can be. But to activate them, I generally need the right set of attributes from a job seeker. If I get the usual "I want to work with smart people at an interesting company doing something in marketing," then I'm not interested. But if I get the Goldilocks level of approach — i.e., not too much about the unique fit, but just enough to get my attention — then that's where I have a much higher hit rate of a useful connection.

But what if the introducer does not want to make a warm introduction?

You can suggest that it's typically better for the third party if they get their permission first, but, of course, you'll follow their lead.

What if you want to talk to someone, but you have no one to introduce you to them?

That's what we'll explore next.

THE ART OF REACHING OUT COLD

If you don't know someone who can introduce you to a person you'd like to talk to, then you can try to reach out cold.

Keep in mind that many people never respond to cold contacts. I nearly never do. Nor do most of the CG members.

But occasionally, I hear a story of someone who got through this way, as you'll see below.

I asked Marian Rich, the founder of ImprovNetworking, what she would recommend. Rich has combined her 20 years of experience as an executive recruiter with her many decades of work as an actress and improv comedian to create a more playful way to network than the traditional approaches.

She suggests the following tips when crafting an email to a cold contact:

1. Know what's important to the person

First, Rich suggests doing what all great improvisers do — know what's important to them, especially if it reflects exploring who they are. "Get off script, and look for something *about them* that you guess they have never heard before." Attention to detail (which feels like appreciation), says Rich, is a wonderful way to be giving to another person. What do you see that you appreciate on their LinkedIn profile — i.e., a way they

turn a phrase in their profile, something about their photo, their schooling, their interests, a person, or company they follow.

2. Be curious

Her second direction is to follow your curiosity. Being curious, says Rich, is an underutilized activity in getting to know someone. As you know, I've emphasized curiosity throughout Social Search. Rich reminds us to not make assumptions but, instead, to make a discovery. Be curious as you look at the person's LinkedIn profile, and see what you can find to play with. What can you discover in their LinkedIn profile that might not be an obvious thing about the person you want to approach? Also, what do they tweet about or write about on Medium if they have a public presence?

3. Be playful

Then, when crafting your email, you can be appropriately playful, using something you discovered. Ask an open-ended question, starting with "How?" or "Why?" Try to go beyond the scripted ways we typically connect with others.

This is Level 1 of the art of making a cold contact.

There's a second level, however, that takes more work and can be more effective.

Wickre's book recommends this second level. It's like Rich's method but with a key twist: figure out what's important to the person you want to meet *and then be proactively helpful to them.*

Let me say that again: figure out how to be helpful to *them.*

Andres Marquez Lara, the Founder of Promethean Community, practices this second level of networking.

I interviewed Marquez Lara in 2019, when he was in Bangladesh speaking at the Frugal Innovation Summit. A Venezuelan, Marquez Lara was there to organize support for the millions of Venezuelan refugees who have fled the Maduro regime. In 2011, Marquez Lara started doing something that Wickre would write about and that Professor Adam Grant would popularize as the "5-minute favor." He would constantly look for what he could do for others that would be meaningful for them and relatively easy for him.

I started listening closely to people and thinking about what matters to them and how I can help them — whether through an introduction, sending them a link to research, or other simple-for-me-to-do favors that matter to them.

Investor Whitney Tilson did the same thing in the 1990s, when he first began building relationships with Buffett, Munger, and others in the financial community. Tilson constantly thinks about others and what he can do for them in terms of articles, introductions, or other easy-but-helpful favors. In the early years, for example, he would send Buffett an article about once a month that he guessed Buffett might enjoy and may have missed.

Over time, he added to those kinds of easy favors by starting an annual holiday cookie tradition. For two decades now, Tilson has baked cookies for Buffett and Munger every Christmas. It's a sweet and charming thing for him to do. Importantly, Tilson never accompanies these favors with a request for them to do anything for him. He's simply sending small gifts.

Readers of this book should take inspiration from Marian Rich, Andres Marquez Lara, Karen Wickre, and Whitney Tilson, and start being creative in your cold-contact networking.

For example, a college student — we'll call her Tanisha — had wanted to work for an up-and-coming hip-hop label in the recording industry.

It's very hard to break into that industry, and Tanisha had no network in the industry.

So, while she was still in college, she reached out to a range of labels and introduced herself. She even smartly reached out to non-music companies in the broader entertainment industry, thinking that, once she got into entertainment, she could move into music (a two-step strategy like Robert followed in the Introduction and again in Chapter 9).

She either received perfunctory answers ("Sorry, we have no openings") or did not hear back at all.

She graduated, and she still had no real leads.

But here's the thing: she *kept* reaching out for *years*.

And, even more importantly, she built herself a JSC made up of friends and family who gave her the moral support and encouragement to continue.

In the meantime, Tanisha took a job in the healthcare industry, doing a job in PR that she didn't like much, but which paid the bills and allowed her to continue at night and weekends to try to break into the recording industry.

Over time, one label sent warmer responses, though they had no openings.

So, she sent them monthly updates that were friendly *and* insistent. That's key: she was not bitter, angry, or upset. She was insistent about a job, but she was insistent in a professional and friendly way.

Recall my words in Chapter 1 about how to ask for help. Tanisha proved to be the mature young person who constantly did her homework, thought about interesting things to say and ask, and kept asking for help throughout the process.

Importantly, early on, one record company executive responded to her request for help and agreed to conduct a Golden Question conversation.

That conversation proved critical. She had been writing to record labels and telling them she would do any job. He disagreed with that and told her *not* to tell labels she would do “anything,” but, as I've said, find a *focus* or “cozy little box.” So, she chose marketing as her focus.

Then, after monthly check-ins with the one label that was responsive, they called her and asked her to come in for an interview.

In her first interview, the record-label executive said to her, “You are getting this interview before we post the job because your emails were persistent without being annoying.”

Wow.

She had *shown* them what a good marketer she is of herself — how friendly *and* insistent she was — and, as a result, they believed she'd be good at marketing their label.

Tanisha had asked for help and gotten the support to slowly change her Candidate-Market Fit.

Most would have given up or not tried. And she would have without the support of her informal JSC.

Learn from Tanisha, especially if you want to break into a business where there are high barriers, and you have no prior experience.

Be persistent. Be patient. Ask for help from everyone you can. And build a support group around yourself.

And certainly, no matter what you do, follow up.

FOLLOW UP

As mentioned in Chapter 5, I find that many people are inconsistent in their thank-you notes and often negligent in providing ongoing monthly or quarterly updates to those they've spoken to during their Listening Tour.

The whole point of Social Search is to be *relational*. This is *not* just about getting a job. It's about building friendships and trust and a village of support around you. It's about tending your garden of relationships as Paula Kerger, President and CEO of PBS, explained to me.

Kerger is constantly cultivating and paying attention to her network, which has been key to not only getting great jobs, but also to becoming, according to many, the most successful CEO in PBS history.

And remember: you will want your network to support you again down the road.

One prominent venture capital investor told me the following:

There is one person I helped get a job that there was no way he ever would have gotten without me. I was not close to this person in any way but was happy to help. They, however, never even let me know if it worked out, much less thanked me. How likely am I to help again?

So, let me lay down the rules again:

1. Send a thank-you note after each networking session

Thank them for their help, and say something specific about what they said to you.

2. Send a regular update

Keep everyone updated monthly or quarterly on your progress. This will bring them joy. And it will sometimes bring you added help.

3. When you do get a job, tell them, and thank them for their help

When you do get that job, of course, reach out and thank each person individually. You will bring enormous joy to them when you do. This literally sprinkles more happiness in the world. And you might become a client, a resource, a partner, or a source of a new job for them. Remember Heather Fisher-O'Neill's story from Chapter 7. The people she worked

with during her Listening Tour continue to be a great source of both friendship and jobs for her.

And don't stop once you've begun working. Do as Kerger does. Do as Tanisha did.

Keep tending and cultivating throughout your career.

Social Search is a lot of simple, everyday steps. It's not a big bang or grand gesture. It's sending a thank-you note or a quick update. And it's remembering that you should never walk, or search, alone — and that, by asking others to walk with you, you are helping them as well.

And by the way, these same people may ask you for help and advice at some point, so this is not just a one-way street. You will likely have the joy of returning the favor to them.

KEEP ITERATING

Keep listening, and keep iterating on your Candidate-Market Fit and on your strategy throughout your whole search. As you network, you will continue to learn new things about the job marketplace and about yourself.

What should you listen for? Listen for any new trends, nuances, or changes in the market that might affect your Candidate-Market Fit.

To provide an example, let's return yet again to DD.

I told you how she received two great offers within weeks of figuring out her Candidate-Market Fit.

Here's what I didn't tell you: one of those offers was not for a CTO role, but for a Chief Data Officer role. And that's the offer she ended up accepting.

What's the point of sharing this?

DD kept listening and learning throughout her whole search, and that enabled her to be flexible throughout her process, including right at the end.

When a very large public company came along and offered her a CDO role instead of a CTO role, DD took it seriously, even though it was off-strategy (her Candidate-Market Fit was about finding CTO roles in midsize banks). She then discussed it with her JSC, and they supported her decision to pursue that possibility.

I've said this before, but I want to say it again: Social Search is a non-linear and iterative process.

So, if a potential employer wants to offer you something off-strategy, then, your JSC should help you decide whether or not to consider it.

But if you, however, come to an employer with the attitude of “I can do a range of things for you,” then chances are you won’t get offers, or at least you won’t get a good offer.

Ironically, you need to have a clear focus to not only get offers for jobs that meet that strategy but also to sometimes receive “off-strategy” offers.

The worst thing to do is to present yourself as someone who could do a range of things depending on what a company needs. This only works if you have worked closely previously with the hiring manager. If they know you well, then, yes, they might customize a unique role for you. Otherwise, in a capitalist marketplace like the job market, you need to present yourself in a clear and focused way.

Let’s now turn to interviewing.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

- Set up your Megibow Dashboard and Opportunity Screener for you and your JSC.
- Get Karen Wickre's book (see below).
- Balance setting up new meetings with conducting existing meetings (so your weeks are constantly busy).
- Update your broader network, including *everyone* you've spoken to thus far — and ask them to act as “listening posts.”
- Create of a list of target companies that align to what you are looking for.
- Identify and join networking groups relevant to your Candidate-Market Fit.
- Tap into university resources, if available to you as a student or alum.
- Keep your eyes and ears open for new kinds of online networking resources or communities.

TOOLS AND TEMPLATES

Megibow Dashboard

(Download from PhylTerry.com)

Set up and start using your Megibow Dashboard.

Jeff's Opportunity Screener

(Download from PhylTerry.com)

Customize this tool to help you evaluate opportunities during your networking.

Taking the Work out of Networking by Karen Wickre

Karen is a master networker *and* an introvert. As a result, this ends up being a terrific book for the job seeker. I'll also note that she's an accomplished practitioner of learning from mutual-support peer groups. She has built her own version of a JSC and today runs her own Career Council.



CHAPTER 12

INTERVIEWING

You are keeping your Megibow Dashboard full and your Opportunity Screener updated. Now you have your first interview.

Your challenge will be how to prepare, and how to be sure you do as much interviewing of them as they do of you. And, importantly, as you'll see, I'll ask you to create a Job Mission with OKRs for any serious potential job.

Remember, interviewing isn't a competition where success means landing *any* job you interview for. You want to land a job that is just as right for you as you are right for the company.

In fact, there's a simple approach that will help you not only figure out if you will love working at a company but also prepare you for interviews — it begins with research.

RESEARCH

Go to the company website, and, if they are a public company, download and read their recent annual reports — especially Section 7 of their most recent annual filing to the SEC (Section 7 is the Management Discussion and Analysis or “MD&A”). This section of the annual report will provide insight into the financial strength (or lack thereof) of the company, but it will also give you a sense of their culture and public strategy (I go into detail on how to analyze these things below).

Look also for articles about the company, blog posts on Medium or LinkedIn, and any other social media artifacts.

Kerry Cooper, Board member at PG&E and advisor to many startups, suggests looking at the activity section of a company executive's LinkedIn profile, as well as searching for any podcasts.

The activity section of a LinkedIn profile is fascinating — what have they shared, commented on, published? Further, it's amazing what you can learn about a company when you find podcasts that feature the CEO or leadership of the company talking about their business.

These are great recommendations, especially helpful for finding out information about privately held companies where there's little public reporting.

For example, today private equity firms (or "PE" in the current parlance) together have trillions in assets. As a result, if your potential employer is private, there is a growing chance they are owned by a PE firm (or venture capital firm), and doing this kind of research on LinkedIn and via podcasts can be very helpful.

Throughout your research, look for several things: bad strategy, bad products, and, especially, bad culture.

Let's start with products.

BAD PRODUCTS

It's important to analyze the quality of the products, services, and customer experience of your would-be employer.

For many jobs, especially in product management, you need to have an opinion on what's working and what's not.

If you are a product manager, then you already know something about evaluating good and bad products. Use your knowledge.

If you are not, or if you are unsure how to do that, or, if the company is B2B and you cannot easily access their product or services, then ask for help, including from the company itself (once you get into an interview process, you can ask for access to their products and services).

When I ran a customer experience consulting firm, I taught new employees how to evaluate good products and services.

Typically, it involved the intersection of two things:

1. Qualitative review

Attempt to use the product or service with careful attention to any points of confusion. Pretend you are a naive customer. What works? What doesn't? What frustrates you? What delights you (if anything)? The most difficult part of qualitative review is adopting the naive mindset and being a very careful listener to your own reactions.

2. Quantitative review

This is typically a combination of usage statistics (customer engagement, etc.) and revenue/financial metrics (sales, sales growth, profit margin, etc.).

Keep in mind that the product is often a website and a mobile app, so check at least both of those. And the naive-customer questions that you develop from your analysis should be baked into your interview questions along with strategy and financial questions.

For more help, you can also look at my first book, *Customers Included*, or any of Marty Cagan's books. You can also Google this topic and look for articles, podcasts, etc. on how to evaluate good (or bad) products.

BAD STRATEGY

In Chapter 9, I recommended you read the terrific book *Good Strategy/Bad Strategy*, by Richard Rumelt.

Now I want you to pay attention to Rumelt's Chapter 3, "Bad Strategy." Rumelt lays out four key signs of a bad strategy:

1. Fluff

Bad jargon, meaningless or esoteric (or trendy) concepts. Re-read Rumelt's Chapter 3 on bad strategy to be reminded how to identify fluff — one telltale sign he says is the use of "Sunday" words (i.e., big words that are abstract and meant to impress rather than provide clarity).

2. Lack recognition of the challenge

Ford and a bunch of companies made this mistake regarding autonomous driving. They all predicted in 2016 that it would be here by 2020. They did not recognize the challenges in building such a system.

3. Mistaking goals for strategy

You may recall, I discussed this mistake in Chapter 9 (and helped you figure out the degree of alignment between your Candidate-Market Fit and your career goals). That experience will help you in evaluating corporate strategy. If you see a company simply stating a goal, especially an outlandish one, with no sense of the challenge or the strategy to achieve it (like Ford above), then be wary.

4. Bad strategic objectives

This is a cousin of mistake #3, but, in this case, it's an objective or deliverable that gets made without a sense of the challenge or how to achieve it.

I recommend you use this as a framework for thinking about any company you consider (and, again, re-read Rumelt's terrific Chapter 3 on bad strategy).

Do not forget to ask your JSC for feedback on your research and evaluation, including on your potential employer's culture. You want to avoid *bad* cultures. To paraphrase, bad culture eats customers and executives for breakfast, lunch, *and* dinner.

BAD CULTURE

Evaluating bad products and bad strategy takes work.

But figuring out the culture of a potential employer is even harder, and for most people, even more important.

So, to identify a bad culture, pay attention to *everything*.

Listen to your own reactions and emotional responses. And run those by your JSC.

Let me say that again: *listen* to your own reactions, and then ask for help.

This is important. You have built-in emotional intelligence that can help guide you.

I find, however, that most job seekers ignore what their own emotional intelligence can help them discover (more on that in a moment).

So, pay attention.

Are they humble?

Are they arrogant?

Or is their tone “corporate-generic,” which could indicate a bureaucratic culture?

For example, if you read Jeff Bezos’ annual shareholder letter, you will learn a lot about the culture of Amazon. Some people don’t like that culture, but the good news is that the ruthlessness and obsessive focus on the customer is clear (note: Amazon has proven up until now that a company can focus on the customer and *not* on the employee experience — though that may be changing).

On the other hand, if you read Warren Buffett’s Letters to Shareholders, then you’ll discover a humble leader willing to admit mistakes, who gives more credit than he takes.

Look for other signs, too.

For example, Jessica, a job seeker, needed help to prepare for an interview with a private financial institution. This company had been around for a long time, but because they were private, there was very limited information about them available.

So, she asked a fellow JSC member, Ricard, to help her do some “scuttlebutt” research, meaning they had to dig deeper and talk to more people.

Jessica and Ricard both worked in financial services and so had a good, combined network to ask.

Jessica worried whether this potential employer primarily relied on face-to-face interactions and did not have very sophisticated technology.

Ricard found a press report about a recent billion-dollar technology investment that they had announced.

That was helpful. But Jessica and Ricard then noticed something interesting.

Neither had any first-level LinkedIn connections to anyone at the company. That was odd. Jessica has been in financial services for 25 years and knows at least one person at all the major players, except this one.

That single insight led to Jessica asking this company targeted questions about the insularity of the company. It turned out that, yes, most people started young and stayed throughout their careers. That is not necessarily a problem and can, in fact, be a good sign. But that led to more questions, including: what's their track record of bringing in senior leaders from the outside? Ricard suggested Jessica not only ask that question but also ask to hear about leaders they brought in who did not work out and why.

Jessica discovered that they had an uneven track record of bringing in senior leaders like herself. That was helpful to learn and led her to turn down this company for another that had more experience welcoming senior-level hires like herself.

Keep researching and asking for help throughout your interviews. Engage your JSC and broader network.

Keep your eyes open.

If, for example, there's a big photo of the CEO, that often suggests narcissism, according to Professors Arijit Chatterjee and Donald C. Hambrick.²⁶ They point out that, if you looked at reports of companies that later failed, you would often have found big photos of their CEOs, while such narcissistic displays were not typical of companies that were more successful over the long term.

A big CEO photo obviously does not predict failure, but it's a clue to the company's culture.

You should also look at the company's Glassdoor ratings while keeping in mind that online reviews can be gamed. You may also want to look for the annual Glassdoor report on the best companies to work for (and there are other firms who produce similar reports).

Search the Internet, and ask your JSC for tips and tactics for figuring out company culture from the outside. As I was writing this chapter, I found *The Muse* had put together a good list of tips taken from around the web in a post they called "9 Sneaky Ways to Figure Out a Company's Culture."

Again, the art of Social Search is the art of constantly asking for help and looking for others to learn from.

Remember that investing your time working in a company with a bad strategy or dead-end products can have a real, long-term, negative impact.

These recommendations are meant to minimize that possibility and help you avoid companies you should *not* work for.

Now it's time to learn more about your potential boss.

BACKCHANNEL RESEARCH

I also recommend that you conduct “backchannel” research — i.e., get insight into your boss (and company) outside the official channels of your interviews.

This is where the power of your expanded network and your JSC's combined wider networks can help. Often someone in your network will either directly know someone who works or has worked at the company, or they will have a contact who does.

One of our CG members, Tom, was hired as President of a successful software company. Sadly, in his case, he didn't do deeper research during the interview process. While it worked out in the end, he missed a key thing that caused him and the company a lot of pain.

It turned out that the CEO and Chief Product Officer (CPO) were co-founders and best friends. The CPO, however, was weak. He would not have been hired into that role in any other firm. But he was a co-founder, good friend of the CEO, and a board member.

It took Tom two years to finally ease out the CPO. And it was hard. The business grew more slowly, and he had to go through a lot of internal drama.

In retrospect, Tom realizes he could have asked any number of questions to figure this out before taking the job. He knew people who had worked there before that he could have interviewed. And the CEO even mentioned at one point that the CPO was a best friend of his (Tom could have taken that information and combined it with his own analysis that the product was weak to anticipate the problem).

You want to know if you are walking into a situation like this (and how to avoid it, if possible). And remember, your JSC can help you see red flags you might miss.

Talk to as many people as you can, and learn as much as you can about the company, its culture, and about the individuals you'll be working with. Check what they tell you against what you yourself are experiencing with your own eyes and ears.

Here's another example: a CG member, Maia, took a job with a founder-led startup. The culture ended up being a terrible fit, and we conducted a debrief after she quit.

She told me something interesting: the founder was good friends with Mark Zuckerberg and, more than anything else, wanted to join the "billionaire boys club" like Mark and others. That trumped everything else.

That story suggests yet another angle of deeper research: if you are going to a startup, then it might be good to figure what drives the founder.

I do have a favorite question that I suggest you consider asking key people, especially anyone who has worked at the company before.

Professor Paul Marshall, who taught the class "Running and Growing a Small Company" at Harvard Business School, introduced me to this question.

If I called and left a voicemail and told you I was considering working for this company (and/or this person), and said please call me back only if you feel strongly that I must go work there . . . would you have called me back? Why or why not?

I've used this many times, and it can help when trying to cut through people's tendency to not want to say bad things about people they've worked with.

And I've encouraged CG members to use the same question when hiring or when interviewing for a new job themselves.

This type of question cuts through the legalities and the unwillingness people have about being negative about others.

For example, a longtime member, Allyson, was interviewing for the President role of a high-profile retailer with a very well-known social media influencer involved as co-founder. She correctly wondered if she could thrive in that situation. The job was a new role, so she couldn't go ask other people who had been in that role before.

So, we both looked for people in our networks who had worked with one of the founders (the business co-founder or the social media influencer co-founder). Luckily, I knew a person who had previously worked with the CEO and connected Allyson to him.

Here's what that person said when Allyson asked what the founder was like to work for: "I learned a lot from him. He's intense and gets very involved in

the details.”

Allyson called me and reported back on this conversation. When I asked her for clarification about that statement, she said she had not asked further.

This is a mistake I see a lot. When doing deeper research like this, keep asking for *more* details and clarification. Every answer is an “offer” to ask more.

For example:

- “How is he ‘intense?’”
- “What did you learn from him?”
- “Would you work with him again?”
- “Was it a good thing from your point of view that he got involved in the details?”
- “Describe the worst interaction you had with him (or witnessed someone else having) . . . and the best.”

Because Allyson didn’t ask more, the only thing we knew was that the CEO was a micromanager.

So, I asked Allyson to go back and find out more.

When she did, here’s what the person further said: “Well, I don’t want to be critical, but, yes, he was often very hard to work with. And he would get angry quickly and criticize mistakes — or things he *viewed* as mistakes — with almost a personal vendetta.”

He then shared a story about the worst interaction, where the CEO screamed at a woman, belittled her, and even criticized her looks.

Allyson clarified: “Is that what you meant by intense — quick to anger and almost personally abusive, especially of women?”

He answered, “Well, I don’t want to say the word ‘abusive,’ but, yes, I think you understand what I’m saying.”

OK. Now we knew more. And Allyson wisely decided *not* to pursue that job.

Note that this kind of “scuttlebutt” research should continue throughout interviews and negotiations. Keep asking both your JSC and your wider network for help.

Having done at least some initial research and evaluation of the company, its people, and its strategy, products, and culture, you are now ready to do a paired interview-preparation exercise with a fellow member of your JSC.

PAIRED INTERVIEW PREPARATION

As mentioned, you not only need to be ready for their questions, but you need to interview them as much as they interview you. To do that, you need to probe their culture, which is hard to do (and we'll talk about a key technique later to do that), and keep asking versions of these questions:

Is this company doing well? Do they make products, services, or experiences that customers want now (and will likely want in the future)? What is the culture of this company, and will I do well in it? What is the company's (proven) tolerance for change? And what about this role itself. Is it well-architected? Will I be set up to succeed here? And will I be happy in this company?

Here's how the paired interview exercise works:

- 1. Pair up with a fellow JSC member who is also interviewing**

- 2. Share key artifacts**

Share the job description, your Candidate-Market Fit, LinkedIn profile, resume, and anything you uncovered about the company during your research, such as reports, key sections of the website, blog posts, Glassdoor insights, etc. Most importantly, share your Mnookin Two-Pager with your "must-haves" and "must-nots."

- 3. Spend 15–20 minutes reading your partner's artifacts**

Each of you should then spend 15–20 minutes reviewing the materials on your own and writing down first impressions of the company and questions you would both answer and ask. Both of you should listen to your reactions and emotional responses to any of the company artifacts.

- 4. Share first impressions**

After the 15 minutes, discuss together your impressions of each company and any thoughts or concerns you each have.

- 5. Write down interview questions for your partner**

Again, based in part on their "must-haves" and "must-nots" as well as anything else you have surfaced here, spend 15 minutes or so preparing questions for your partner to ask and to answer. Look again at the job

description, their rehabbed LinkedIn profile/resume, and my sample culture questions below, and answer these two questions: 1) if you were the potential employer, what questions would you want to ask your partner? and 2) if you were the job candidate, what would you want to ask the potential employer?

6. Share your questions with each other

Discuss and edit them so that, eventually, you develop a single list of prioritized questions to answer and to ask (and keep in mind that these are starter questions . . . your list should evolve over time as you learn more and interview more).

7. Practice interviewing

Finally, practice, practice, practice. Have your partner interview you, and then switch and interview them (so you act as both interviewer and interviewee).

SAMPLE QUESTIONS

I've said this already, but let me reiterate. You should be interviewing your potential employer as much as they are interviewing you, especially to understand the culture of the company.

Anytime someone hires you, you make a social contract: they give you money, and you give them your time and expertise. So, if you are going to give a boss and a company some of your most important assets, then make sure they deserve it.

Further, know that *asking* good questions is a key part of making a good impression.

There are an endless number of questions and resources to help you think about questions to ask to help you evaluate a potential employer.

You certainly need to ask questions that reflect the job you want based on all your earlier work in your Listening Tour and crafting a strategy. Combine that with the questions you created in the exercise above, and you'll be in good shape.

Below, I'm going to give you some additional role, strategy, and culture questions that you might consider.

ROLE QUESTIONS

- Is this role a new job, or are you filling a vacancy?
- If you are filling a vacancy, did the last person succeed? Or fail? Tell me more (note: “tell me more” is always a great question). *Why* did they succeed or fail?
- Can you tell me more about anyone your firm has hired recently who has *not* worked out? What happened?
- If the role is newly created, then ask about the process the team used to decide that this position was needed. Who would this person report to? How matrixed is it?
- If you were to hire me, what would I have to do to *fail* at this job? What would I have to do to *succeed*?
- How do you measure success in this role? Do you have OKRs (objectives and key results) outlined for this role? Or any other details about what success looks like?
- What do you think it will take to be successful here?

STRATEGY QUESTIONS

- I believe the company’s core revenue is generated from x, but there are other sources of revenue (if that is true) such as y, z, and w. Can you help me understand how important they are now and for the future?
- How is the company going to grow?
- What are the biggest challenges facing that growth?
- What is the company doing today that it should not be doing? What should the company do more of?

PRODUCT, CUSTOMER, AND MARKET QUESTIONS

- Tell me about your customers. What pain points are you solving? Is your product/service/experience a must-have or nice-to-have?
- How much time does the management team spend with customers?
- Which competitors do you worry about the most? Are there any disruptive threats?
- Does the company believe in continuous iterative testing with customers?

CULTURE

- Can you describe your culture? Ask the hiring manager to describe the culture — and why they like working at the company.
- What qualities do you look for in every employee?
- How do people work/collaborate with each other?
- When two teams disagree on priorities, how does the disagreement get resolved?
- Ask for examples of the culture in action (work hours, collaboration, disagreement resolution, celebrations, etc.)
- Ask for examples of the kinds of employees that do well in their company and why.
- Ask for an example of an employee who did *not* fit the culture well and was fired. And why.
- Ask about employee-engagement surveys — do they run them, and what kind of feedback, both positive and negative, do they get? And how seriously do they take the surveys? And can you give an example of a change that was made based on the surveys?
- Ask about a recent hire who did not work out and why.
- Ask about a time when a team did not hit their goals, or a project failed. What happened?
- Certainly, ask about the diversity of the firm and any diversity and inclusion programs they have — or goals they have set.
- How did the core team meet? Do all of them come from a prior company?
- Do employees stay for a “good run” and take logical growth steps inside the company? Or is this a place where people go as a “last stop” in their career?

REFLECTIONS ON FIT

- Now given everything I’ve learned . . . here’s my answer to the question: “Am I a fit for this role?” And then share your thoughts on whether the company is a fit for you, and you are a fit for the company.
- Be honest here. You will win the trust of your interviewer.

- Assuming, however, that this is a job you want, and it is a fit, then highlight several of the most compelling reasons.

Finally, this is not an exhaustive list.

Ask your JSC for help.

Go online to look for other questions.

Remember, Social Search is always about learning from others — from your JSC, from the web, Tik Tok, etc.

The Ladders provides good lists of interview questions you should ask (and be ready to answer).

Search for questions relevant to your domain, and check my book website, which I plan to continuously update with resources to help you.

And, again, your fellow JSC members may have some suggestions for questions, or know of other resources you could tap into.

Further, keep in mind that there are different kinds of interviews and many online resources to help you prepare.

For example, if you are a college student interviewing for consulting jobs, then you will likely be asked to a “case study” interview. Case studies typically look for how you think and reason and follow standard formats. Look up online resources and practice with members of your JSC or members of a student management consulting club.

Other companies also increasingly use case-study interviews. For example, product managers are now often given case studies.

You may also find that your potential employer asks you to do some significant work as part of the interview process. That’s fine, unless they are asking you to do a piece of work that they normally pay an employee (or contractor) to do.

So, for example, if they ask you to put together a 30-, 60- or 90-day plan, then that’s fine and within the bounds.

If, however, they ask you to show how you would redesign the checkout process along with prototypes or wireframes, then they should pay you for that.

If you think they should pay you, or you are not sure, then ask for help in figuring this out from your JSC or broader network. If they should pay you, then how much they should pay depends on your level of experience and the

amount of work you are doing. To figure that out, again ask for help and input.

Let's now explore what to do during the interview itself.

WHAT TO DO RIGHT BEFORE YOU INTERVIEW

You are prepared. You understand your Candidate-Market Fit. You have done your paired interview-preparation exercise and developed a set of questions to ask them, as well as prepared your answers to the questions you hope they'll ask you.

Yet, if you are like most people, you are nervous.

How do you put yourself in the right headspace?

If you meditate, do that.

I also recommend a simple exercise that utilizes what you already did in Chapter 5.

Look back on your gratitude list, and think about your relationships with those people.

Remember the smart and caring people who have already helped you. They respect you. They have confidence in you. They are rooting for you.

Most importantly, you are not alone. Your JSC and your broader network are with you.

Just knowing you are not alone and that others have confidence in you improves your confidence before going into an interview. Let's now explore what to do during the interview itself.

LISTEN TO *WHAT* THEY DO

Whenever you meet someone, they'll tell you everything you need to know about them by their actions. You just need to use your millions of years of ingrained social intelligence.

The biggest mistake I see candidates make in this regard is they replace *reality* with *wish fulfillment*. In other words, they want their potential boss and potential company to be good, so they *ignore* what their eyes, ears, and social brains are telling them is happening right in front of them. Andy made that mistake in Chapter 9 when he ignored the warning signs and took the COO job from a company that was almost immediately indicted for fraud.

So, pay attention to how your interviewer acts, especially if they are your potential boss.

One important way to hone your skill at listening to what they do is to keep a simple job-search journal. Spend 10 or 15 minutes after each interview reflecting on what happened and what you learned about them. This is great preparation for the post-interview debrief that I also recommend you do with a fellow JSC member (see more about that below).

Remember, the best treatment you will ever get from this company is during the interview. That's when your potential boss/colleagues are on their best behavior.

Unfortunately, most job candidates take it personally when interviewers treat them badly. That misses the point. They are *not* saying something about *you*, they are revealing something about *themselves*.

About 15 years ago, I went to the Harvard Club in New York to celebrate the growth of a company that serves private equity (PE) firms. Not only did the firm invite all the PE titans, but they all showed up. In fact, the one many recognize as the “king” of the PE firms agreed to speak. He got up on the podium and started to talk to this small group of about 30.

But then this CEO's phone rang.

I figured he'd ignore it. He was on stage, after all.

Instead, he took the phone out and answered.

Then I figured he'd just tell the caller he'd call them back.

But no.

Right there in front of all of us, he just started talking on the phone. He talked and talked and had an entire conversation. He didn't apologize or even turn away. When he was done, he then hung up and said to all of us, “Thank you, everyone” and left. That was it.

I was flabbergasted.

After that, I noticed his name in the middle of several controversies that simply proved again and again that he's a total a**.

POST-INTERVIEW DEBRIEF

Many job seekers can get caught up in the hiring company's passion and excitement and miss red flags, which is one of the reasons I ask you to do a post-interview debrief with a JSC member.

Take Berry, for example.

She got so passionate about a startup's idea and the compelling CEO/founder that she ended up taking a job that she boomeranged out of two years later.

She had gotten “so wrapped up in the founder's passion that I jumped into something prematurely without asking all the right questions and doing the due diligence.”

Berry further explained:

“Ideas, by nature, are exciting to me. Pair that with my personality, which is far more risk-driven than safe, and the risk is that I jump into something prematurely, without asking all the right questions/due diligence. Social Search is very focused on due diligence, but even if you theoretically agree with the approach, it is easy to get ‘swept up’ in the excitement and skip paying attention and asking questions.”

I imagine that Berry's dilemma is true for many readers of this book.

New products/services/companies are exciting. And it's good to get excited about innovation. I support that.

At the same time, however, you need to cultivate your capacity to see beyond the excitement.

The thing is, like most recommendations I make, it is easy to intellectually agree with this and *hard* to put it into practice, especially if you do it alone.

Berry's mistake was to *not* include her JSC and broader network at this moment in her job search. She got excited and quickly accepted an offer.

She did not ask for help in evaluating the company or in negotiating the salary, budget, resources, and support she needed to succeed.

She ended up experiencing two hard years with a narcissistic boss.

You have to resist the temptation to go fast at every stage of the job search. Even if you have already created a JSC, conducted a Listening Tour, developed your Candidate-Market Fit, and found a job that seems to meet that strategy, you cannot then speed up at the end.

The funny thing about this recommendation is that when I say, “Slow down,” I don't mean “Take weeks.” Literally, this often means slowing down to conduct a debrief. I'm talking about a few hours.

But time gets compressed when you get close to an offer. So, be careful. Resist the urge to say yes now.

Having said that, let's now talk about how to run a post-interview debrief.

After interviewing with your hiring manager, CEO, founder, or Board Chair, get on the phone with a JSC member, and ask them to ask *you* these questions:

CULTURE/PERSONALITY

- Did this person listen to *you* well?
- When they talked about the company and the team, did they use “we” or “I”?
- Did they talk too fast and make it hard for you to say anything?
- Did they seem impatient?
- Did they make you feel important or like a nuisance?

RELEVANT KNOWLEDGE AND EXPERTISE

- Does your hiring manager understand the dynamics of this business? For example, if this is a software company, then do they understand modern software dynamics, or are they stuck in an old mindset?
- How well do they understand the products/services of the company?
- Do they understand and communicate to you the product-market fit? Do you find it believable?

The final question your debriefer should ask: Were you uncomfortable with anything you cannot put your finger on?

And for the debriefer, if there's something your JSC member is telling you that you don't understand about their interview, then keep probing. Keep in mind that when an interviewer treats a candidate badly, that candidate is apt to take it personally, rather than as an important negative cue about that interviewer and that company's culture. So, keep probing (and being supportive).

GET CREATIVE IN PROBING CHALLENGES

Take for example, a story from Kerry Cooper's career.

Today Cooper is a board member at several public and private companies, and an advisor to VC firms, but earlier in her career, when she was COO and CMO at Internet retailer ModCloth, an interesting thing happened.

They were recruiting for a new CFO, and one of the candidates, Dinesh Lathi, asked for a session with both Cooper and the founder/CEO Eric Kroger.

Lathi sensed there might be some issues in decision-making on the leadership team, so he brought the two together and asked the following questions:

- If Kerry thinks the marketing budget should be increased, but I don't, how will we resolve it?
- If Kerry wants to hire someone I have reservations about, how will we come to an agreement?

As Cooper later said to me, "These were reasonable questions and showed me he was putting himself in the role and probing how the founder and I might deal with tough issues, where there might have been misgivings, *and* he got us to commit to how we would make such decisions down the road."

Cooper's last point is important: how do you get companies to commit to key issues before you agree to join? And that takes us to the next topic, which is one of the most important recommendations in this whole book: create a Job Mission with OKRs.

CREATE A JOB MISSION

If you are doing multiple interviews with a company, and the job is consistent with your strategy, the business model is strong (or has potential if it's a startup), and you like what you are observing in terms of their strategy, products, and culture, then it's time to create a Job Mission with OKRs.

This is a twist on what Geoff Smart and Randy Street recommend in their book *Who*, a "Job Mission."

They suggest that the hiring manager does this, not you, the candidate.

But I'm turning that upside down and suggesting *you* do it.

The essence of the Job Mission is that you identify the objectives and key results (OKRs) you will promise to deliver if they hire you into this new role.

Most companies do not create Job Missions. As a result, they do not outline the clear deliverables they want from the people they hire.

This is a problem for them, but it's also a problem for you.

Let me explain.

For employers, the key benefit of a Job Mission is to filter out candidates who interview well, but don't want to be on the hook to deliver results.

For candidates, the Job Mission process will provide five key benefits: 1) it will help guide your questions during subsequent interviews (to clarify what the job is); 2) when presented, it will impress the hiring manager; 3) it will help you be sure you are both in alignment about the role; 4) if you then get an offer, the Job Mission will give you leverage to ask for all four legs of the negotiation stool: salary, budget, resources, and support; and 5) it will help you hit the ground running once you start.

One final note: while creating a Job Mission is one of my most important recommendations, it is also the least followed.

Of the 200 job seekers who used early drafts of this book, 80% formed JSCs, most conducted Listening Tours (though many could have done more there), many figured out their Candidate-Market Fit, and almost none of them created Job Missions with OKRs — that is until we spoke and I insisted on it.

Once they did, they were hooked and swore they would never skip it again. It truly delivered all five benefits outlined above.

But keep this in mind: you will be inclined to skip this step. Do not make that mistake. Ask your JSC for help.

HOW TO CREATE A JOB MISSION

1. Download the Job Mission Samples document from my book website

See the “Tools and Templates” on my book website to get a file of sample Job Missions from real job seekers. Read through all the samples to get inspiration for drafting yours.

2. Draft your Job Mission for this role

Based on the samples on my website, and on the answers you've already received in your interviews, draft *your* Job Mission with OKRs. Key is to make it about the objectives of your job and key results you will be on the hook to deliver.

3. Ask more questions

Crafting the Job Mission will help you identify more questions you'll need to ask to understand the objectives and key results (OKRs), and overall focus. So, in subsequent interviews, ask more questions that will help you fill out your Job Mission.

4. Ask for feedback

Run a draft by your JSC and any relevant person in your network to get feedback.

5. Present to your hiring manager

Show a copy to your hiring manager, and ask if you have understood the job properly, including the objectives and key results you are signing up for.

Assuming your interviews go well, and your would-be employer is impressed with you and your Job Mission, let's now move to the next two chapters to talk about the all-important process of negotiating.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

- Research any company you plan to interview with.
- Run a paired interview-preparation exercise.
- Right before all interviews, review your Gratitude House exercise to remind yourself of all the people rooting for you (this will help calm and focus you).
- Make sure to hold a post-interview debrief after every interview.
- Create a Job Mission with OKRs, and let that guide the rest of your interviews, which will impress your employers and set you up to negotiate well (Note: send me your Job Mission if you'd like me to add it to the library of anonymized samples).

TOOLS AND TEMPLATES

Sample Job Missions

(Available on my author site: PhylTerry.com)

View sample Job Missions to get ideas for how to structure your own.

Sample interview questions

Search online for sample interview questions for your domain and industry. Check out TheLadders.com for their resources.

Who by Geoff Smart and Randy Street

Get the Kindle version, and go to page 24 to see their example of a Job Mission.

Glassdoor Best Places to Work and other online resources

Glassdoor produces an annual report on the best places to work (just Google that title, and you'll find it). You should also search online for: "How to figure out a company culture from outside" and see what you find. That's how I found *The Muses'* helpful compilation of tactics from around the web (search for "9 Sneaky Ways to Figure Out a Company's Culture").

STEP 5

Negotiate and Prepare to Start

	Step 1 JSC	Step 2 Listening Tour	Step 3 Candidate- Market Fit	Step 4 Networking/ Interviewing	Step 5 Negotiate	Total Time
Full-time job seekers (i.e., those unemployed)	1-2 weeks	2-3 weeks	1-2 weeks	4-8 weeks	1-2 weeks	2+ mos
Part-time job seekers (i.e., those still employed)	2+ weeks	4+ weeks	2-3 weeks	4+ weeks	1-2 weeks	4+ mos



CHAPTER 13

NEGOTIATING SALARY

Negotiating is one of the most difficult steps in the job search.

Here's why: most people, whether college students or senior executives, have little practice in negotiation.

Even if you have negotiated deals for companies or negotiated salaries for people you hire, you may still find that you are less practiced in negotiating on behalf of yourself.

The good news is you have done great work to get to this point, including creating a Job Search Council and the all-important Job Mission with OKRs.

Armed with both, you'll be able to negotiate well.

I have watched JSC members help each other negotiate, and collectively get millions of more incremental dollars.

The key is to have the courage to ask.

As I noted in the Introduction, the data shows that, if you ask, you will receive — 83% of the time.

Part of the reason is that most job offers are not extended at the maximum budgeted amount. Companies expect to get asked for more, and they want some cushion so they can be accommodating and have you feeling excited about getting slightly more dollars.

Oh, and two more things.

If you followed my recommendation to create a Job Mission in the last chapter and vetted your objectives and key results with your hiring manager, then that should increase their interest in hiring you and thereby increase your leverage in asking for more money.

And secondly, if you negotiate not just for money, but for the budget, resources, and support you'll need to succeed in this job — as I'll explain in the next chapter — then that should also *increase their interest in hiring you*.

Sadly, however, as documented by the two researchers Linda Babcock and Sara Laschever, most people, especially women and people of color, do *not ask*.

The result?

They estimate at least \$560,000+ of lifetime earnings are lost.

Social Search can help you *not* lose that money.

For example, Lauren, a member of a JSC, was recently offered a new job. Her fellow members helped her ask for more salary and for non-financial support (more on that in a moment).

The result?

She estimated that she got several hundred thousand more dollars than she otherwise would have — and that compounds to millions over a lifetime.

Amazing.

That's the power of *not* negotiating alone.

The company's first offer was below Lauren's current salary and below market norms.

This happens all too often, but it can be more pronounced for women, and especially women of color.

Even in professions like medicine, with lots of schooling and credentials, and where women are more than 50% of medical-school students, women doctors still make *less* than their equally qualified male counterparts.²⁷

So, Lauren's JSC helped her frame the conversation better with the CEO of the hiring company.

In this case, the company Lauren was interviewing with was unique to many in New York. 50% of their customers were Black women. Lauren, however, would, if hired, have been the *only* Black woman — in fact, the only Black *person* — on the management team.

Her JSC helped her focus on that and ask for more pay and more non-financial support because she was going to understand the customer base better

and be able to play a public role in cultivating and working with their customers.

As a result, she received both more pay — about \$200,000 more between base salary, signing bonus, and equity — and something few negotiate: the budget, resources, and support she'll need to succeed, which I'll say more about in the next chapter.

Before we get deeper into the details of salary negotiations, let me return to an earlier topic: managing recruiters.

MANAGE THE RECRUITER

Building relationships with recruiters is a job that never ends.

As we discussed in Chapter 8, you want recruiters to help you understand your Candidate-Market Fit.

Here I will address the more challenging topic of how to manage the recruiter who is working with you on a potential job.

The most important thing for you to remember is that your goal is *not* to do the recruiter's job.

For example, the recruiter typically gets paid when a candidate accepts the role. This is true even if they are on retainer. Retained recruiters won't keep those retainers if they are not effective at placing candidates. One mitigating factor is that the best recruiters are evaluated by how well the candidates perform in the job, how long they stay, and what value they bring to the role and company. So at least those recruiters also want to find the right and best candidates.

Many recruiters, however, focus on placing someone *quickly*.

They are not, therefore, going to encourage you to negotiate salary or non-financial support. They also are not necessarily trying to help you find the best fit. Like real estate agents, who focus on selling more homes (rather than maximizing the price of any home), many recruiters want you to say yes *quickly*.

Your job is different.

With the help of your JSC, you must evaluate whether this role is for you, including negotiating the salary and non-financial support you need.

That's not the recruiter's job.

That's your job.

Recently, several CG members were facing a lot of pressure from recruiters. One recruiter made a candidate, Antonio, feel like it would be a “betrayal” if he did not say yes right away.

Antonio reached out to his JSC. He was upset that he had to act so fast.

They told him that he did not have to act that fast.

Antonio could tell the recruiter he was very interested but could not move that fast.

He was relieved and communicated that to the recruiter and, while not happy, the recruiter agreed to give him more time (bonus: by moving at his pace, Antonio had the side benefit of showing confidence).

Another CG member received two offers simultaneously, and one of the companies had an internal recruiter pressuring her to accept and tried to convince her that, if she didn’t, then she was acting without integrity.

She called her JSC upset and talked it through. *They* were upset at the way this recruiter was treating her and coached her to insist on respect. She called back the recruiter, and I’m happy to say that the recruiter then apologized for the hardball tactics.

Having said all of this, it’s important to cultivate and work closely with the recruiters. They are not your friends or members of your JSC, but you should cultivate them.

For example, do something I find most candidates do *not* do: make the recruiter your partner. The best recruiters already do this, but in case your recruiter does not proactively support you this way, then ask them for as much help and coaching as you need throughout the interviews. Ask them to help prepare you so you can do your best. Share the questions you have prepared to answer, and ask them if they would add any. Ask them for due diligence on the people you are talking to. And ask them to practice with you.

One word of caution: be thoughtful about the debrief you give the recruiter after each interview. For negotiation purposes, you may want to keep some of your thoughts private. You never want to be overly excited or underwhelmed with your feedback to the recruiter. Be honest with your JSC. But with the recruiter and hiring company, take the process one step at a time.

Now we can finally turn to one of the most seemingly difficult parts of the job search: negotiating your offer.

If you decide your prospective boss is a good boss, you like the job, the company, and the culture, and, importantly, your JSC agrees, then it’s time to

negotiate.

We'll start with salary and other compensation elements and then, in the next chapter, move to budget, resources, and support, which few negotiate.

SALARY NEGOTIATIONS PREPARATIONS

Jason Fried is the well-known co-founder and CEO of Basecamp, a software company, and a *New York Times* bestselling author who has written a lot recently about the difficulty of negotiating salaries.

Fried discovered that his employees were frustrated and unhappy that they had to be good at both their jobs and at negotiating their salaries. "It's weird that you can't just be great at what you do — that you also have to be a great negotiator, too," he said to me.

With the help of his employees and peers outside his company, he and his team created a system at Basecamp where there are clear job titles and salaries. Thus, employees no longer need to negotiate salaries. For more details, you can read Fried's blog post "How we pay people at Basecamp."

This is a rare example of a system where employees don't have to negotiate.

Sadly, you are not likely going to get an offer from Basecamp or another company that has done this. Instead, you are going to have to negotiate.

The good news is, however, you have already invested the time and effort to set the context for help. You have your Job Mission and your JSC ready to assist you in this critical moment.

JSCs can help members even if they do *not* ask for that help.

One member, Rebecca, mentioned she was about to accept an offer. She didn't ask for help negotiating the salary, but the JSC probed and discovered, not surprisingly, that the offer was too low.

The council then helped her negotiate. Remember, helping members see through blind spots like not negotiating salary is one of the great benefits of a JSC.

As one Chief Product Officer candidate told me:

I've shared compensation info with my JSC and learned whether the offer was right for that size and stage of company, and for my level of experience. It was a lifesaver. This kind of advice can be especially helpful when negotiating stock options at the executive level.

One JSC gave great advice to Rebecca, a woman on their council who was debating whether to negotiate salary.

They said, “Don’t negotiate for yourself, think of your job as negotiating for your *family* and what you’ll be able to do for them with the extra money.” That simple reframing made all the difference, and, in fact, the additional salary Rebecca received ended up paying for her daughter’s college tuition.

Here’s the “thank-you” Rebecca wrote:

I not only got the job, but I got the increased salary!! Thank you, everyone. The discussion around negotiating salary as the “major breadwinner” was a game changer for me. I had new clarity around what I wanted and unemotionally asked for what I was worth. Without that matter-of-fact discussion on reframing the approach . . . then my negotiations would not have played out successfully.

Asking for help during salary negotiations pays dividends for a long time.

“It wasn’t just that the salary was 25% higher, but now that would be the new base that would grow every year. That adds up,” said Rebecca.

SALARY EXERCISE

Here’s an exercise you should do before you start negotiating (and after you’ve received an offer).

1. Outline all the compensation elements in the offer

Begin by noting everything they have offered. Make sure you are clear on what they are offering, including:

- Base salary
- Bonus (and what the bonus is tied to)
- Equity (options, restricted stock units, etc.) — and if you don’t understand the equity, ask for help from your JSC and broader network
- Signing bonus (if they are offering one)
- Retirement plan (do they make contributions, how much, etc.?)

- Healthcare benefits (what is the insurance plan and options, what's the premium? etc.)
- Vacation/time-off
- Etc.

2. Read Chapter 5 of *Women Don't Ask*

Read Chapter 5 — “Fear of Asking” — of the 2021 edition of *Women Don't Ask*, by Linda Babcock and Sara Laschever. What they point out is that there are several psychological and cultural barriers that prevent women — and many others, including some men — from asking for the right salary *even* when they know that's what they should be paid.

3. Ask around

Do some research. Speak to the recruiter working with you (if you are working with one), and see if they have any access to industry pay benchmarks. Call recruiters you don't know, and see if they can help.

Several companies, including global staffing firm Robert Half International, offer salary calculators to job seekers as a tool to use for negotiations. Glassdoor has its own version called the *Know Your Worth* tool, which offers pay recommendations based on market value.

Note: If you are interviewing at a venture capital-backed company, ask around, and see if you can get access to VCECS (The Venture Capital Executive Compensation Survey). It's sold primarily to companies, so see if you know anyone who has access to it.

4. Think about your “deal-breaker” minimums

How much money do you want to make — keeping in mind any research you have done on salaries *and* any special context that will make a strategic difference to the company like Lauren had in the story above. What's your minimum cash needed? What about stock?

5. Think about anything else related to compensation

Remember that there are several non-salary ways companies can compensate you: moving costs and other financial incentives, remote work, student-loan debt assistance, graduate-school tuition reimbursement, credit assistance, private, personalized financial assistance,

childcare discounts or full coverage, health savings accounts, 401K contributions, more vacation days, etc. Think about what might be helpful to you and get your JSC's feedback on what to ask for (and how to ask).

6. Bring the result of your research to your JSC, and ask their opinion

Bring your offer package, your salary research, and your deal-breaker minimums to your JSC, and get their feedback and input.

As I've said before, I cannot anticipate what you will face in your negotiations. That's why I recommend you do the exercise above with your JSC and ask for help each step of the way, including for what we'll discuss next: asking for the budget, resources, support, and anything else that will set you up to succeed in the new job.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

- Complete your salary-negotiations preparation exercise
- Be sure to ask your JSC for help, not just with salary bands and amounts, but for the confidence to ask for what you deserve
- Whatever you do, ask!

TOOLS AND TEMPLATES

Women Don't Ask by Linda Babcock and Sara Laschever.

If you are a woman, transgender, non-gender conforming, or even a man who wants to negotiate better, then this is a book worth reading, especially Chapter 5, “Fear of Asking.”

Online Salary Resources

Several companies, including global staffing firm Robert Half, offer salary calculators to job seekers as a tool to use for negotiations. Glassdoor has its own version called the *Know Your Worth* tool, which offers pay recommendations based on market value. So, look those up, or go to websites like [Salary.com](https://www.salary.com) or any that are specific to your industry or function.



CHAPTER 14

NEGOTIATING WHAT YOU NEED TO SUCCEED

Most people, if they negotiate at all, negotiate only the salary or other monetary elements.

Money is very important, but do *not* skip negotiating the budget, resources, and support you will need to succeed in this new role.

As I've said, I've tracked about \$100 million in incremental compensation that job seekers have negotiated with the help of JSCs.

That's amazing.

But even more important has been the *hundreds* of millions of dollars in non-financial support that they have negotiated. This jet fuel meant they were set up to perform well and, as a result, they often received promotions and new job offers faster than they might otherwise have expected.

Your biggest obstacle in negotiating both money and what you need to succeed is your own fear.

This is where your investment in creating a JSC and support in your broader network pays off in big ways.

You likely worry that, if you ask for more, you'll lose the offer.

That almost never happens, but I can't convince you through simply the words in this book.

You need trusted peers, mentors, and others who can give you real-time help to ask for everything you deserve.

And, again, here's where the Job Mission you created in Chapter 12 is helpful.

For example, a CG member, Wallace, identified a great potential job and during interviews discovered that one of his first objectives was to retire \$20 million in "technical debt" (meaning they had to spend \$20 million to bring their technology up to date), and so his JSC insisted he get the CEO's commitment to retire that debt as a condition of accepting the new job, which is exactly what he did.

So, because he asked for what he needed to succeed before starting, he was able to quickly eliminate the technical debt (instead of spending months justifying why they should fund the \$20 million).

Wallace was then able to focus on innovation, which led to a promotion, and then, after only 18 months since he joined, to being considered for the CEO role.

Wow!

That's why asking for the budget, resources, and support can be even more important than the amount of your initial salary in the new role — getting what you need can accelerate your career *and* your earning power.

Or consider this example.

Another CG member was offered a similar CPO/CTO role and knew there was \$10 million in technical debt.

But, despite my pleas, did not negotiate the \$10 million as part of his offer.

On day 1, the company did NOT write a check.

By 6 months, the company still had not written a check.

By 12 months, no check.

At that point, the member was demoralized and looking for a new job.

He's talented so he got a new job, but he paid an opportunity cost in lost time and stunted career growth.

This is why when you negotiate, you need to negotiate not just for salary, but for the budget, resources, and support you'll need to succeed.

This is one of the *most* important steps in Social Search.

Do not skip this.

Instead, follow the lead of the CG member in this next example.

In the last chapter, I told you about Lauren. In her prior job, the CEO had treated her as a “token” and gave her no support. When Lauren had asked for success metrics for her role, the CEO had none. It was very frustrating.

For the new job, Lauren developed a Job Mission with clear OKRs.

To deliver on those OKRs, she needed mentorship from the CEO, board-preparation coaching (so she could start joining boards), *and*, most importantly, key investments in the employee-customer experience that would allow her to have a bigger impact and put her on track for bigger jobs down the road.

She asked her JSC for help to negotiate this, which they provided mostly in the form of encouragement, and she received all of this. This was on top of an improved base salary, bonus, signing bonus, and stock package.

Wow!

Keep in mind that, on average, about 17% of the people who ask do not get what they ask for, at least in terms of compensation. I have found, on the other hand, that when people ask for budget and resources and support, while they may not get everything, they do tend to get much of what they ask. The reason is employers are typically impressed that candidates are taking the role so seriously that they are negotiating not just for compensation but for what they’ll need to succeed.

So, negotiate how the company is going to invest in your success, including everything and anything: funding for a team or project, investing in your own professional learning and development, or making a commitment to helping you get on boards of directors. Again, these types of items can set you up for long-term success and thus are often *more* important than salary.

Sometimes what you need to succeed can be counterintuitive.

For example, a recent CG member took a CMO job in a new industry.

One of her key objectives in her Job Mission was to learn the new industry.

Further, she joined the company halfway through the year, but, as she talked it through with her JSC, she realized that she’d need about six months to get up to speed. Her JSC suggested she propose giving up her bonus for the first six months.

She and her JSC knew that if she forfeited her bonus for the first six months, then she’d experience *less* pressure to perform right away. This ended up being an important step in helping set her up to succeed.

When I checked in with her six months later, she told me that removing herself from the bonus pool for those initial months helped her settle in and learn the new industry. And I'm happy to say that, as of a year later, she's been promoted to CEO.

Wow!

Having said that, giving up a bonus is *not* a rule.

In fact, in general, if a woman told me she wanted to lower her pay initially, my first response would be "no," given the wage discrimination that women face. But, in this case, the collective intelligence of her JSC helped her come to this. And it worked.

Now, let's turn to an exercise to help you figure out what you'll need to succeed in this new job.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED TO SUCCEED EXERCISE

1. Review the Job Mission with Examples document

Review the Job Mission with Examples document that I asked you download from PhylTerry.com in Chapter 12. Review some of those examples and look at how CG members integrated their Job Mission with OKRs with the budget, resources, and support needed to achieve those objectives and key results.

2. Review starter questions below

Then review the starter questions below.

3. Add the budget, resources, and support to your Job Mission with OKRs

Begin to add the budget, resources, and support you'll need to your Job Mission with OKRs.

4. Review with your JSC

Show your expanded Job Mission with OKRs to your JSC and get their advice and input on what you are asking for and how to present it to your hiring manager.

5. Show to your hiring manager

Now show this expanded Job Mission with OKRs to your hiring manager and ask them for the budget, resources, and support you'll need to succeed. They should be impressed and excited that you are already thinking about how to succeed in the new role.

STARTER QUESTIONS

Budget

- How much budget do I need to accomplish these OKRs?
- What kind of team do I need? How many (approximately) might I need to hire or transfer in from elsewhere in the organization? And approximately how much will that cost?
- Are there technology investments that need to be made? If so, what's a ballpark budget?
- Is there tech debt that needs to be retired? If so, approximately how much?
- Are there new systems/processes/tools that need to be built or purchased?
- Do I need to build new capacities, departments, divisions?
- Do I need more budget for sales, marketing, business development, etc?

Resources

- Do I need a internal recruiter dedicated to my team so I can hire the people I need?
- Do I need a dedicated HR partner to, for example, help survey employees and build the culture of my team/group/division?
- Do I need access to external resources that the company has on retainer (vendors, partners, recruiters, etc.)?

Support

- What mentoring from my boss or boss's boss do I need to come up to speed quickly on this new industry, function, business?
- What training or professional development do I or my team need?
- What industry groups or associations, peer councils, etc. do I need budget for and support to attend?

- Do I need an executive coach?
- Do I want support and coaching to join Boards of Directors...to become better at public speaking...to develop a particular skill?

And just to clarify again, you are thinking about everything from informal and formal mentoring from your boss and others to budget commitments for people, technology, etc., to help getting seats on boards of other companies, to whatever you will need to succeed.

Keep in mind that some of what you are asking for, the company cannot guarantee — for example, help getting you a seat on another company's board. But they can help by paying you to attend Stanford's board-training program, by recommending you to fellow CEOs looking for board members, by giving you exposure to the board, and by asking board members to help find spots for you on other boards they may be on. So, in this case, you ask for their commitment to these activities.

Be sure to get these commitments in writing, not just in a handshake. These are core to your success, and you don't want the company taking them lightly as time passes. One easy way to record them is in an offer letter that the company provides that outlines salary, benefits, and these agreed-upon commitments.

Finally, with these two chapters on negotiations, I am advocating that, each step of the way, you ask for help so that you have the support you need *especially* during negotiations.

Remember, the research I've cited several times: 83% of the time, if you ask, you will get it. And in our work with thousands of job seekers helping each other, we have found that, when they ask, they get more money and support closer to 100% of the time (note that often the company will counter-offer, and you'll still end up above the initial proposal).

Let's now turn to preparing to start your new job.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

- Complete your “What You’ll Need to Succeed Exercise”
- Be sure to think about how to tie your Job Mission and OKRs to what you’ll be asking for in terms of budget, resources, and support. If you do this well, then it will set you up to succeed. This is one of the *most* important recommendations in the book.

TOOLS AND TEMPLATES

Sample Job Missions with Budget, Resources, and Support

(Available on my author site: PhylTerry.com)

View sample Job Missions with budget, resources, and support tied to agreed-upon OKRs. And please consider sharing your Job Missions with me so I can add them to the archive for future job seekers.



CHAPTER 15

PREPARING TO START YOUR NEW JOB

Congratulations!

You have a new job.

What do you do next?

First, bring this great news to your JSC, and thank them. You will inspire them and spread some joy.

Second, send a follow-up note to everyone in your extended community and thank them. You will spread even more joy.

Third, keep helping others in your JSC in *their* job search. This will give *you* joy.

Fourth, ask your JSC to help you prepare for the new job, as I outline in this chapter.

MOVE TO PRE-START PREPARATION

Recently, a CG member set up a JSC and then, several months later, got a great job.

When she accepted the offer, she sent a heartfelt thanks to the JSC. It gave them a much-needed boost of energy.

She also acknowledged that she now needed help to start the new job well.

Your first few months will be hectic and intense, but you will need all the help you can get to position you well.

Remember, asking for help and building a community of support *never* ends.

MORE BACKCHANNELING

One of the most important things you can do before you start is to keep backchanneling insight and feedback about your new boss, your new company, and potentially new industry.

This is very important before starting a new job.

Take the example of Mark.

Mark had been the CTO and CPO of a successful online retailer. He helped build the company from around \$50 million in sales to \$1 billion.

He decided, however, that, after about a decade with the company, he wanted to leave the online retail world and look for a job with a fast-growing business software company in Silicon Valley. He formed a JSC, and, after a lot of help from his support group, he landed a new role.

In this new job, however, he would not be the Chief Product Officer but instead report to the CPO, Kristy, and oversee their most promising new product line. This was a big change for him at several levels, including taking a step back in title. Going down a level in title is not necessarily a problem, and, in this case, his JSC thought it was a good move and, as such, reflected the reality of his Candidate-Market Fit in the software world (as opposed to in the retail world). Further, it also helped that he was not taking a step back in salary. The new job with a lower title was paying *more* than his previous retail role.

Once he accepted the job, but before he started, I suggested to Mark that he conduct some due diligence on his new boss, including talking with someone who had worked for her before. That person could help him understand how she operates and what her strengths and weaknesses might be (as we discussed in Chapter 12, this kind of research can also be done while interviewing).

He asked his JSC and broader village, including the CG community, if anyone knew anyone who had worked for Kristy. Fortunately, he found a member on one of the councils who knew someone who had previously

worked for her and introduced the two of them. Mark proceeded to have a good conversation.

This person — we'll call him Tony — told Mark that Kristy is a fair boss who works seven days a week to support her teams. Kristy, he said, loves to coach and then get out of the way. The biggest mistake Mark could make would be not to share what he doesn't know or where he needs help. In other words, he should work to be “coachable.”

This turned out to be very helpful advice, since Mark was taking a step down in title and could have felt pressure to “prove” what he knew, mingled with a bit of bitterness for not having the top job himself.

Instead, when he started, he worked extra hard to be open and humble with Kristy, and that helped get their relationship off to a good start, which, two years later, led to a job offer as Chief Product Officer working for Kristy in a new company where she had just been made CEO.

You can and should do due diligence on all the key people you work with, whether a new boss or a key new peer. You should also conduct another inversion exercise aimed at exploring how you might fail at this new job.

HOW CAN I FAIL AT THIS JOB?

Before you start your new job, ask yourself again: How can I fail at this new job?

Review your notes from the inversion exercise in Chapter 14, go back to your JSC, and ask for their help in anticipating possible challenges.

One of our longtime CG members, Shandra, did this well.

After Shandra was hired to run a global customer-service operation for several parts of a major bank (she went from being responsible for 1,000 agents to 5,000 agents), she asked her JSC for help figuring out how to fail in making this leap to running a bigger operation.

As you know already, instead of asking how to succeed, ask how to fail. The question can be both fun and informative.

In this case, Shandra got some great answers:

- “Do not figure out and assess the quality of your direct reports”
- “Don't hire a rock-solid EA who can manage your calendar well” (Note: Shandra reported being triple-booked in this new role)

- “Do *not* delegate weekly operational reviews”
- “Under-communicate”
- “Wait for your bosses to provide direction and clarity” (Note: Shandra also said she was not given clear objectives)

She took this into account, and it helped her eventually get promoted to running all of customer service globally for the bank.

Another thing you can do before you start your job is assemble a Peer Coaching Call.

PEER COACHING CALL (PCC) FOR FIRST 90 DAYS

First 90 Day Peer Coaching Calls bring together three to four leaders from across non-competing companies who are already doing the job you are *about* to start. The calls last for an hour and typically deliver significant help.

We run hundreds of these a year for CG members, but you can do a version of this on your own.

Let me share a few examples first, before I give you instructions for how to set one up.

Last year, a longtime CG member, Barbara, accepted an offer as CTO of a global retailer.

To help her think about how to plan her first 90 days in this new global role, we convened CTOs at companies like Spotify, Salesforce, Northrop Grumman, and TripAdvisor. This cross-industry group of peers spent 60 minutes with Barbara answering her questions and talking about how they would approach the first 90 days in this new job.

Likewise, Jeremy, the new head of HR for one of the American sports leagues, needed help being effective in his new job. He had a lot to do, including creating the culture of the league. So, we recruited heads of HR from the NBA, Amazon, and Comcast. The conversation was very helpful.

One word of caution: these calls can be more difficult to set up than any other exercise I have recommended. You will be asking busy people in jobs to take an hour to help. Your network may not include all the right people. You will have to use your JSC and broader network to help you recruit.

Remember, however, that you are giving peers the opportunity to *give* help, which is an honor. So don't be afraid to ask.

If you nonetheless have trouble recruiting, then one fallback is simply to run a PCC with your JSC. That will still be productive.

Before I share how to structure these calls, let me give you one more story from a recent PCC.

Marcia was internally promoted to President of one of the largest retailers in the country and her first job was to oversee a three-year complete overhaul of more than 100 technical systems. She believed, however, that neither she, her cross-functional peers, the CEO, nor even the Board quite knew what they were doing.

She asked if my team could organize a confidential Peer Coaching Call with non-competing President-level retail executives who had been through major digital transformation projects.

Marcia started the PCC by saying, “I have no idea what I’m doing, and I’m afraid we might be heading for disaster.” She then explained how there were multiple competing goals for the project as well as multiple power centers within the company trying to elbow each other out in a harmful competition to oversee this project.

One of the executives on the phone, who had run three major retail operations, explained how he had overseen two major digital overhauls that cost hundreds of millions of dollars and yet produced no tangible business or customer value. He then offered the top five reasons for those failures. Of course, Marcia and her team were making some of those very same mistakes.

In just one hour with relevant external peers, Marcia developed a new approach to the digital transformation project with concrete advice and confidential examples that she took back to the CEO and board. I’m happy to say that, as a result, the company both clarified the key success metrics and simplified the structure and governance for the project. They were headed for disaster, but quick intervention helped turn it around. The good news is that Marcia asked for help at the beginning of that project. She didn’t wait for disaster to happen. Further, due to the help she received, she achieved early success with this project and earned another promotion 18 months later.

HOW TO SET UP A FIRST 90 DAYS PCC

Identify three to four peers outside your new company *already* doing the job. So, if you just got your first job out of college, then ask several alums a few

years out to join you. If, on the other hand, you are a Chief Technology Officer, use the members of your JSC and broader network to help you find these people.

Invite them to come together for an hour via Zoom or whatever online video-conferencing technology you prefer.

Many leaders we ask are excited to get such an invitation. They realize how much they will learn from both giving help and hearing what the other coaches have to say. If someone you ask is not immediately interested, then move on to invite others. There are enough other leaders out there who quickly get how valuable this can be.

For example, Brianna, a senior in college, had just landed her first full-time job (with the help of her JSC).

During her Listening Tour, she had contacted several alumni, who were just a few years out, to give her help and perspective.

Now that she'd landed a job, she reached out to those same people and asked if they would participate in a First 90 Days PCC to give her advice and support in figuring out how to start her first full-time job well.

They all agreed.

And when it came time to run the call, Brianna followed this simple, three-part agenda, which you'll recognize from the format of RFHs in your JSC. One suggestion: ask a member of your JSC to moderate this call for you, which is what Brianna did.

1. Context

Take five or ten minutes to talk about your new job and the questions you have for the coaches.

2. Introductions and Clarifying questions

Go around the room, and ask each coach to say a few words about themselves and then ask any clarifying questions about what you are asking. Ask them to focus just on questions. And, by the way, the questions are typically the best part of these calls.

3. Shared experience and advice

Finally, go around the room a second time, and ask for shared experience and advice.

After the call, send everyone a detailed thank-you note. Identify key things you learned from each of the coaches.

That's it.

Let's now move to one of the most common ways I see job seekers fail after they get a new job: they do *not* help their teams understand how they work. That's why everyone needs to create a "user manual" as we'll discuss next.

CREATE A USER MANUAL

Adam Medros, the President and Co-CEO of edX, a consortium of universities started by Harvard and MIT, creates what he calls a blueprint or user manual when he starts a new job. (Note: if you are early in your career, then I recommend you ask your boss to create a user manual to help you understand how to work with them.)

He learned this simple concept from his then-colleague at TripAdvisor, Luc Levesque.

The purpose is to describe how you work, including any of your weaknesses or foibles. You share this blueprint, user manual, or readme file (the same kind of document goes by three different names) with your team, as a way of asking them to help *you* be a better leader *and* helping *them* learn how to work with you.

For example, Adam tells his teams (through his user manual) that he's someone who can react too quickly and, if that were to happen on an important topic, they should persevere and trust that he will eventually slow down and hear them out. He may not end up agreeing with their proposed course of action, but, if they ask him to go slower, he will pull back from being dismissive.

This is not an uncommon challenge for leaders with many competing priorities. A blueprint is a good way to forewarn your teams to help you be a better leader rather than a Doonesbury caricature.

It's also a great way to onboard new team members. In fact, that was the original reason that Luc Levesque, who today is VP of Growth at Shopify, created a blueprint approach back in 2013, as he told the *New York Times* and then again in a subsequent interview with me.

His coach originally helped him create the idea when he was growing the team at his startup, TravelPod, which he later sold to TripAdvisor.

“I was hiring about five new people, and I remember talking to my executive coach about it and thinking: Now I have to go through that whole process again. This is going to take forever. And that’s when I went back and forth with my coach, and we thought, Wouldn’t it be great if you had a blueprint to give someone on Day One that encapsulates what works for me and what some of the quirks about me are? So, I wrote it up and started sharing it with my team.

It’s worked well.”

There’s a simple two-step process for creating a user manual on my book website, which you can download (see “Tools and Templates” at the end of this chapter for more information). As I’ve done with most of the exercises in this book, I recommend that you and your JSC do this together.

The one exception to my recommendation is regarding college students. They don’t yet know enough about their own style of working to create a good User Manual. So, I typically recommend they skip this step, although I’ll note a few have gone ahead and done it and found it helpful.

You can pair up within your JSC or prepare these on your own and bring drafts to a meeting where everyone shares what they have done.

Once you have completed your user manual, you are now ready to start your new job *and* continue to get smart about your new company.

FOLLOW UP, FOLLOW UP, FOLLOW UP

As a reminder, keep thanking people. And be enthusiastic and appreciative about it.

Also, write thank-you cards (better on paper than in an email) to everyone who has helped you along the way in this job search and more broadly in your career (and remember for the latter, you already have those names because of the Gratitude House exercise in Chapter 5).

Sadly, I find that many job seekers do not do this.

This is, indeed, a wonderful moment.

Each heartfelt thank-you card with your words about how they specifically helped you will generate joy and happiness. Yes, you are happy, and doing this will make you even happier, but remember when you are grateful to the people who help you, that makes *them* happy.

I told you that part of your job as a job seeker is to spread joy and happiness. This is one of the key moments when you get to do that.

And there are few things in life that are better than spreading joy and happiness.

Finally, you should now give back.

Support the people who helped you, and help those who ask for your help in the future.

Share what you know, and share what you've learned. Maybe even share this book.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

- Do more backchannel research on your new boss and other key people.
- Run the inversion exercise to help you think about how you might fail at this new job.
- Set up and run a Peer Coaching Call
- Create your User Manual
- Reach out to everyone who has helped you along the way, and give them the good news, and, of course, thank them. You'll spread some joy and deepen your community.
- Consider converting your JSC into a Career Council to keep going in supporting each other every step of the way.

TOOLS AND TEMPLATES

Instructions for Creating a User Manual

(Available on my author site: PhylTerry.com)

Download this template to help you and your fellow JSC members create “user manuals” to bring with you to your new jobs. This document also contains examples of user manuals.

My Next Book

My next book will help you lead and grow once you are in your new job (some job seekers turn their JSC into a Career Council once everyone lands their next role). Knowing that it always takes longer to finish a book, I cannot promise when this will be published. Email me if you want to get updates on the publication timing.



CHAPTER 16

THE LAST WORD

Two of the best general management books of the last 30 years may have been *Built to Last* (1994) by Jim Collins and Jerry Porras and *Good to Great*, also by Collins (2001).²⁸ I bring this up because the few companies that lasted and became great shared one key trait: they had leaders willing to exhibit humility and ask for help, which is what I've asked you to do in your job search.

Some of the companies lauded by Collins and Porras have stumbled or worse. Critics have used these developments to claim that the authors were wrong.

I disagree.

Append the word “longer” to the title of the first book, and “er” to the end of the title of the second book — *Built to Last Longer* or *Good to Greater* — and you have more accurate titles, which arguably better represent the intended messages of the books.

That's how I've also wanted you to think about the challenges of the job search. You can't *build* a career that's built to last, but you make one that's built to last *longer*. As the world keeps changing, you can get better at changing with it.

This concept is important because we all will keep losing our “fit” for any one job (either the company or job goes away, skills become stale, or both). And this is also not likely to be your last job search. We all now change jobs

frequently. 12.3 times between ages 18 and 52,²⁹ and one recent survey of technology company employees found that more than one-third “plan to look for a new job in the next few months.”³⁰

This constant reshuffling means that, if you want to have a better career, including making more money or getting promoted, then you need a better way to search. Too many people search alone, like DD, whose story is weaved through this book, or simply jump at the first opportunity that comes along, rather than being mindful and taking the time to find the role and company that can make them happy, make them more money, and accelerate their careers.

Helping you do that was my aim with this book.

MY NEXT BOOK

You have now directly seen the power of mutually reinforcing activity and how it can help you bridge the gap between *knowing* what to do and doing it.

As a result, you should have a good job where you are paid well and, even more importantly, set up to succeed.

The next thing you should do is convert your JSC to a Career Council, where you and non-competitive peers meet and help each other make good decisions *in* your new jobs.

One of the stories I tell in the next book is unfolding as I write this.

And you won't be surprised to learn that it's about DD.

After she started her new job, she immediately ran into some negative politics that threatened to derail her.

Her Career Council and I are helping her now learn to play positive politics, and the results of that work will be featured in the next book.

The need for help never ends.

We all need a safe space where we can get the support to grow our careers and companies.

That's why peer councils are the next big thing in leadership development, and that's why my next book will tell you how to set up and leverage a Career Council (or convert your JSC into a CC) so you can continue to benefit from the wisdom of a curated crowd.

Thanks, Chic!



Chic (aka Helen in high school in the 1950s)

As you may recall, my mother, Chic, is responsible, directly, or indirectly, for much of what I've written here (along with my team and the thousands of CG members over the years).

And here's a random tidbit: My mother loved See's Candies, a U.S.-based chocolatier.

So, if you use this book to get your next job, go to a local See's (or, if you must, some other chocolatier), buy some chocolate, and post a photo toasting

Chic on Instagram with the tag #thanksChic.

#thanksChic!

Love,

Phyl



ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

I asked for help *every* step of the way in writing this book. Yes, I never *write* alone.

I've already said enough about my mom, Chic, but I'll state the obvious: without her, nothing. And I'll say the same about my wonderful sister, Allyson Terry Goldsby.

2023 is the 20th anniversary of CG. I'm deeply grateful to the 2,000+ product managers and general managers who since day one have built this wonderful community and taught me so much.

Their questions and lessons created the possibility for me to develop everything in this book, including Social Search, Job Search Councils, Candidate-Market Fit, negotiating for budget, resources, and support, etc. Some are featured in the book, such as Allison Mnookin, whose name is now part of the two-pager I recommend you create, David Krauter, who taught me about Reverse Exit Interviews, and Joe Megibow, who provided the Megibow Dashboard. Others are anonymous.

I also want to thank the 200+ leaders who agreed to be interviewed for this book. Everyone from the former CEO and Chairman of American Express Ken Chenault to Paula Kerger, CEO of PBS, to humanitarian and writer Kareem Abdul-Jabbar, to Mark Tatum, Deputy Commissioner of the NBA, Randy Garutti, CEO of Shake Shack, and many others. Thank you. You all taught me so much. Your lessons are here and in the next books I'm working on.

Patti Freeman Evans, my close friend and editor, went through many drafts with me — fortunately not all 400 drafts, but close to it! Thank you, Patti. You

are a great wordsmith and friend.

Marty Cagan has been a friend for more than 20 years and, most of the time, he's also believed in me more than I have. But he's done more than that: he's taught me a lot, including about myself. Thank you, Marty, for all you give to me and to so many others in our industry — and for your lovely Foreword to this book.

Of course, I must acknowledge all 200+ early readers/implementers who helped me write this book. With their and Patti's help, I took a wrench to the words and twisted and turned through more than 400 drafts and 2,500 comments.

All 200+ know who you are. Thank you, again!

And special thanks to these early readers who put in a *lot* of extra effort to help: Kerry Cooper, Bruce Upbin, Rob Schmults, Priya Mathew Badger, Agata Celmerowski, Amber Johnson, Elizabeth Kell, Kathy Marryat, Abigail Muraskin, Isabelle Meyer Stapf, Lance Willett, Kimarie Matthews, Bonny Gildin, Brent Tworetzky, Andy Cerio, Allison Mnookin, Joe Megibow, Charlee Riggio, Jeff Prus, and David Rabkin.

I also want to thank the *first* people to read early drafts and start cooking, including forming and moderating JSCs: Robin Gordon, Tommy Doyle, Kristen Johansen, Christian Nimsy, Priya Mathew Badger, Andy Cerio, Aaron Cooper, Lou Weiss, Bruce Upbin, John Seebeck, Tanisa Williams, and many others whose names I cannot include for confidentiality reasons.

The students in the WBRG program (Warren Buffett Reading Group) helped me discover that this book is relevant for high school and college students — a surprising and delightful discovery. Special thanks to all of them, including McKenzie, Luke, Arden, Maslyn, Sona, Mallory, Andrew, and Alexi.

My team at CG has co-created everything with me. Thank you to all of you, especially Marichu Aliser, BJ Arnone, Britany Chism, Maya Pacheco, Charlee Riggio, Stephanie Saladen, Jennai Tibayan, and all the CG moderators.

My close friends Pat Wictor and Roger Grunwald helped me as I wrote, re-wrote, and agonized over this book (Pat also was there for the formation of my first council in college and, thankfully, has walked with me every step of the way since).

Much of what I do in life is due to the support and love of my life partner and best friend, Lisa Dombrow. She has challenged, inspired, and made me a

better person for decades.

A longtime CG member, and one of my closest friends in business, Sam Taylor, who ran one of Warren Buffett's companies, tragically passed away while I was writing this book. Sam — what you taught me weaves through this book and through my life. I still feel your presence and hear your voice everyday. Thank you for what you gave me and the world.

My friends and forum members in my YPO Manhattan chapter in New York have helped inspire and support me for years.

For two decades, the members of my own CG Council have given me the hope, courage, accountability, and motivation to keep going in every aspect of my life, including writing this book. Gregg taught me to focus on what counts and matters to me. As a bestselling author, Ramit gave me all kinds of practical advice. JP and I have helped and challenged each other since we met nearly 30 years ago. Sumeet has let me borrow his brain from time to time to think through tough problems (and has been a good friend for many years), while Jeff has inspired me with how he applies his engineering mentality to business design.

My therapist, Bill, has done tremendous work, helping me grow during the writing of this book, including deepening my understanding of asking for help and the social dynamics of growth, as well as helping me embrace my gender fluidity. My talented and now-retired former group therapist, Christine, had a big impact on me, including teaching me more about the dynamics of asking for help, and the power of small-group environments. My coach, David, has answered my requests for help, often several times a day, and has helped me never walk alone for decades.

I also want to acknowledge the team at the Hospital for Special Surgery (HSS) who helped me recuperate from an accident during the middle of writing this book. Dr. Teena Shetty, CEO Lou Shapiro, and many others deserve my thanks. I could never have healed alone. If you like this book, then thank them, too, because I wouldn't have finished it without their amazing care. And if you are ever in New York and need a great orthopedic hospital, then you're lucky because HSS is the best in the country. You can tell them I sent you.



THIS BOOK IN TWO PAGES

In this book, I redesign the job search and present a radical new approach that will help bring you more joy, money, and the possibility for greater impact.

I call this new approach Social Search, and it has the following five steps, which are outlined in detail in the book.

	Step 1 Job Search Council	Step 2 Listening Tour	Step 3 Candidate- Market Fit	Step 4 Networking/ Interviewing	Step 5 Negotiate
Chapters	2-3	4-8	9-10	11-12	13-15

Of all the tools, advice, and approaches that I recommend throughout this book, below are the few ideas that carry *most* of the work.

Form a Job Search Council (Chapters 1 - 3)

This is the first and most important step in the modern job search that I call Social Search. This JSC will provide many surprising benefits, perhaps most importantly converting your fear, envy, insecurity, and dejection into hope, confidence, and motivation. The connection and community you'll build with your JSC will provide the foundation for you to do everything better in your job search and career.

Conduct a Listening Tour *Before* You Begin Networking and Interviewing (Chapters 4 - 8)

This may be the most difficult step of Social Search. Everyone wants to start networking and interviewing right away, and many career counselors recommend that approach. I decidedly do not. I want you to embrace this ‘liminal’ or transitional phase and be open-minded, creative, and curious. Get out there and understand how the market sees you, what the opportunities are, and what you want (i.e., your Listening Tour will not only help you understand the market, but it will be a journey of self-discovery).

Form your Candidate-Market Fit (Chapters 9 - 10).

Once you have completed your self-discovery and market research, then I recommend you create a concise Candidate-Market Fit. Or, in other words, I ask that you put yourself in a clear, marketable box. Don’t make the mistake of being “open” to a wide range of offers. Narrow your focus. Once you do, *then* you can transition to where others start their job searches: with networking and interviewing.

Create a Job Mission with OKRs when interviewing and negotiating (Chapters 12 - 14)

Once you start to get serious with a potential employer (but before you finish interviewing), create a Job Mission with OKRs. This move will impress your potential employer, help create alignment about the role, and set you up to negotiate the money *and* the resources and support you’ll need to succeed.

Negotiate for Budget, Resources, and Support (Chapter 14)

Many people do not negotiate salary, but almost none negotiate the budget, resources, and support they’ll need to succeed. This may be the single most important tactical tip in the whole book. I say that because, if you set yourself up for success, then, you can improve the odds of doing well in the new role, thereby creating the possibility for gratification and joy, not to mention promotions, raises, and new offers down the road.



SOURCES AND CITATIONS

Most of the real names of the job seekers profiled in this book have been changed into pseudonyms, though a few allowed me to use their actual names and company names.

Here's how you tell the difference between a pseudonym and a real name:

- First name only = pseudonym
If only a first name is provided, then that name is a pseudonym, but based on a real person and their real story.
- First name *and* last name = real name
If both a first and last name are provided, then that is a real name. Note that, after I introduce someone with their real first and last name, then subsequent references will, with some exceptions, use only their last name.

For any quotes or data that came from research reports, articles, or published interviews in the media, I provide endnotes.

If, however, there is *no* endnote for the quote, then that means it came from an interview I conducted with that person. All interviews were conducted between 2016 and 2021.



GLOSSARY

CG	CG (“Collaborative Gain Councils”) is the program my team and I started in 2003 for product management and customer experience leaders at Amazon, Google, and other Internet companies. More than 2,000 leaders have now gone through the program. I reference many CG members throughout this book because it was via helping them (and their college-aged children) look for new jobs that Social Search was born.
Social Search	The tested five-step process that helps job seekers never search alone.
Job Search Council (JSC)	Forming a Job Search Council is Step 1 of Social Search and is one of the most important recommendations in the book. A mutual support group of 6–8 peer job seekers, your JSC will walk with you through each phase of the job search.
Listening Tour	This is the second step of Social Search and is designed to help you understand how the market sees you, what the opportunities are, and what you want (i.e., your Listening Tour will not only help you understand the market, but it will help you understand you).
Candidate-Market Fit	Borrowed from the product management world (the original phrase is “product-market fit”), I’ve applied this concept to the job search. Your Candidate-Market Fit reflects the intersection of what you want, your skills, and what the market needs at the moment you are looking.
Reverse Exit Interviews	This is one part of your Listening Tour and is designed to help you get insights from former colleagues.
Golden Question	This is another part of your Listening Tour and is a redesign of the “informational interview” — and, as such, it makes possible a more creative and far-reaching conversation.
Inversion Exercises	Throughout the book, I recommend inversion as a thinking tool that helps illuminate insights by turning things upside down.

RFH	Request for help — this is a part of the regular agenda of your JSC.
Emotional Balance Sheet	Every one of us has an emotional balance sheet made up of assets (hope, confidence, motivation, etc.) and liabilities (envy, fear, insecurity, dejection, etc.).
Job Mission with OKRs	Job Mission is a reimagined job description that is actionable and tied to OKRs (objectives and key results.)
Peer Coaching Call	A format we invented at CG that brings together peers with specific expertise to help you navigate a challenge or situation. I recommend readers set up First 90 Days Peer Coaching Calls after they get their offers but before they start their jobs (or just after they start).

Job Search Council and Peer Coaching Call are trademarks of Collaborative Gain and Phyl Terry. All rights reserved.



ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Phyl Terry has devoted the past 25 years to helping top talent land their dream jobs at companies they love.

Phyl is the founder and CEO of Collaborative Gain, a community of senior-level leaders who are passionate about helping one another build great products, companies, and careers.



An in-demand advisor, coach, and speaker, Phyl started their career in the early Internet – on the startup team of the first company Amazon bought. Phyl was also the longtime CEO of Creative Good, the pioneering customer experience firm that worked with Apple, Facebook, Microsoft, and many others.

Phyl sits on for-profit and nonprofit boards, and has launched several global programs including Slow Art Day, Reading Odyssey, and the Warren Buffett Reading Group, which introduces high school and college students to business, finance, leadership and ethics.

A graduate of the Harvard Business School, Phyl's previous writing includes the book *Customers Included*, a chapter in the book *The Warren Buffett Shareholder*, and the *Harvard Business Review* article, "Who Can Help the CEO?"

Phyl lives in Brooklyn, identifies as non-binary, and welcomes any and all pronouns.



LEARNING MORE

Here are Phyl's projects and how to learn more.

- ***Never Search Alone*** (PhylTerry.com)
Find all the additional tools and templates cited throughout these pages.
- **CGCouncils** (CollaborativeGain.com)
For director, VP, and C-level product managers, general managers, and others who are interested in peer learning and long-term career acceleration. If that's you, then you may want to set up a conversation with the CG team.
- **Associate Councils** (CollaborativeGain.com)
For early-career women, people of color, and LGBTQ+ in product and UX who want support to grow their careers.
- **WBRG — Warren Buffett Reading Group** (WBRG.org)
If you are a high school or college-aged student (or know one), then you can apply for the *free* summer program started by Phyl and other Harvard MBAs. Note this program, which is an introduction to business, is in pilot mode and may have a long waiting list.
- **Woodstock for Capitalists Insider Experience**
(CollaborativeGain.com/Buffett)

If you want a once-in-a-lifetime experience, then consider joining Phyl for their annual trek to the “Woodstock of Capitalism.”

- **Slow Art Day** (SlowArtDay.com)

Visit SlowArtDay.com to find out more about this global annual art event that is reimagining the visitor experience in museums and helping people learn to slow down, look at, and love art.

- **Reading Odyssey** (ReadingOdyssey.org)

If you are interested in lifelong learning and reading difficult books in community with others, including scholars, then visit our website to learn more.

- **The Mitzvah Project** (TheMitzvah.org)

Founded by Roger Grunwald, the son of an Auschwitz survivor, this project, which Phyl advises, seeks to use theater to help high school and college students learn to challenge the stigma of the “other” and insure that “never again means never again for anyone.”



NOTES

1. **College students in my Warren Buffett Reading Group . . .**: I started a free program for high school and college students where I and other experienced Harvard MBAs teach the basics of business via Warren Buffett's letters to shareholders. You can read more about it at WBRG.org.
2. . . . **research shows that if you ask, you will receive (83% of the time!)**: Stephanie Vozza, "Before you accept that job offer, do this to negotiate salary," *Fast Company*, February 19, 2020.
3. . . . **they "are not afraid to ask for help"**: Eilene Zimmerman, "Inside the Minds of the Ultrawealthy," *The New York Times*, Feb. 19, 2017.
4. **85% of executives . . .**: This statistic is based on the more than 200 interviews that I conducted for this book where I talked to leaders at various levels about their willingness to ask for help and about some of the key turning points in their careers.
5. **Take Olivia**: As I mention in my "Notes on Sources and Citations" — when I use only a first name, then that is a pseudonym for a real person whom I interviewed or worked with. If, on the other hand, I use a first *and* last name, then that is a real name. Either way, the stories are *real*.
6. **Professors Adam Grant and Francesca Gino published a paper . . .**: Adam M. Grant and Francesca Gino, "A Little Thanks Goes a Long Way:

Explaining Why Gratitude Expressions Motivate Prosocial Behavior,” *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, Vol. 98, No. 6, 2010, pp. 946–955.

7. **“new insights . . . have done little to help”**: Emily Bobrow, “Psychiatrist Thomas Insel Looks for a Cure to America’s Mental Health Crisis,” *The Wall Street Journal*, February 11, 2022.
8. **three professors conducted a meta-analysis on all the research . . .**: Chyrell D. Bellamy, Timothy Schmutte, Larry Davidson, “An update on the growing evidence base for peer support,” *Mental Health and Social Inclusion*, Vol. 21, No. 3, June 2017.
9. **These settings, he says, have shaped our “need to belong,”**: Irvin D. Yalom and Molyn Leszcz, *The Theory and Practice of Group Psychotherapy 6th Edition*, Basic Books, 2020, p. 34.
10. **. . . Mario Luis Small published some groundbreaking research . . .**: Mario Luis Small, *Someone to Talk To*, Oxford University Press, 2017. Subsequent references to Small come from this book.
11. **He said weak ties could help . . .**: Mark S. Granovetter, “The Strength of Weak Ties,” *The American Journal of Sociology*, Vol. 78, No. 6., May 1973, pp. 1360–1380. Granovetter’s work has been highly influential and very helpful. He was right that “weak ties” (strangers or acquaintances) can be key to a good job search via information sharing. He, however, missed that these so-called “weak ties” can *become* strong ties.
12. **“my intuitive thinking is just as prone to overconfidence . . .**: Daniel Kahneman, *Thinking Fast and Slow*, Farrar, Straus, and Giroux, 2011, p. 417. Subsequent references to Kahneman come from this book.
13. **“[I]f a smart person goes into a room,”** Katharine Graham, *Personal History*, Alfred A. Knopf, 1997, p. 537. Subsequent references to Graham and the Orangutan Room concept come from this book.

14. . . . **share a willingness to learn and ask for help from others . . .**: Annie Duke, *Thinking in Bets*, Portfolio/Penguin, 2018. Duke talks about mutual support groups in Chapter 4.
15. . . . **more than 150,000 CEO members . . .**: This estimate came from a conversation with Mo Fathelbab, who was Executive Director of Young Entrepreneurs Organization and has gone on to run several peer leadership organizations. Further, as of 2021, YPO and Vistage alone have more than 60,000 CEO members, and there are several hundred other peer organizations catering to CEOs.
16. . . . **kind of private council with the aim of providing “mutual support”**: Alice Schroeder, *The Snowball: Warren Buffett and the Business of Life*, Random House, 2008, p. 405.
17. **When Karen Wickre, now author and Google veteran . . .**: Author interview with Karen Wickre, January 3, 2019. I’ve noted this interview because Wickre is also an author, and I want to clarify that this came from our discussion rather than from one of her books.
18. Much of this brief biographical sketch of Jacobi’s life is taken from several pages of this book: Ioan Mackenzie James, *Remarkable Mathematicians: from Euler to von Neumann*, Cambridge University Press, 2009, pp. 97–103.
19. You’ll note that this is the second important exercise that I learned directly from a CG member. Remember, I wrote this book based on decades of working with thousands of CG members, and they taught me a lot, including this exercise. In aggregate, I believe I’ve learned more from them than they have learned from me.
20. **“I am not sure I would have gone further . . .**: Beth Comstock quoted by Joanna Lublin, “Know Enough Not to Act Like a Know-It-All,” *The Wall Street Journal*, January 9, 2019. The rest of the quotes come from my interview with Comstock, conducted during the writing of this book.

21. . . . as more job seekers leave their jobs . . . : Jon Hilsenrath and Sarah Chaney Cambon, “Job Openings Are at Record Highs. Why Aren’t Unemployed Americans Filling Them?” *The Wall Street Journal*, July 9, 2021.
22. . . . 87% according to one source — re found through networking . . . : 2019 Job Seeker Nation Survey, page 16. Report accessed online on 6–1–21 via [Jobvite.com](https://www.jobvite.com).
23. This is the “hidden job market”: Alison Doyle, “What Is the Hidden Job Market?” *The Balance Careers*, January 20, 2020. Accessed online on 6–1–21 via thebalancecareers.com.
24. Her book, which began with a blog post that went viral . . . : Karen Wickre, “I’ve Spent a Lifetime Building a Mighty Network. Here are My Secrets,” *Wired*, August 26, 2016.
25. Chris Fralic, a venture capitalist at First Round Capital . . . : Chris Fralic, “The Art of the Email Introduction: 10 Rules For Emailing Busy People,” *Forbes*, March 27, 2013.
26. . . . big photo of the CEO . . . : Arijit Chatterjee and Donald C. Hambrick, “It’s All about Me: Narcissistic Chief Executive Officers and Their Effects on Company Strategy and Performance,” *Administrative Science Quarterly* 52, 2007, pp. 351–386.
27. . . . women doctors still make less than their equally qualified male counterparts: Suzanne Koven, *Letter to a Young Female Physician: Notes from a Medical Life*, W. W. Norton & Company, May 4, 2021, p. 2. I highly recommend this terrific memoir to anyone, especially to college students thinking of medicine.
28. Two of the best general management books . . . : Jennifer Reingold and Ryan Underwood “Was ‘Built to Last’ Built to Last?” *Fast Company*,

November 1, 2004; Rebecca Borrison, “The Best Business Books of All Time,” *Inc Magazine*, July 6, 2021.

29. **12.3 times between ages 18 and 52 . . .**: Bureau of Labor Statistics Study, “Number of Jobs, Labor Market Experience, and Earnings Growth: Results From a National Longitudinal Survey,” August 22, 2019.
30. **. . . more than one-third “plan to look for a new job in the next few months”**: Angus Loten, “Companies Struggle to Keep Their Tech Workers From Logging Off,” *The Wall Street Journal*, June 28, 2021.



PRAISE FOR *NEVER SEARCH ALONE*

"Helped me find the right job for moving my career forward."

– **Corleen Heidgerken**, Director of Product, Glassdoor

"A secret unlock to the job marketplace."

– **Pedraun Pardehpoo**, Director of Product, Airbnb

"This groundbreaking book is required reading for every job seeker."

– **Amy Edmondson**, Novartis Professor of Leadership and Management, Harvard Business School

"This book helped me land my first full-time job. I'll revisit this throughout my career."

– **Maslyn P.**, University of Virginia Class of 2022

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